



Capital starts two-week mandatory GST training programme for officers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government's Trade and Taxes Department has launched a comprehensive two-week training programme for GST officers and employees, running from June 15 to June 26, with three sessions scheduled each day. The training covered everything from the fundamentals of tax administration to investigation techniques and digital tools, in collaboration with the National Academy of Customs, Indirect Taxes and Narcotics, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta announced on Tuesday.

The Chief Minister said tax administration today extends well beyond revenue collection and has become an integrated system involving technology, law, investigation, analysis, and public service, making regular capacity building essential for officers.

The training programme covers a wide range of subject



areas. Participants will receive instruction on the fundamentals of GST, taxation and tax collection, supply of goods and services, time and place of supply, valuation, and classification of goods and services. The curriculum also includes Input Tax Credit, registration, tax invoices, credit and debit notes, returns, the composition scheme, e-way bills, tax payments, assessment, audit, refunds, works contracts, job work, and input service distributors.

Officers will also receive

practical training on the GST Network covering return filing, registration, amendments, cancellation, restoration, back-office operations, helpdesk functions, and grievance redressal mechanisms.

Officers will be trained in intelligence gathering, investigations, interrogation, recording statements, examination of witnesses, inspection, search operations, arrests, detention of goods and vehicles, seizure, release procedures, disposal of offences, and the use of digital

investigation tools.

Officers will also be familiarised with relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, and the Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam, India's newer criminal law codes. Additional training will cover the preparation of panchnamas, recording of statements, demand and recovery procedures, drafting of show cause notices, appeals, revisions, advance rulings, case disposal, and procedures for handling matters before the High Court and the Supreme Court.

The Chief Minister said the programme offers officers an important opportunity to familiarise themselves with the latest legal provisions, judicial decisions, technological platforms, and departmental best practices, and urged participants to actively engage in training sessions, case studies, discussions, and practical exercises.

MCD records highest-ever annual revenue of ₹14,549.06 crore in 2025-26, up 17.27%

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi recorded its highest-ever annual revenue of ₹14,549.06 crore in 2025-26, a 17.27 per cent increase over the previous financial year, officials said on Tuesday.

The revenue figures were shared by MCD standing committee chairperson Satya Sharma, who said the civic body's total revenue increased from ₹12,406.75 crore in 2024-25 to ₹14,549.06 crore in 2025-26, an increase of ₹2,142.31 crore.

"MCD's own revenue rose from ₹9,400.20 crore to ₹11,239.24 crore during the period, registering a growth of 19.56 per cent, while revenue and grants received from the Delhi Government increased from ₹2,983.87 crore to ₹3,309.82 crore," Sharma said.

The revenue growth



comes even as the civic body continues to carry liabilities of more than ₹15,000 crore, according to a report submitted earlier to Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu.

More than half of the liabilities comprise loans from the Delhi Government, followed by internal loans, employee-

related dues, including retirement benefits, and pending payments to contractors executing infrastructure projects.

According to an official statement, property tax and property transfer charges remained the corporation's largest sources of income, contributing ₹3,116 crore and ₹3,758.59 crore,

respectively, in 2025-26.

Revenue from advertisements stood at ₹441.30 crore, while car parking and leasing of the civic centre's C-Block generated ₹166.18 crore and ₹182.71 crore, respectively, the statement read.

Advertisement revenue increased from ₹359.32 crore in 2024-25 to ₹441.30 crore in 2025-26, while income from leasing the civic centre's C-Block rose from ₹75.23 crore to ₹182.71 crore, the figures showed.

The MCD, however, fell short of its property tax collection target of ₹3,500 crore for 2025-26. The civic body collected around ₹3,116 crore from 13,52,552 taxpayers during the year, compared to ₹2,132.89 crore from 11,33,161 taxpayers in 2024-25.

Officials said a substantial number of properties in the Capital continue to remain outside the property tax net.

LG pushes Khan Market upgrade, reviews rainwater harvesting network

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Sardar Taranjit Singh Sandhu has directed officials to expedite ongoing redevelopment works at Khan Market. He also ordered to complete pending rainwater harvesting projects before the onset of the monsoon, while maintaining strict quality and safety standards.

During a visit to Khan Market, one of the Capital's most prominent commercial destinations, the Lieutenant Governor reviewed the progress of infrastructure improvement works and interacted with shopkeepers, visitors, and officials. NDMC Chairman Keshav Chandra, Vice Chairman Kuljeet Singh Chahal, and senior officers accompanied him during the inspection.

The Lieutenant Governor inspected development works in the market's middle lane and received a detailed briefing on project timelines and implementation status from NDMC officials. He stressed the need to modernise the market and improve civic facilities to strengthen its position as an international destination.

Sandhu said efforts were underway to create a better experience for visitors while upgrading public infrastructure and civic amenities.

He directed concerned departments to speed up the remaining works while ensuring compliance with quality and safety benchmarks, including fire safety measures. He also called for the adoption of global best practices in urban infrastructure development.

The Lieutenant Governor said Delhi's transformation



Delhi LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu reviews the implementation of the Modular Rain Water Harvesting System and receives a briefing from officials of the New Delhi Municipal Council on the project's design, operational efficiency and sustainability features in New Delhi

into a modern and sustainable urban centre requires the upgradation of iconic public spaces and commercial districts.

He added that creating a seamless experience for visi-

tors, tourists, and local businesses remains a priority. Apart from reviewing the Khan Market redevelopment project, Sandhu also inspected the implementation of a Modular Rain Water Harvesting System

at Satya Marg under NDMC's jurisdiction.

NDMC Chairman Keshav Chandra informed the Lieutenant Governor that 290 out of 340 existing and planned rainwater harvesting structures under NDMC have already been cleaned and made operational. According to NDMC, work on the remaining 50 structures is progressing on a fast-track basis and is expected to be completed by the end of June. These include 28 modular rainwater harvesting systems and 22 conventional structures.

NDMC Vice Chairman Kuljeet Singh Chahal said the civic body is committed to upgrading public infrastructure and strengthening environmental sustainability in line with the broader vision of developing a cleaner, greener, and smarter New Delhi.

Govt to use EMI-based payment model for streetlight upgrade in a first: PWD Minister

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a first, the Delhi Government will implement an EMI-based payment model for a major streetlight modernisation project, PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh said on Tuesday.

The city Government's push to convert around 93,000 streetlights on main roads will cut its electricity consumption and save around ₹300 crore in five years.

"For the first time, we will be giving a project, which will have the EMI model of payments, monthly, based on the performance report of the streetlights. This is being done specifically to ensure proper functioning and management of new smart streetlights," Singh said.

The project, estimated to cost around ₹473.24 crore,



will be implemented in phases on roads maintained by the PWD.

"Under the project, all HPSV lights and older LED fixtures will be replaced with smart LEDs. Provision has also been made for installing 5,000 additional poles to cover future requirements and currently-unlit stretches," Singh said.

A control-and-command centre will be set up to monitor the status of all the streetlights in real time. The project also envisages dim-

mable and individually-controlled streetlights, so that real-time adaptation and control in accordance with weather conditions could be achieved, Singh added.

According to the project details, the command centre will be set up at the MSO building, the PWD headquarters, with two 75-inch-display computers and related software. The contractor will have to ensure proper functioning of lights to get payment.

The tender for the project has been issued and the work will be awarded to the contractor within a fortnight.

The finance department's observations on the project show that over five years, the reduction in power expenditure is expected to be significant compared to the current arrangement.

Public Notice

Notice is hereby given that one Ms. Devesh Kumar Sharma & Ms. Chanchal Sharma (hereafter referred to as the said Mortgagees) have agreed to create mortgage in respect of the property more particularly described in the Schedule hereunder written in favour of my client PNB Housing Finance Ltd., Branch-Noida. The Owner/Borrower/Ms. Chanchal Sharma D/o Mr. Yogesh Sharma (W/o Mr. Devesh Kumar Sharma) has lost/misplaced the following Original documents i.e.: 1. Original General Power of Attorney executed/registered on 10.01.1989 vide its Doc. No. 681 by Mr. Manohar Lal in favour of Ms. Rama Sharma; 2. Original Lease Deed executed/registered on 11.06.1990 vide its Doc. No. 1563 by New Okhla Industrial Development Authority in favour of Mr. Manohar Lal & 3. Original General Power of Attorney executed/registered on 15.09.1994 vide its Document No. 2259 by Ms. Rama Sharma in favour of Ms. Neeru Vaid alongwith ATS & Will in favour of Ms. Mamta Sharma W/o Mr. Yogesh Kumar Sharma all documents are the Leasehold Residential House No. 178 admeasuring area 29 sq. mtr. in Block-C situated at Sector-20 in Noida Distt. Gautam Budh Nagar (U.P.). If any person having any claim against or in respect of the said property more particularly described in the Schedule hereunder or any part thereof by way of sale, exchange, mortgage (equitable or legal), lease, gift or otherwise, gift, trust, inheritance, family arrangement, maintenance, bequest, partnership, possession, lease, sub-lease, tenancy, license, lien, charge, pledge, easement or otherwise howsoever are hereby requested to notify the same in writing to me with supporting documentary evidence at the address mentioned herein below within 7 days from the date hereof, failing which the claim, if any, of such person will be considered to have been waived and / or abandoned any my client shall proceed with the disbursement of loan and creation of mortgage on the scheduled property.

The Schedule showing the description of the property : Leasehold Residential House No. 178 admeasuring area 29 sq. mtr. in Block-C situated at Sector-20 in Noida Distt. Gautam Budh Nagar (U.P.).

Date: 13.06.2026 Place: Ghaziabad Divesh Singhal (pnhl Panel Advocate)

Office No. SC-319 on Ground Floor "Near Double Water Tank" Situated at Block-C Shastri Nagar, Ghaziabad (U.P.)-201002 /Also/ at Chamber No. 76-A, Tehsil Court Compound, Ghaziabad, (M): 9811834005

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Rakesh Kumar Sindhi, S/o Sh. Chela Ram Sindhi, resident of A-244, Double Story, Kalkaji, New Delhi-110019, do hereby inform the general public that I have severed all ties with my son, Devesh Kumar and his wife, Deesha, as they have been conducting themselves in a manner completely contrary to my expectations, causing me severe mental distress and harassment. Due to their disrespectful behavior and irreconcilable differences, I have severed all my relations with them. Deesha is continuously threatening me to falsely implicate in false cases if I do not act as per her demands. Hence, I have debarred them from all my movable and immovable assets. Any person dealing with them shall do so at their own risk and responsibility.

Date: June 15, 2026
Place: New Delhi

Yogesh Kumar Advocate

PUBLIC NOTICE

Mr. Naveen Dantlax has approached ICICI (Bank Ltd.), Punjabi Bagh, New Delhi. (Bank) to avail a loan for purchase of Entire Ground Floor of Property No. 277, (85.9 sq. yds), Old Rajinder Nagar, New Delhi-110060 from Ms. Sangeeta Wadhwa who has represented that she is the absolute owner of the said property by virtue of Sale Deed dated 09.09.2005 (Doc. No. 7592) & Relinquishment Deed dated 07.05.2026 (Doc. No. 2026/24/4509). If anybody, person, body corporate has any right, lien or claim whatsoever on the said Property by way of inheritance, mortgage, sale or otherwise, then he/she/it may contact the undersigned with documentary proof of claim within 15 days of publication of this notice, otherwise it shall be deemed that either there are no claims or the same have been waived off. No claim or objection shall be entertained thereafter and Bank shall proceed to advance the loan on mortgaging of the said property.

Amit Kumar, Advocate

Narang & Associates
D-28, Jangpura Extension,
New Delhi-110014.

E-AUCTION NOTICE

FIRE AFFECTED TIN SHED SCRAP/ IRON SCRAP, BOPP ROLL / POLY ROLLS, WET FG LAMINATE MATERIAL, WET METALIZE PET, PRINT PET

Interested Buyers are invited to participate in the e-Auction for the disposal of "Fire Affected Approx. 4,800 Tin Shed Scrap/Iron Scrap, Approx. 4,055 Kg BOPP Roll/Poly Rolls and Approx. 12,061 Kg of Wet FG Laminate Material, Wet Metalize PET, Print PET" on "Per Kg" Basis. The subject salvage will be sold on "As is Where is", Whatever there is" and "No Complaint" Basis and belongs to **M/s. Bala Plastic Industries**. The subject materials (Tin Shed Scrap/Iron Scrap) can be inspected at **M/s. Green Recycler Private Limited**, Kila No. 30/18/2/3, 23.34/3/3, Basantpur, Tehsil Rai, Sonapat, Haryana - 131028 & (Bopp Roll/Poly Rolls & Other material) lying at O-20, 21, DSIDD, Industrial Area, Sector - 5, Bawana, Delhi-110039 between 17-06-26 to 25-06-26 between 10 AM to 5 PM only. Kindly contact Mr. Ashok Chauhan at 8920396443 for inspection.

E-AUCTION WILL BE HELD ON 26-06-2026

Kindly contact Mr. Nitin Kumar at 7011830975 to obtain the form containing terms & conditions of e-Auction or download from website <https://www.sealthedeal.co.in/>.

Auctioneers: Seal The Deal having registered office at 5th Floor, Office No. 2, Kings Mall, Rohini Sector 10, Delhi-110085.

LAST DATE OF SUBMISSION OF FORMS & EMD DEMAND DRAFT IS 25-06-2026

The Pioneer Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Chandra Samant W/o- No. 4198864L Hav Pradeep Singh, R/o- Tiwari Nagar, Bindukhatta, PO- Lalakuan, Distt- Nanital, Pin- 262402, have changed my name from Chandra Samant to Chandra Devi, vide affidavit dated 16/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1390)C I, Kumari Rajwati W/o No. 2889040F Ex-Hav Satyapal Singh, R/o- VPO- Salhawas, Teh- Salhawas, Dist- Jhajjar, Haryana- 124146, have changed my name from Kumari Rajwati to Rajwanti, vide affidavit dated 16/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1391)C I, Kunimoni Sahoo Mother of No.14834685N Sep/MT Manoj Kumar Sahoo, R/o- Vill & PO- Hadapada, Dist- Khordha, Odisha- 752018, have changed my name from Kunimoni Sahoo to Kuni Dei, vide affidavit dated 16/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1392)C

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER, PWD JALUKBARI TERRITORIAL ROAD DIVISION, FANCY BAZAR, GUWAHATI-01

PRESS NOTICE INVITING RE-TENDER

The Executive Engineer PWD, Jalukbari Territorial Road Division, Fancy Bazar,Ghy-01 on behalf of ,e Governor of Assam invites bid for 2 (Two) No of work under SOPD-G for the year 2025-26 amounting to Rs. 89.03 Lakhs including GST etc(Approx) in Jalukbari LAC Kamrup District of Assam from approved and eligible Contractors registered with Assam PWD (Roads) or Contractors registered with other State/Central Government Departments, Institutions, Undertakings Authorities for the following works as stated in the table below.

Details may be seen from 18.06.2026 at website www.assamtenders.gov.in Amendment /Addendum to the SBD, if any, and further notifications shall appear in this website and also at the office of the undersigned during office hours. The contractor/bidder must be registered with the Electronic Tendering System (ETS) of PWRD, Assam website www.assamtenders.gov.in.

Note: - N.I.T Value is inclusive of GST, Labour cess etc.

Sd/- Executive Engineer PWD Jalukbari Territorial Road Division, Fancy Bazar,Ghy-01

DIPR/CF/PIO/463/17-Jun-26

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER, PWD (ROADS), BHAWANIPUR-SORBHOG AND PAKABETBARI TERRITORIAL ROAD DIVISION, BARPETA ROAD

No BSPTRD/TECH/PDNA/168/2025-26/19

PRESS NOTICE INVITING RE-TENDER

The Executive Engineer,PWD(Roads),Bhawanipur-Sorbhog & Pakabetbari Territorial Road Division,Barpeta Road, on behalf of Governor of Assam, invites bids from eligible contractors registered with Assam PWD(Roads) for 1 (One)no. of Works amounting to Rs.24.72 Lakh (approx.) for Re-Construction & Recovery Window (Assam Flood and Landslides 2022)NDRF(PDNA-2022) for the year 2025-26 in Barpeta District, Assam.

Details along with schemes for the works may be seen from 17-06-2026 at website www.assamtenders.gov.in and also at the office of the undersigned during office hours. Amendment /Addendum to the SBD, if any, and further notifications shall appear in this website and also at the office of the undersigned during office hours. The contractor/bidder must be registered with the Electronic Tendering System (ETS) of PWRD, Assam website www.assamtenders.gov.in.

Schemes are not yet sanctioned by the competent authority. In the event of non-sanctioned of the schemes, the bid may be cancelled and no claim what so ever on this account shall be entertained from the bidders.

Note: - N.I.T Value is inclusive of GST (18%), Labour cess (1%) etc.

Sd/- Executive Engineer,PWD, Bhawanipur-Sorbhog and Pakabetbari Territorial Road Division, Barpeta Road.

DIPR/C/PIO/99-17-Jun-26

SOUTH EASTERN COALFIELDS LIMITED

"A MINI RATNA COMPANY"

SECL/BSP/GMEE/2026/1405

Date: 04.06.2026

Notification for engagement of Full time Advisor (FMC,PMC&Siding), in SECL on fixed tenure basis.

South Eastern Coalfields Limited (Subsidiary of Coal India Limited) invites application for engagement of one **Advisor (FMC, PMC & Siding)**, in SECL from retired executives of CIL & its subsidiaries,PSUs/autonomous organizations of Central/State governments Officers of class-C and above of Central & state Govt. (Non-clerical) & members of National level professional institutions on fixed tenure basis for an initial period of two year which may be extended further, as per CIL policy for engagement of Advisor's depending upon the requirement and satisfactory performance.

The Application Form and detailed notification can be seen and downloaded from SECL website www.secl-cil.in under the caption Career. Interested candidates fulfilling the criteria may submit their application in prescribed format with supporting documents to the "Office of GM(HR), Executive Establishment Department, South Eastern Coalfields Limited, Seepat Road, Bilsapur, Chhatisgarh, Pin 495006, latest by 18.06.2026, by 5.00 pm by Registered Post/Speed/ e-mail in mail id - gmhr.ee.secl@coalindia.in. Applications received after 18.06.2026 by 5.00 PM will not be considered and the company will not be responsible for any postal delay/loss in transit in submission of application within specified time.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Known to all that my client Sh. Vijender Singh owner Third Floor, With Roof, Plot No. 15, Area 99 Sq. Yds. Kharsa No. 34/12 & 40/1/2, Dalip Vihar, Nilothi Extn, New Delhi-110041, and My Client Purchased aforesaid property from Smt. Sarita Sethi vide notarized GPA, ATS and Will dated 11.06.2024 now My Client wants to sell aforesaid property. And it is informed that any deal with said documents by any person except my said client and said institution regarding said property, shall be deemed as null and void. If any person having any claim, right in said property then he may contact and handover the same and apprise his claim to undersigned within 15 days of this publication.

AD REM LEGAL SOLUTION

Ch. No. 760 - Dwarka Court Sector-10, Dwarka, New Delhi-75
Mobile :- 9899013918

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM

OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER, PWD KAMRUP ROAD CIRCLE, FANCY BAZAR, GUWAHATI-01

No.GRC/NIT/510/2021 -22/Pt./I

PRESS NOTICE INVITING RE-TENDER

The Superintending Engineer PWD (Roads), Kamrup Road Circle, Guwahati-01 on behalf of Governor of Assam invites re-bids online from approved and eligible registered contractors of APWRD for "Repair/ Rehabilitation of BUG Br. No. 1/1 including approach and protection works on Garchuk- Pamohi Road at Ch. 235.00 m under Jalukbari TRD under SOPD- G for the Year 2025-26" under Jalukbari Territorial Road Division for 1(one) no. of work, amounting to Rs. 149.86 Lakh (Approx) (including 12% GST +1% LWC). Details may be seen in the website <http://assamtenders.gov.in> and also at the office of the undersigned from 19/06/26 to 25/06/26 during office hours.

Sd/- Superintending Engineer PWD (Roads), Kamrup Road Circle, Guwahati-01

DIPR/CF/PIO/460/17-Jun-26

SBI STATE BANK OF INDIA,

CRAMC New Delhi (65299), NBCC Building, 2nd Floor, Bhishma Pitamah Marg, Lodhi Road, New Delhi-110003.

(RULE - 8(1) POSSESSION NOTICE (For Immovable Property)

Whereas, the undersigned being the Authorized Officer of the State Bank of India, CRAMC, New Delhi under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets & Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (54 of 2002) and in exercise of powers conferred under section 13(12) read with rule 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002, issued a Demand Notice Dated 26.03.2026 calling upon the **Borrower:- MR. GANESH RAY S/O MR. DAROGA RAY, R/o Flat No.4-C, 2nd Floor, Pocket-B, Radhe Krishna Apartment, DDA LIG, Sec-3 Dwarka, Behind DPS School, New Delhi-110078** plinth area of 29 Sq.Mtrs., to repay the amount mentioned in the notice being **Rs.20,17,562/- (Rupees Twenty Lakhs Seventeen Thousand Five Hundred Sixty Two Only) + (further interest, cost, charges and other expenses etc. thereon)** from 26.03.2026 within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The borrower having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the Borrower/Guarantor and the public in general that the undersigned has taken **Possession** of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him/her under section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 on this **11th Day of June 2026**. The Borrower/Guarantor in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealing with the property will be subject to the charge of **State Bank of India, CRAMC, New Delhi** for an amount of **Rs.20,54,466/- (Rupees Twenty Lakh Fifty Four Thousand Four Hundred Sixty Six Only) + (further interest, cost, charges and other expenses etc. thereon)**. The Current outstanding as on 11.06.2026 is **Rs.20,54,466/- (Rupees Twenty Lakh Fifty Four Thousand Four Hundred Sixty Six Only) + (further interest, cost, charges and other expenses etc. thereon)**. **The borrower's attention is invited to provisions of Sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available to redeem the secured assets.**

DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY

All that part and parcel of the property bearing Flat No. 4-C, 2nd Floor, Pocket-B, Radhe Krishna Apartment, DDA LIG, Sector-3, Dwarka, Behind DPS School, New Delhi-110078. Plinth Area of 29 Sq.Mtrs.

Place: NEW DELHI
Date: 11/06/2026

Sd/- Authorised Officer, State Bank of India, CRAMC, New Delhi

AXIS BANK

Axis Bank Ltd., Axis House, Tower T-2, 2nd Floor, I-14, Sector-128, Noida Expressway, Jaypee Greens Wishnoida, Noida (U.P.)-201301.
Registered Office: "Trishul" 3rd Floor Opp. Samartheshwar Temple, Near Law Garden, Ellisbridge, Ahmedabad - 380006

Appendix IV [Refer Rule - 8(1)] Possession Notice (For Immovable Property)

Whereas The undersigned being the Authorized Officer of Axis Bank Ltd. under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13 (12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued demand notice dated 11-Mar-2026 calling upon **Ms. Manjeet Rani & Mr. Gurnam Chanda (Borrower/Co-borrower, Mortgagee/Guarantor)** to repay the amount mentioned in the notice being of **Rs. 1,14,93,345/-(Rupees One Crore Fourteen Lakh Ninety Three Thousand Three Hundred Forty Five Only) due as on 11-Mar-2026** and interest and cost thereon within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The Borrower(s)/Co-Borrower(s)/Mortgagee(s)/Guarantor(s) above said having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the Borrower(s)/Co-Borrower(s)/Mortgagee(s)/Guarantor(s) and the Public in General that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him/her under Section 13 (4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 on **15-06-2026**. The Borrower(s)/Co-Borrower (s)/ Mortgagee(s)/Guarantor(s) above said in particular and the Public in General is hereby cautioned not to deal with the properties and any dealings with the properties will be subject to the charge of the **Axis Bank Ltd.** for an amount of **Rs. 1,14,93,345/-(Rupees One Crore Fourteen Lakh Ninety Three Thousand Three Hundred Forty Five Only) as on 11-Mar-2026** together with further interest thereon at the contractual rate of interest till the date of payment & expenses thereon. The Borrower(s)/Co-Borrower(s)/Mortgagee(s)/Guarantor(s)'s attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets.

Description of immovable property All that part and parcel of Property bearing:

Entire First Floor, Without Roof Rights Built On Plot No. 3086, Known As Ansal Versalla Situated In Sector-67 And Sector-67A, Village Badshahpur, Sub-teshil Badshahpur, Urban Complex, Gurgaon, Haryana And Bounded As Under- As Per Site Plan, West - As Per Site Plan, North - As Per Site Plan, South - As Per Site Plan

Please note that as mention in sub Section 13 of Section 13 of the aforesaid act, you shall not transfer by way of sale, lease or otherwise any of the assets stated under security referred to in this notice without prior written consent of our bank.

Date: 17-06-2026, Place: Gurgaon
Authorized Officer, Axis Bank Ltd.

PD(1392)C

Moneylenders to ISI operatives: 7 men in Pakistan’s proxy network

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

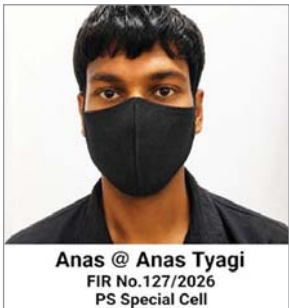
Before they were arms and drug traffickers working for a Pakistan-based handler, several of the seven men arrested in Delhi Police’s latest crackdown were small-time moneylenders in Ghaziabad’s Loni area.

They lend money at exorbitant daily interest rates and carry illegal pistols to intimidate borrowers who fall behind on payments. It was this existing taste for illegal firearms, and the hours spent browsing social media, that brought them into contact with an Instagram account run by a man named Ajmal Gujar, and from there, into a network controlled from across the border.

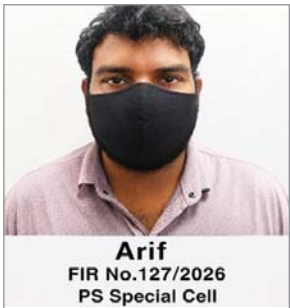
According to investigators, accused Mohit, Arif, absconding accused Aamir, and Anas were engaged in the informal moneylending business in Loni, Ghaziabad, before their recruitment. Their search for sophisticated weapons to



Jatan
FIR No.127/2026
PS Special Cell



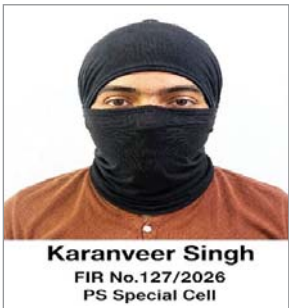
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PS Special Cell



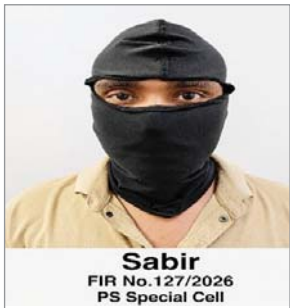
Arif
FIR No.127/2026
PS Special Cell



Deepak
FIR No.127/2026
PS Special Cell



Karanveer Singh
FIR No.127/2026
PS Special Cell



Sabir
FIR No.127/2026
PS Special Cell



Mohit
FIR No.127/2026
PS Special Cell

maintain dominance over borrowers led them to Gujar’s social media presence, and gradually to direct contact with Shahzad Bhatti himself, a Pakistan-based gangster-turned-terrorist whom Indian security agencies have linked to ISI-sponsored proxy operations over the past year.

Anas, full name Anas Tyagi (26), a resident of Ashok Vihar in Loni, has three previous criminal cases against him and was found to be in direct contact with Gujar and Bhatti several hundred times since November 2025. Mohit, alias Yogi, also 26 and from

Sarasvati Vihar in Loni, had been in contact with Gujar several thousand times over the same period, the most intensive communication trail among the seven accused. It was Mohit’s arrest near the Bhagirath Water Treatment Plant in Yamuna Vihar that unravelled the wider network.

Arif, alias Pradhan (30), from Loni, has two previous cases under the Arms Act and the NDPS Act. He was the one who purchased a jigana pistol from Gujar for ₹1 lakh, paying via UPI scanner transactions routed through accounts belonging to people

working in Dubai. Arif was also directed by Bhatti to conduct reconnaissance of a well-known eatery in Haryana, certain individuals residing in Delhi and Loni, and other sensitive locations across Delhi-NCR.

In February 2026, Arif supplied narcotic substances to an associate named Happy, who was subsequently arrested by Punjab Police, an arrest that, in hindsight, was an early thread investigators could have pulled to unravel the network sooner.

Karanveer Singh (26), from Fatehgarh Sahib in Punjab, has one previous NDPS Act

case and was in direct contact with Gujar. He was deputed alongside Anas to Punjab to facilitate the smuggling of heroin into Delhi and the NCR using a dead-drop delivery system designed to minimise direct contact between handlers and couriers.

The most criminally entrenched of the seven is Deepak Agrola (38), from Tronica City in Ghaziabad district, who has 23 previous cases against him, including murder, dacoity, attempt to murder, and charges under the Gangster Act.

Agrola was already lodged

in Mandoli Jail when Anas introduced him to Gujar.

Operating from inside the jail using a mobile phone that was eventually recovered by jail staff, Agrola coordinated the procurement of illegal weapons through his associate, Jatan (29), from Tronica City, who has two prior attempt-to-murder cases. Agrola’s case illustrates a recurring vulnerability in India’s prison system, where inmates with established criminal networks continue to direct operations from behind bars using smuggled phones.

The seventh accused, Sabir

(30), from Loni, completes the group, which collectively spans Uttar Pradesh and Punjab and reflects the geographically dispersed, socially ordinary profile that investigators say Bhatti’s recruitment model deliberately seeks out.

What distinguishes this case from a conventional organised crime bust is the directive nature of the instructions these men received. They were not simply criminals expanding into new territory on their own initiative. They were told what to photograph, where to look, and what

information to send back to handlers physically located outside India, all while being paid through proceeds generated from the very narcotics and weapons sales the network was running.

Bhatti’s recruitment method has been described by investigators as targeting tech-savvy Indian youths with no criminal record, often teenagers or those in their early twenties, offered money and a sense of importance for following instructions, recording themselves with weapons, and gathering intelligence on potential targets.

Four new greenfield cities planned for NCR with high-speed transport under 2041 plan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The National Capital Region Planning Board (NCRPB) on Tuesday decided to develop four new greenfield cities with a high-speed transport network under the ‘Regional Plan 2041’ for the NCR to promote balanced growth across the region.

The NCRPB also declined to accept the Haryana’s proposal to exclude five peripheral districts — Karnal, Jind, Panipat, Mahendragarh and Bhiwani — from the NCR.

The NCRPB meeting was chaired by the Union Housing and Urban Affairs Minister Manohar Lal on Tuesday. Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini and urban development ministers of Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh attended the meeting.

“In the meeting, it was decided that four greenfield cities will be developed. These cities will be called ‘Namo Nodes’,” Lal told reporters after the meeting. A city node refers to a designated urban centre that is



connected to other cities through transport networks and provided with infrastructure to support housing, employment, education, healthcare and commercial activities.

₹5,000 crore will be released for these cities. States will submit their proposals and these four cities will be selected through a challenge, he said.

For Delhi, a sub-city would be proposed instead, he noted. The new cities and the sub-city would be located along transport corridors, including the Regional Rapid Transit System (RRTS). He said the “Namo” label was chosen to match the name of the RRTS trains, Namo Bharat. The minister said the

current population of NCR is 7.5 crore and it is expected to rise to 15 crore in the next 15 years. The region will be highly urbanised in the coming decades, with urban populations of about 57 per cent by 2031 and about 67 per cent by 2041.

The 42nd NCRPB meeting also discussed several forward-looking proposals under the Regional Plan-2041 framework. A committee has been constituted to finalise these recommendations and is expected to submit its report by August 15. The board’s 43rd meeting is now proposed for December.

Of Haryana’s 23 districts, 14 currently fall within the NCR. Had the proposed reduction gone through, Karnal,

Panipat, Jind, Mahendragarh and Bhiwani would have been excluded a move that would have had significant implications for infrastructure investment, land-use permissions, and development funding tied to NCR status. Rajasthan had the most to lose from a boundary contraction.

Under the proposed changes, only Bhiwadi would have remained within the NCR from the state. Rajasthan was openly opposed to the reduction, and its pushback is believed to have been a factor in Tuesday’s outcome.

According to the officials, in keeping with the twin approach of decongesting Delhi and providing for the already burgeoning population, four new greenfield townships will be developed, based on productive economic impulses.

They said the NCRPB has also identified nine Counter Magnet Areas (CMAs) spread over six adjacent states — Haryana’s 23 districts, 14 currently fall within the NCR. Had the proposed reduction gone through, Karnal,

CM pushes for joint NCR action on pollution and connectivity at Planning Board meet

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Tuesday called on all NCR states to pursue sustained, coordinated efforts for the region’s balanced development. The Chief Minister is speaking at the 42nd meeting of the National Capital Region Planning Board, chaired by Union Minister for Housing and Urban Affairs Manohar Lal, where she pressed specifically for a common strategy among Delhi, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh, and Rajasthan to address pollution and expand green cover.

The meeting was attended by Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini and senior representatives from Delhi, Uttar Pradesh, and Rajasthan.

The Chief Minister said the pace of regional development can only accelerate through a coordinated approach that allows growth to benefit every part of the NCR. She said all concerned states must work jointly to provide adequate, quality public services, ensuring bal-



Union Minister Manohar Lal Khatter being greeted by Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini, in the presence of Delhi CM Rekha Gupta, during the 42nd meeting of the National Capital Region Planning Board (NCRPB) at Vigyan Bhawan in New Delhi

anced development and a better quality of life for residents. While noting that the Delhi Government continues to prioritise expansion of public facilities and development works, she said other NCR states must match this effort so that population pressure on Delhi can ease and regional balance can be restored.

Discussions at the meeting covered strengthening institutional coordination among the four states, improving regional transport and connectivity, accelerating development project implementation, and

addressing other NCR-wide issues. The Chief Minister said it was encouraging that transport and connectivity infrastructure across the region continues to expand, making travel more convenient for residents, and stressed that all states must keep working together so that no part of the NCR is left behind on connectivity.

She noted that Delhi, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh, and Rajasthan currently have what she called like-minded Governments that are coordinating more effectively and prioritising public welfare and development.

As a result, she said, implementation of development schemes has gathered pace, with the common priority across all four states being the overall development of the NCR and better facilities for its residents.

On pollution, the Chief Minister described the issue as a serious and shared challenge requiring long-term, concrete efforts from all four states acting together. She said that if the states adopt a common policy, modern technology, and adequate resources for pollution control in a coordinated way, the problem can be tackled more effectively, adding that the issue matters not just for the present generation but for the health and future of generations to come.

On green cover, the Chief Minister reiterated her commitment to expanding plantation efforts across the region, saying large-scale drives and greenery enhancement programmes should continue on a sustained basis to help control pollution and maintain a healthy environment.

DU offers 11,548 PG seats in 1st round across 74 courses

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi University has offered 11,548 seat allocations in the first round of admissions to its two-year postgraduate programmes, with admissions opened across 74 courses under various reservation categories.

The allocations under Round 1 were made live on Monday and cover admissions under the Unreserved, Scheduled Caste and Tribes, Other Backwards Classes-Non Creamy Layer, Economically Weaker Section, Persons with Benchmark Disabilities, Kashmiri Migrant (KM), Single Girl Child (SGC) and Orphan categories.

Candidates allotted seats can accept their allocations till June 17, while the last date for fee payment is June 19, a statement said. The university said allocations for performance-based programmes, including MA Music, Master of Physical Education (MPed), Bachelor of Physical Education (BPed), Master of Fine Arts (MFA), and admissions under the CW and Sports categories, will be carried out along with the third round of admissions.

Applicants to these programmes have been advised to check the websites of the

respective departments for audition and performance schedules, it stated.

Admission to the two-year PG programmes is being conducted through the Common Seat Allocation System (CSAS-PG) based on candidates’ CUET-PG scores, according to the statement.

The admission process for the two-year PG programmes began on May 16 and remained open till June 7. University officials had earlier said candidates would be able to apply only for subjects in which they appeared in the CUET-PG examination and were advised to fill the maximum possible preferences.

Meanwhile, DU is also set to launch admissions for its newly introduced one-year PG programmes under the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 framework. The one-year programmes will be open only to DU students who have completed a four-year bachelor’s degree and meet the prescribed eligibility criteria.

DU Dean of Admissions Haneet Gandhi had earlier said a separate portal would be launched for the one-year PG admissions, marking the first year of implementation of the programme in the university.



Govt clears 4-km flyover on SSN Marg to ease traffic

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has approved construction of a four kilometres long flyover on SSN Marg in Chhatarpur area with an aim to decongest traffic in south Delhi, PWD minister Parvesh Sahib Singh said on Tuesday.

The Public Works Department (PWD) had last year begun the process for a feasibility study to construct a flyover on the road.

“The stretch is heavily congested due to a mix of slow-moving vehicles and cross movements during peak and non-peak hours. There also several farm-houses and religious structures due to which there is heavy footfall. The project has been approved and soon a tender will be floated to hire a company,” Singh said.



Surrounded by busy commercial areas and the constant movement of buses, cars, autos, two-wheelers, and pedestrians, this key South Delhi road stretch has turned into a traffic nightmare even during non-peak hours.

“The PWD plans to construct an integrated transit corridor to decongest the

entire area. The corridor will include the construction of a flyover, slip roads, and an underpass or foot overbridge to facilitate pedestrian movement,” he added.

The heavily congested four-kilometre stretch of Sant Shri Baba Nagpalji (SSN) Marg between the Anuvrat Marg intersection and DLF farms is mostly

used by commuters travelling to Gurugram, Delhi airport, Vasant Kunj and other parts of South Delhi.

Currently, there are three traffic signals along the Anuvrat Marg, approximately 200 metres ahead of the Chhatarpur Mandir intersection.

In June last year, the PWD minister visited the Chhatarpur assembly constituency on the request of area MLA Kartar Singh Tanwar. During the visit, PWD officials were directed to come up with a plan to decongest the areas.

“The road width varies from 27 to 30 metres, due to encroachments on the road and there are several commercial establishments. So there are a few challenges, which will be cleared after the detailed project report is prepared,” an official said.

10 held for supplying mule bank accounts to cyber fraudsters, Kerala victim’s ₹2 lakh traced

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Police’s East District cyber unit busted an organised mule bank account supply racket that allegedly provided bank accounts and financial instruments to cyber fraudsters operating across the country. Police said they arrested 10 people in connection with the case on Tuesday.

The arrests occurred during the investigation of a cyber fraud case in which ₹2 lakh was allegedly siphoned off from a woman in Kerala and routed through a mule bank

account maintained with a private bank.

According to police, the probe revealed a well-organised network engaged in procuring, operating, and supplying bank accounts to cybercriminals for receiving and transferring proceeds of online fraud.

The accused allegedly targeted unemployed and financially vulnerable individuals, luring them with fake job offers and monetary incentives to open bank accounts in their names.

Once the accounts were opened, the gang would obtain control of the account credentials, ATM



cards, cheque books, registered mobile numbers and internet banking facilities. Investigators said these accounts were then supplied to cyber fraudsters across different states to channel illicit funds and

obscure the identity of the actual beneficiaries.

The police conducted extensive financial trail analysis, technical surveillance, mobile phone examination and field verification to unravel the network.



DFS makes safety certificate must for 11 building types, multi-level basements

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Amid multiple fire accidents in the city in recent weeks, Delhi Fire Service (DFS) has asked owners or occupants of various types of buildings, and basements with two or more levels, to mandatorily have a fire safety certificate.

The DFS, in its notice issued on Tuesday, listed 11 categories of buildings that are required to provide fire prevention and fire safety measures as per National Building Construction Standards-2026 (Part-F), the Delhi Fire Service Act, 2007 and Delhi Fire Service Rules, 2010.

These buildings include residential (other than hotels and guest houses) and business buildings, having a height of over 15 metres or comprising five or more stories, including mezzanine or still floor above ground level. Hotels and guest houses, which are over 12 metres tall or have four or more stories, including mezzanine or still floor above ground level.

Education buildings having a height of over 9 metres or comprising three or more stories, including mezzanine or still floor above ground level, are also required to have the certificate.

Fire NOC is also mandatory for institutional and mercantile buildings having a height of beyond 9 metres or comprising three or more stories, including mezzanine or still floor above ground level, and assembly and industrial buildings having a covered area of more than 250 square metres on all stories.

Storage and hazardous buildings having covered areas of more than 250 sq metres and 100 sq meters, respectively, on all their stories are also among the types of buildings that need to have the certificate.

The latest DFS notice also carries a clarification regarding underground structures. Basements with two or more levels will now require a fire safety certificate. A senior officer said that the provision was not specified earlier.

IN FOCUS



People gather at Sagar Vihar, an Arabian Sea water front in Vashi as clouds hover over during sunset, Navi Mumbai (PTI)

Chief Minister Gupta inaugurates citizen lounge, learning centre

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Tuesday inaugurated a "Citizen Lounge-cum-New Age Learning Centre" at the New Delhi District Magistrate's office complex. The facility is designed to give visitors a library, reading corner, modern waiting area, and clean restroom facilities, while also functioning over time as a hub for career counselling, competitive exam guidance, and skill development for young people.

During her visit, the Chief Minister inspected the Citizen Lounge, the library and reading corner, and the newly constructed toilet block.

She described the initiative as an example of good governance, saying citizens visiting administrative offices should have a dignified and comfortable experience, which she called a key priority of the Delhi government.

The Chief Minister said the facility represents more than a waiting lounge or library.



She said children from nearby settlements and economically weaker sections would be able to study there and access facilities not ordinarily available to them.

The centre is planned to evolve into a knowledge and skill development space for students and young people. Books on law, administration, career guidance, and competitive examinations will be made available, along with computers to provide access to digital resources.

For visitors more broadly, the Citizen Lounge offers an air-conditioned waiting room, comfortable seating, newspapers, books, magazines, and a dedicated reading corner.

Over 6.5cr devotees visit Mathura during Purushottam Maas in UP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

Mathura

More than 6.5 crore devotees from across the country and abroad visited Mathura during the month-long Purushottam Maas, offering prayers at Braj temples and completing various religious circumambulations, officials said. According to official figures, the maximum number of pilgrims participated in the Braj Chaurasi Kos Parikrama, with around three crore devotees completing the 126-km-long pilgrimage route covering several holy sites of the Braj region. More than 2.5 crore devotees performed the seven-kosi parikrama of the sacred Govardhan hill, with a large number of local devotees also joining the pilgrimage multiple times.

A significant number of devotees also visited Mathura and Vrindavan for parikrama and temple darshan, while several others travelled to Barsana to seek blessings at the Ladli Ji temple dedicated to Radha Rani. The Purushottam Maas (Adhik Maas) began on May 17 and concluded on June 15.



Officials said such a large gathering within a short span of 30 days put the arrangements made by the district administration and police to the test.

However, barring a few minor incidents, the period passed peacefully, with authorities attributing the successful management of the massive gathering to coordinated efforts by police and administration.

Mathura Superintendent of Police (Rural) Suresh Chand Rawat said more than 6.50 crore devotees visited various religious sites and participated in parikramas in the rural areas of the district alone. He said the figure was significant compared to previous years,

with 9.55 crore devotees visiting Mathura for religious purposes throughout 2025, 8.35 crore in 2024 and 7.90 crore in 2023.

Rawat said around 2.5 crore devotees performed the Govardhan parikrama during the Adhik Maas period, while nearly three crore completed the Braj Chaurasi Kos Parikrama.

He added that Barsana also witnessed a surge of devotees, with around one crore pilgrims participating in the parikrama and visiting the Ladli Ji temple.

To ensure smooth movement and security of the devotees, the Mathura Police deployed additional personnel across pilgrimage routes.

Under the security arrangements, 25 inspectors, 60 sub-inspectors and more than 350 constables were deployed in addition to regular police personnel at crowded locations, the officials said.

Rawat said the police administration was also considering setting up new police outposts and police assistance centres along parikrama routes in view of the increasing number of devotees in the future.

The administration also started preparations for the annual 'Mudiya Poono' fair scheduled around Guru Purnima on July 29, where more than one crore devotees are expected to reach Govardhan within a week to perform the parikrama.

Mathura District Magistrate Chandra Prakash Singh and Senior Superintendent of Police Shlok Kumar personally inspected arrangements by undertaking parikrama routes, while Agra Divisional Commissioner Nagendra Pratap and Range Deputy Inspector General of Police Shailendra Kumar Pandey also reviewed the situation periodically.

Three held for digital arrest cyber fraud; Pakistan links found



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New Delhi

Delhi Police's Rohini Cyber Police Station busted a cyber fraud syndicate allegedly linked to a Pakistan-based handler, arresting three men accused of facilitating a sophisticated "digital arrest" scam that cheated a Delhi resident of over ₹15 lakh, officials said on Tuesday.

Investigators said the alleged mastermind, Mohammad Noor Alam, was in regular contact with a Pakistan-based associate identified as Bilal, to whom the proceeds of cyber fraud were allegedly transferred after being converted into cryptocurrency. Police said the gang operated as a key financial conduit for cyber-criminals by arranging mule bank accounts, routing stolen funds, and converting the money into USDT before sending it overseas.

The arrests followed a complaint lodged on the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal (NCRP) by a victim who alleged that a fake law-enforcement investigation duped him of ₹15.31 lakh.

According to police, the fraud began on January 8 when the complainant received a call from a woman posing as a telecom company employee. She claimed that a mobile number issued using his Aadhaar card was being used for illegal online gaming activities in Bengaluru. The call was then transferred to a man posing as a sub-inspector from the Indira Nagar Police Station in Bengaluru.

The fraudsters told the victim that four bank accounts had allegedly been opened using his Aadhaar

credentials and linked to a money laundering case involving a person named Hitesh Mehta. To make the story appear credible, the victim was connected via video calls to several individuals impersonating senior police officers and government officials.

Police said the fraudsters employed a tactic commonly known as "digital arrest", in which victims are psychologically controlled through continuous monitoring and threats of criminal action. The complainant was allegedly kept under constant video surveillance and warned not to disclose the purported investigation to anyone.

The scammers allegedly coerced him into revealing details of all his financial assets, including bank accounts, fixed deposits, mutual funds and shareholdings. Claiming that the money had to be verified by RBI auditors, they convinced him to liquidate his investments prematurely and transfer the funds to designated accounts. To reinforce the deception, fake RBI receipts were sent to him as proof that the money would be returned after verification.

Between January 9 and January 16, the victim transferred ₹15,31,997 to multiple bank accounts and UPI IDs provided by the fraudsters. He later realised that he had been cheated and approached the authorities.

During the investigation, police traced two beneficiary accounts that received part of the fraud proceeds - a Union Bank account that received ₹1.98 lakh and another account that received ₹98,000.

MCD cracks down on illegal constructions in Kalindi Kunj

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New Delhi

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) on Tuesday carried out a demolition drive in the Kalindi Kunj of southeast Delhi, targeting structures allegedly built illegally in the Yamuna floodplain's O-Zone.

The MCD officials said only under-construction structures built on the floodplain were being demolished and asserted that strict action against illegal constructions across the city would continue. The action was carried out as part of the corporation's ongoing drive against unauthorised constructions in the floodplain area.

Speaking on the ongoing action, MCD Standing



Committee Chairperson Satya Sharma said the civic body was surveying unauthorised constructions and buildings exceeding permissible height limits in view of a series of recent accidents in Delhi.

"Strict action will be taken based on this survey. Anyone who does not hold

a valid licence or has violated MCD rules will face action," Sharma said.

The officials further said that authorities launched the demolition drive in the Kalindi Kunj area on Tuesday morning, targeting structures allegedly built illegally and newly constructed in the floodplain.

Woman dies after falling from fourth floor in Alipur

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New Delhi

A 26-year-old woman died after allegedly falling from the fourth floor of a residential building in Delhi's Alipur on Monday night, police said. According to police, Alipur police station received a PCR call at around 10:33 pm reporting that a woman had fallen from a building near Rishikul School in Alipur.

A police team rushed to the spot and launched an inquiry. Preliminary investigation revealed that the woman, identified as Rashmi Gupta, wife of Sumit Gupta and a resident of Alipur, had allegedly jumped from the roof of a four-storey building.

FROM PAGE - 1

PM raises maritime security concerns...

The PM said disruptions to maritime trade in the Strait of Hormuz have hit the global economy.

"It is our responsibility to ensure the safety of the seafarers who connect all nations through global maritime trade. We must ensure that maritime routes remain secure and that seafarers can perform their duties without fear," he said.

The US Central Command said it initiated action to disable the three vessels -- Marivex on June 8, Settebello on June 9 and Jalveer on June 11, saying they were trying to violate the US blockade of Iranian ports.

Modi also flagged the concerns of the countries of the Global South and said they aspire to be partners in global development.

"Today, the Global South has high expectations of the global community. However, what they seek is not merely support, but partnership. They aspire to be partners in global development, not just beneficiaries," he said.

"We must move beyond the donor-recipient mindset and work as equal partners. We should walk together, side by side. Partnership must be rooted in dignity, not dependency."

"Through these efforts, we will lay a strong foundation for sustainable development for future generations," Modi said.

On the sidelines, Modi is scheduled to hold important bilateral discussions with several leaders, including Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney, British Prime Minister Keir Starmer, and UAE President Sheikh Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan.

Govt blocks Telegram app before NEET

He justified use of Air Force for logistics because the timeframe for conducting the examination is very short.

NTA and IIT Madras justified the temporary restriction on Telegram citing instances where the platform was allegedly used to fabricate evidence of question paper leaks through edited messages carrying old timestamps.

Google has hence removed messaging app Telegram from its Play Store, and Apple is likely to follow suit in compliance with a Government order, sources aware of the development said on Tuesday.

The nationwide examination is conducted by the National Testing Agency (NTA) for admission to undergraduate medical institutes. The agency cancelled the previous exam held on May 3 amid allegations of paper leak. Existing Telegram accounts continued to remain operational. While Apple's App Store was showing the app,

the new account could not be activated on iPhones.

The Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY), acting on recommendations made by the NTA, has issued a direction under Section 69A of the Information Technology Act, 2000, restricting access to the Telegram platform in India for a defined and limited period ending June 22, 2026, covering the day of the NEET (UG) 2026 re-examination and its immediate aftermath.

Government said the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C), under the Ministry of Home Affairs, has served as the principal nodal agency, coordinating the operational response to the Telegram-based fraud and misinformation targeting NEET candidates.

According to the agency, acting on inputs from the NTA, state law enforcement agencies, including the police forces of Bihar, Gujarat and Rajasthan, and its own monitoring efforts, I4C secured the prompt takedown of a "substantial number" of Telegram channels, groups and bots that openly advertised fraudulent and misleading purposes.

Digital advocacy group The Internet Freedom Foundation criticised the Government's curbs on Telegram and disabling its message-editing feature ahead of the NEET-UG 2026 re-exam, calling the move a band-aid solution and a "disproportionate" response to exam fraud.

Delhi Police bust ISI-linked terror-crime ring

MOHIT's interrogation led investigators to associates Anas, Arif, and Karanveer Singh, who had allegedly been recruited to facilitate the smuggling and distribution of weapons and narcotics trafficked from Pakistan, including through drone deliveries. Anas's interrogation revealed that Bhatti and Gujjar had directed the group to conduct reconnaissance of potential targets, including public places, to create fear and disturb communal harmony. Photographs and videos of identified locations were transmitted to handlers in Pakistan for operational planning.

The financial trail was traced through UPI scanner transactions routed through accounts belonging to individuals working in Dubai, with funds ultimately reaching conduits associated with the syndicate. Arif had purchased a Jigana pistol from Gujjar for Rs 1 lakh through this route. The group later moved into smuggling heroin from Punjab into Delhi and the NCR, using a dead-drop delivery system to avoid detection. Anas and Karanveer were deputed to Punjab to facilitate this operation.

Investigators also found that gangster Deepak Agrola, lodged in Mandoli jail and facing 23 prior

cases, including murder and dacoity, was introduced to Gujjar by Anas. Agrola used a mobile phone smuggled into jail, later recovered by jail staff, to coordinate the procurement of illegal weapons through his associate Jatan.

This is not the first time Shahzad Bhatti's network has surfaced in Delhi Police investigations. Additional Commissioner of Police Pramod Singh Kushwaha had earlier confirmed that Bhatti, a Pakistani national, was operating at the behest of Pakistan's intelligence agency and had directed an attack involving a hand grenade thrown at the Gurdaspur City Police Station. Investigators have established that Bhatti, believed to operate between Pakistan and Dubai, uses Instagram, WhatsApp, and voice messages to recruit tech-savvy Indian youths with no prior criminal record, often teenagers or those in their early twenties, offering them money and a sense of importance in exchange for following instructions.

The recovery in the present case includes seven mobile phones containing voice notes and chats that directly link the accused to Bhatti and Gujjar, one Scorpio vehicle used by the syndicate, and details of multiple bank accounts used to route proceeds from arms and narcotics sales.

Police said legal action has been initiated against all seven accused. Efforts are underway to apprehend absconding associates, including Aamir, and to identify the intermediaries, suppliers, and recipients involved in the cross-border smuggling network. Further investigation is in progress to map the full extent of the conspiracy.

El Nino effect: As Monsoon falters...

The weather department has forecast the southwest monsoon at around 90 per cent of the long-period average, signalling a below-normal season.

On June 11, the United States' National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration declared that El Nino had formed and issued an advisory, putting a 63 per cent chance of it turning very strong by winter. India's own weather office is more cautious, still calling the Pacific neutral but "transitioning toward El Nino", a gap in thresholds, not direction.

Chouhan gave clear directions that full preparations should be made in advance in those districts where there is a possibility of low rainfall or uneven rainfall.

He said that such districts should be clearly identified and crop-wise contingency plans should be prepared in coordination with state Governments so that in any weather challenge situation, farmers can be provided immediate alternatives, advice and support.

The Agriculture Minister said the Government is working closely with states to expand cultivation of pigeon pea, black gram, and green gram through crop rotation, area expansion, improved seed availability, and technical guidance, with the aim of reducing import dependence. The review covered fertiliser availability, market prices, reservoir levels, and water storage status across states.

Chouhan assured that fertiliser supply is adequate at the national level and will be further streamlined to states and districts as the monsoon progresses. He directed officials to ensure advance supply in areas facing potential micro-level shortages.

Chouhan stressed the need for tighter coordination among agricultural universities, ICAR institutes, KVKs, and state agriculture departments, noting that technical knowledge is "meaningful only when it reaches the fields in a timely manner."

Punjab: Akal Takht-Mann clash as faith, politics...

Instead, the party now finds itself defending its tallest leader against allegations that have pushed its governance agenda into the background.

The Akal Takht's decision declaring Mann "Guru dokhi" and "Panth virodhi" has placed AAP in a delicate position. The party must defend its Chief Minister while avoiding any perception of confrontation with Sikhs' highest temporal seat. Mann's own response reflects this balancing act. He has repeatedly reaffirmed the supremacy of the Akal Takht and his reverence for the institution, while questioning what he describes as politically motivated functionaries and appointments influencing its decisions.

By doing so, AAP appears to be drawing a distinction between the sanctity of the institution and the neutrality of its present management, attempting to challenge the politics surrounding the decision without challenging the institution itself.

Politically, Mann has also sought to change the narrative. Rather than allowing the controversy to revolve around the viral video, he has linked it to his Government's stringent anti-sacrilege law, arguing that vested interests have targeted him because the legislation received public support. His repeated emphasis on protecting Punjab's "Paani, Jawani, Kisani and Bani" is an attempt to portray himself as a leader under attack for pursuing Punjab-centric policies rather than someone facing a purely religious censure.

Ironically, the controversy invites comparisons with the sacrilege incidents that politically damaged the SAD after 2015. The series of dese-

cration cases and the subsequent police firing at Behal Kalan and Kotkapura severely eroded the SAD's panthic image and contributed to its electoral decline. More than a decade later, AAP now finds itself confronting allegations that seek to associate its own Chief Minister with hurting Sikh sentiments. While the circumstances are entirely different, the political attempt to link a ruling dispensation with sacrilege-related issues reflects a familiar pattern in Punjab politics.

The episode also underscores a larger battle for Punjab's panthic space. For decades, the SAD projected itself as the principal panthic party and political representative of Sikh interests. However, successive electoral setbacks and the fallout from the 2015 sacrilege controversy weakened that position. AAP's enactment of a stringent anti-sacrilege law was widely viewed as an effort to reassure Sikh voters and strengthen its own panthic credentials. The present confrontation, therefore, is not merely about a viral video but about competing claims over political legitimacy and credibility on issues deeply intertwined with Sikh identity.

Mann's decision to publicly name SAD chief Sukhbir Singh Badal is politically significant, as it seeks to portray the row as a struggle for political relevance rather than a religious dispute. In doing so, AAP is attempting to challenge SAD on its traditional panthic turf and deny it the opportunity to reclaim lost political ground ahead of the polls.

For the opposition, the controversy presents a valuable political opportunity. The SAD is likely to use the Akal Takht's pronouncement to reclaim lost panthic ground, while the Congress has already framed the issue as one of moral legitimacy by demanding Mann's resignation. The BJP, too, has attempted to highlight the administrative and political implications of the directive, adding to the pressure on the ruling party.

For AAP, the challenge is that a campaign intended to centre around governance, welfare schemes and administrative performance now risks being overshadowed by an emotionally charged religious debate. Punjab's political history shows that once elections become intertwined with questions of faith and identity, electoral calculations often become unpredictable.

Ultimately, what began as a dispute over a controversial video has evolved into a contest over political legitimacy, Panthic credibility and public perception. For AAP, the immediate task is to ensure that a religious controversy does not eclipse five years of governance. For the opposition - particularly the Shiromani Akali Dal - it presents an opportunity to reclaim its traditional political space and redefine the electoral discourse.

NIA attaches Amritsar house in LeT narco-terror probe

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Amritsar

In a decisive step to choke the financial lifelines of terrorism, the National Investigation Agency (NIA) on Tuesday attached a house in Amritsar's upscale Holy City enclave, identifying it as proceeds of a sprawling transnational narco-terror conspiracy linked to the Pakistan-based Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT).

The house, located at number 33 in Holy City, Holy Enclave Phase-I, Amritsar, is registered under the name of the accused's father, Ankush Kapoor (also known as Ankush Vipan Kapoor), who the agency says is a key member of the network in India.

The Salaya narco-terror case started in 2018, when Gujarat's Anti-Terrorism Squad (ATS) registered FIR No. 01/2018 at PS ATS, Ahmedabad, on August 12.

This happened after they intercepted a large shipment of drugs smuggled from Pakistan by sea to the

Gujarat coast near Salaya. The NIA later found that about 500 kg of heroin entered India this way and was then moved to different states, mainly Punjab, for storage and sale. The profits were sent through hawala and other money laundering methods to support LeT operations in India.

The ISI-sponsored terror network operated in several countries, such as Italy, Australia, the UAE, Pakistan, Iran, and Thailand. Investigations have found that it had important connections to LeT-linked handlers in Dubai. The NIA identified three main leaders: Simranjit Singh Sandhu (based in Italy), Tanveer Bedi (also known as Tanveer Singh Bedi, based in Australia), and Ankush Kapoor (based in India, managing operations in Punjab).

It was revealed that Ankush Kapoor coordinated the Indian side of the operation. NIA says he managed logistics, transport, storage, and local drug distribution in



Punjab. He also helped transfer money to other accused individuals. Kapoor's name first came up in January 2020 during Punjab police operations. He was arrested on January 29, 2020, in connection with FIR No. 20/2020 (Mohali) and FIR No. 23/2020 (Amritsar) under the NDPS Act and Arms Act. During the

search of his premises, the police found heroin, processing chemicals, and other evidence.

The NIA later took over the investigation and linked the Punjab cases to the larger Gujarat-based conspiracy. Kapoor has faced long legal proceedings and several bail requests. The agency has

opposed his release, saying he played a key role in funding terror. Court records show the NIA asked for his bail to be cancelled and pointed to his alleged role in cross-border drug rings and hawala deals. The investigation has continued with several more charge sheets.

The probe agency filed the eighth supplementary charge sheet before the NIA Special Court in Ahmedabad in October 2025, naming eight more accused. These include Pakistani national Tariq (also known as Bhaijaan), Gagandeep Singh Arora, Tamanna Gupta, Sukhbir Singh (also known as Happy), and Anwar Masih. So far, 26 people have been charged in the case. The charges include sections of the NDPS Act, Indian Penal Code, and the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA), focusing on terror funding and conspiracy. Some accused are still at large.

Attaching the Amritsar house is a direct move

against the syndicate's financial network. NIA teams carried out the order in accordance with legal procedures, with independent witnesses and assistance from local authorities.

The property is now officially attached as "proceeds of terrorism." This action is similar to other NIA cases, where assets like real estate and bank accounts linked to the accused or their families are seized to weaken the financial base of terror groups.

By tracing the chain from Pakistani suppliers and sea smugglers to Indian distributors and international money launderers, the NIA has mapped out a multi-country operation that was allegedly set up to benefit LeT.

The attachment of the property on Tuesday shows that, even with some accused in custody or on the run, the agency will continue to target property obtained through this illegal trade, an official said.

States Focus



GOVT REJECTS UPSC PRELIMS PAPER LEAK CLAIMS AS FAKE

The Centre on Tuesday debunked social media posts claiming that the recently concluded civil services prelims exam question paper was leaked as "fake".

In a post on social media, the Press Information Bureau's Fact Check wing said that "several social media posts circulating online are alleging that the UPSC Civil Services (Preliminary) Examination, 2026 question paper was leaked". "This claim is fake," it said, attaching a photo of a social media post by the National Students' Union of India (NSUI), the student wing of the Congress party.

The civil services examination is conducted annually by the Union Public Service Commission in three stages – preliminary, main and interview – to select officers of the Indian Administrative Service, Indian Foreign Service and Indian Police Service (IPS), among others. (PTI)

BJP hails historic moment as PM gets Slovakia's top award

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A day after Prime Minister Narendra Modi was conferred Slovakia's highest civilian award, the BJP on Tuesday described it as "historic" and said it is a recognition of his welfare work in the country and the global trust he has earned.

Speaking to reporters, BJP national spokesperson Sambit Patra said the bestowing of the award on the prime minister has brought honour

to the country.

"With this, Prime Minister Narendra Modi has been conferred a total of 33 highest civilian awards of various countries. These awards have been bestowed on him for the development work that he has done and the trust that he has earned – not just in India but across the globe," the BJP MP said.

These awards have been conferred on the prime minister also for the work that he has done for the welfare of the country's people, including those who are poor, he said.



BJP national spokesperson Sambit Patra

CBI files chargesheet against 13 in CREST scam

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Chandigarh

On Tuesday, the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) filed a chargesheet in a special court in Chandigarh, naming 13 people accused of siphoning ₹75.34 crore from the accounts of the Chandigarh Renewable Energy Science and Technical Promotion Society (CREST). This is an important step in the agency's investigation into the large-scale diversion of Government funds meant for renewable energy projects in the Union Territory.

The chargesheet lists five officials from IDFC First Bank, two senior officials from CREST under the Chandigarh UT Administration, two shell companies, and four private individuals. All 13 are charged with criminal conspiracy, criminal breach of trust, cheating, forgery, destroying evidence, and offences under the Prevention of Corruption Act, 1988.



The CBI says that officials from IDFC First Bank worked with CREST public servants to divert money directly from the society's bank accounts. The stolen funds were then sent through several channels to private individuals and companies who benefited. The agency called the scheme a carefully planned conspiracy involving both public servants and private individuals.

The present case pertains to the misappropriation of Government funds amounting to ₹75.34 crore, siphoned off from CREST bank accounts by IDFC First Bank officials in criminal con-

nivance with CREST public servants. The siphoned-off funds were then diverted in connivance with several private persons, who also benefited from these funds," the CBI spokesperson said.

The agency has said this is not the final chargesheet in the case. Officials explained that more charge sheets will be filed as the investigation reveals more details of the conspiracy. This case is part of a larger CBI investigation into the alleged misappropriation of Rs 657 crore connected to projects in Chandigarh and Haryana. The agency registered three separate FIRs at the request of the

Governments of Chandigarh UT and Haryana. The investigation examines several government schemes and projects in which public funds were allegedly diverted by bank officials, government employees, and private companies.

Before this, the CBI had already filed two charge sheets in Haryana-related cases, naming 17 accused. It also filed one chargesheet in the Chandigarh Smart City Project case against seven people. The latest chargesheet focuses on the diversion of CREST funds and brings the total number of accused in the three cases to 37 so far. The case has revealed major problems in the monitoring of Government accounts linked to renewable energy groups. As the investigation continues, more information about the flow of funds and the people who benefited is expected to come out in future charge sheets.

Rebel TMC MPs' merger plan mirrors Pema Khandu's 2016 move: Officials

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Former Election Commission officials have noted that the plan by 20 dissident Trinamool Congress Lok Sabha MPs to merge with a lesser-known, unrecognised party is similar to the 2016 split in the Congress's Arunachal Pradesh unit under Pema Khandu. That year, Arunachal Pradesh experienced a significant political realignment.

In September 2016, Khandu and 42 Congress MLAs joined the People's Party of Arunachal (PPA), while former chief minister Nabam Tuki remained with the Congress. The PPA, which was part of the BJP-led North East Democratic Alliance (NEDA), subsequently formed the Government with Khandu as chief minister.

In December 2016, Khandu and 32 PPA legislators joined the BJP. This resulted in the BJP securing



its first full-majority government in Arunachal Pradesh, with 45 members in the 60-member Assembly. The PPA was left with 10 MLAs and the Congress with three.

In the 2019 Assembly elections, the BJP won 41 out of 60 seats. Khandu continued as chief minister.

In 2026, a similar situation has emerged.

A group of 20 dissident TMC Lok Sabha MPs have informed Lok Sabha Speaker

Om Birla of their intention to merge with the Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI), a registered but unrecognised political party based in Howrah, West Bengal.

In the 2023 Tripura elections, the NCPI fielded four candidates. Two contested for the party symbol, one stood as an Independent, and the nomination of the fourth was rejected. None of the candidates won, and all received votes equal to

or fewer than NOTA.

The Lok Sabha Secretariat is seeking a written legal opinion regarding the TMC rebels' merger request to ensure that the Speaker's decision can withstand judicial scrutiny if challenged.

Former Lok Sabha secretary general and constitutional expert P D T Achary cited paragraph 4 of the 10th Schedule of the Constitution to underline that only a political party can merge with another party, and MPs or MLAs cannot merge on their own. Paragraph 4 of the 10th Schedule deals with the exception to disqualification in case of a merger.

It says that a member of a House will not be disqualified if the original political party to which they belong merges with another political party, and not less than two-thirds of the members of the legislature party concerned agree to such a merger.

NCPI agree to accept rebel TMC MPs, says Kakoli

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

On Tuesday, rebel Trinamool Congress MP Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar said the Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI) has agreed to take in all dissident Lok Sabha members from her party. She also mentioned that their group could grow from 20 to 22 members.

She explained that the rebel MPs are not linked to the dissident TMC MLAs. Those MLAs have formed their own group in the West Bengal Assembly, which Speaker Rathindra Bose has recognised. When asked about what comes next for the rebel TMC MPs, Dastidar said they want to settle in first, then focus on merging with another party.

"Acceptance has already come to us. They (NCPI) are happy to take us. We will work together with the NDA under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah," Dastidar told reporters at Parliament House. When asked about her faction's



strength, she said, "Currently, we are 20 (MPs). The numbers may go up to 22." In the 2024 general elections, 28 MPs were elected to the Lok Sabha on TMC tickets.

Dastidar again said that the dissident MPs are not connected to the rebel TMC MLAs in Bengal.

"We have no connection with them. They are a separate group; their issues and agenda are different," she said. Earlier in the day, Dastidar attended a meeting of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Home Affairs. She said the previous TMC Government in West Bengal did not implement the

women's safety scheme in the state for the past 10 years.

"We were just discussing that even child safety issues were not allowed in Bengal. Like that, many other schemes were not implemented under the previous (TMC) Government," she said.

The senior MP also said they want to implement all Central schemes in Bengal with help from Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari.

"Certain schemes have not been implemented in West Bengal. Child marriage is highest in Bengal, according to NCRB data. That is also a crime. So, these things were happening in Bengal, which

none of them took up. So, we are trying to work for the betterment of the people of Bengal," Dastidar said.

The crisis in the TMC grew on Sunday after the dissident MPs announced they would merge with the little-known NCPI and met Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla to request a separate seating arrangement in the Lok Sabha. After meeting Birla, Dastidar told reporters that 20 TMC MPs had signed a letter given to the speaker. speaker. "Two-thirds of TMC MPs have given a letter to the speaker for a separate seating arrangement in the House. We will merge with the Nationalist Citizens Party and support the NDA," she had said.

The NCPI became a registered political party in January 2023. Its address in the Election Commission's records is a building in Sankarail, Howrah district, West Bengal.

The little-known outfit has now unexpectedly entered the national political discourse after the rebel TMC MPs announced their merger with the party.

Air India trials cheaper basic fares without meals

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Air India has introduced the basic fare option without complimentary meals on domestic flights as the loss-making full-service airline grapples with rising operational costs. The basic fare is entirely optional, and the three other fare categories of value, classic and flex would also be available for the passengers.

The three categories of value, classic and flex include complimentary meals and a range of bundled benefits at progressively higher price points.

The introduction of basic fare simply adds another layer of choice, particularly for price-conscious travellers who prefer a more unbundled offering, the airline said in a statement on Tuesday.

According to the airline, the basic fare is currently available on select domestic routes on a pilot basis.

"Being trialled on select domestic



routes, the Basic fare is available for travel in Economy Class and is designed for travellers who prioritise value. It includes a 15 kg checked baggage allowance, 7 kg cabin baggage allowance, complimentary beverage service (tea/coffee), while complimentary meals are not included," the airline said.

Union Govt to train panchayat leaders on gender equality

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Ministry of Panchayati Raj will conduct a three-day training-of-trainers programme from June 17 to 19 to sensitise elected male representatives towards gender equality and women-related issues under its "Nirbhay Raho" initiative.

The programme, titled "Sensitisation of Men towards Women-related Issues, including Safety and Security of Women", will be held at the Indian Institute of Public Administration in New Delhi and is part of "Nirbhay Chetna", one of the three interventions under the Nirbhay Raho initiative.

According to the ministry, the training aims to build a cadre of trainers capable of sensitising elected male representa-



Union Minister for Panchayati Raj Rajiv Ranjan Singh

tives within Panchayati Raj Institutions on gender equality and women's issues.

A total of 45 master trainers, including consultants from the National Institute of Rural Development and Panchayati Raj, will participate in the programme.

Participants have been invited from Assam,

Chhattisgarh, Maharashtra, Odisha, Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand.

The inaugural session will be attended by Panchayati Raj Secretary Vivek Bharadwaj, who will deliver the keynote address. Additional Secretary Sushil Kumar Lohani and Joint Secretary Amit Agarwal will also address the participants.

A key highlight of the inaugural session will be the launch of a training module developed under the Nirbhay Raho project. The module seeks to promote critical reflection on social norms, gender roles, masculinity, power relations and community leadership, while strengthening the role of panchayats in fostering safe, inclusive and gender-responsive communities.

The sensitisation module has been developed by Transform Rural India.

Nirbhay Raho, launched on March 11 this year through the Nirbhaya Fund, is being implemented by the Panchayati Raj Ministry in collaboration with the Ministry of Women and Child Development and the National Law School of India University, Bengaluru.

The initiative comprises

three components: Nirbhay Netri, focused on capacity building and legal awareness of elected women representatives; Nirbhay Chetna, aimed at sensitising elected male representatives on gender equality and women's issues; and Nirbhay Drishti, which envisages the installation of CCTV cameras at strategic rural locations to strengthen technology-enabled safety infrastructure in panchayats.

The ministry said the initiative aims to train more than 17.5 lakh male elected representatives and over 14.5 lakh women elected representatives across the country, with learning from the training programme expected to foster future capacity-building efforts through panchayati raj training institutions and local governance networks.

States Focus



TAMIL NADU GOVT RELEASES WHITE PAPER ON STATE FINANCES

Tamil Nadu Finance Minister Marie Wilson on Tuesday released a white paper on the State's finances, which faulted the previous DMK regime helmed by then Chief Minister MK Stalin. Addressing a press conference at the Secretariat, Wilson said Tamil Nadu has a "direct" debt burden of Rs 10 lakh crore and ₹78,324 crore of revenue deficit, a "new high, not seen so far." As regards key metrics of SOTR (State's Own Tax Revenue) and GSDP (Gross State Domestic Product), it stood at 5.45 per cent, which was pretty low. Soon after taking over as the chief minister, TVK founder leader C Joseph Vijay had assured that his Government would release a white paper on the State finances. (PTI)



FIRST KAILASH MANSAROVAR YATRA BATCH REACHES GANGTOK

The first batch of this year's Kailash Mansarovar Yatra pilgrims arrived here for their onward journey through the Nathu La Pass. Officials said the first batch that arrived here on Monday evening comprises 44 people, including two liaison Officers and one medical officer. Among them are 32 men and 12 women. A statement from the Tourism Department said the pilgrims were accorded a warm welcome at a local hotel by Sikkim Tourism Development Corporation Chairman Lukendra Rasaily and deputy general manager Amit Kapil Chettri. The pilgrims will undergo a four-day acclimatisation programme here, following which they will on June 20 proceed for Gangtze, a town in the Tibet Autonomous Region of China, that serves as a transit point for pilgrims taking the Nathu La Pass route. (PTI)

HARYANA, UP TO TEAM UP AGAINST SEX DETERMINATION RACKETS



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

In a step towards strengthening the campaign against illegal sex determination, Haryana has initiated efforts to further enhance inter-state cooperation with neighbouring Uttar Pradesh.

In a letter on Monday addressed to UP Additional Chief Secretary (Medical Health and Family Welfare) Amit Kumar Ghosh, Haryana's Additional Chief Secretary (Health and Family Welfare) Sumita Misra underscored the shared commitment of both states towards improving the sex ratio at birth and advancing the objectives of the Beti Bachao Beti Padhao campaign. She emphasised that coordinated enforcement and administrative support are essential to eliminate illegal practices that threaten the rights and dignity of the girl child. Highlighting Haryana's sustained and proactive enforcement strategy, Misra noted that the state's Pre-Conception and Pre-Natal Diagnostic Techniques (PC&PNDT) Act teams have been consistently conducting decoy operations and raids against illegal operators involved in sex determination activities.

Between January 2024 and March 2026, Haryana carried out 84 such raids, including 37 operations in UP, reflecting the state's determination to pursue offenders even beyond its borders, an official statement said on Tuesday.

ED raids Suraksha ARC, realty firms as part of YES Bank loan probe

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Mumbai

The Enforcement Directorate on Tuesday raided 17 locations in Mumbai, Khandala and Delhi linked to Suraksha Asset Reconstruction Company Ltd (SARCL), Suraksha Realty Ltd and Khyati Realtors Pvt Ltd. The raids focused on the companies' promoters, directors, employees, and a former YES Bank official as part of a money-laundering investigation into suspected irregularities in loan assignments and corporate insolvency processes.

Officials said the investigation is examining the suspected fraudulent granting of loans by YES Bank, particularly to Mackstar Marketing Pvt Ltd, as well as other advances made in 2016-17 and 2017-18. Investigators are checking whether these loans were improperly



assigned to asset reconstruction companies through circular transactions, which may have enabled the takeover of stressed assets at low prices.

The raids also aim to find evidence of inflated claims and a lack of transparency in the Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code. ED teams

took documents, financial records, and digital data from the sites. No one has been arrested yet. The agency is reviewing the roles of company officials and the former bank employee in the loan assignment process.

This investigation follows ongoing scrutiny of YES Bank's lending practices during the time Rana Kapoor was in charge.

Reports say YES Bank extended about ₹202 crore in loans to Mackstar Marketing Pvt Ltd, allegedly used to move funds linked to the HDIL group. These loans were later transferred to Suraksha ARC. Special audits and earlier investigations have pointed out governance issues, possible round-tripping of funds, and early transfers of assets to ARCs. Similar problems have come up in other cases where Suraksha ARC acquired YES Bank's stressed loans. Suraksha ARC, led by industrialist Sudhir Valia, is registered with the Reserve Bank of India. Suraksha ARC buys non-performing assets from banks and seeks to resolve them through restructuring or insolvency proceedings. Asset reconstruction companies like Suraksha often act as financial creditors in insolvency cases.

Quitting AIADMK with anguish: ex-minister Vijayabaskar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

Former AIADMK minister C Vijayabaskar, who resigned as MLA on Tuesday, said he has quit the party with "anguish" and a "heavy heart" and blamed party chief Edappadi K Palaniswami for "wrong decisions."

In a two-page letter, the former health minister thanked cadres and well-wishers who supported him.

"AIADMK is facing trials and tribulations due to party chief Palaniswami's wrong decisions," Vijayabaskar, a doctor by profession, alleged.

He is the fifth legislator to quit the party in a month's time. While he is yet to reveal his political plans, four other members -



Maragatham Kumaravel, S Jayakumar, P Sathyabama and Esakki Subaya, resigned as MLAs and joined the ruling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam, despite winning the April Assembly election on AIADMK ticket. These legislators were among 21 rebel MLAs who defied party diktat and voted in favour of the TVK Government during the floor test in the Assembly on May 13.

Vijayabaskar was elected from Virulimalai Assembly seat. Earlier in the day, he

met Assembly Speaker J C D Prabhakar and submitted a handwritten letter stating that he was resigning as MLA.

Following his resignation, the AIADMK's strength in the Assembly has declined to 42 in the 234-member House.

Also, the exodus of AIADMK members and cadres from various parts of the state to the ruling TVK has resulted in a crisis in the party.

"It pains me deeply that a movement I loved all my life is now facing hardship and trials due to the wrong decisions of an individual. In this context, I am making this decision with the feeling that it would not be right to continue my journey carrying unresolved ache in my heart," Vijayabaskar said in an emotional statement.

"What I am stepping away from is not a party, but a chapter in my life," he added, recalling his association with the AIADMK for over 35 years, inspired by iconic leaders - Amma (late chief minister J Jayalalithaa) and party founder M G Ramachandran. He has been in the party since his student days and a second-generation politician in his family.

"To me, AIADMK is not just a political organisation but my passion, my identity and part of my life," Vijayabaskar said.

He had served as health minister during the Covid outbreak and initial lockdown.

Earlier in a post on 'X' he said, "Leadership is not authority or arrogance... a profound embrace of dedication."

BJP failed test by not sacking Pradhan: Kharge

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Tuesday accused the BJP Government of having completely failed the test of accountability by not asking Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan to resign following several exam irregularities.

He also criticised the Government for putting curbs on the Telegram messaging app ahead of the NEET-UG 2026 re-exam on June 21.

"The Modi Government has temporarily blocked



Telegram for the NEET exam re-test. Modi ji should first demand the resignation of his Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, who has blocked the futures of millions of youth," Kharge

said in a post on X. "Whether it's deploying the Indian Air Force, blocking Telegram, or catching small fish to protect the paper leak mafia — this is all something the Modi Government has to do

because in the last 10 years, 90 paper leaks have occurred, and 9 crore youth are suffering due to this fraud and corruption. How long will this Government keep covering up its failures?" the Congress chief asked. The Leader of Opposition in the Rajya Sabha claimed that nearly half a dozen young people have been forced to take their own lives due to the exam irregularities.

"Modi ji doesn't utter a single word. There are countless candidates whose parents took loans to prepare them for recruitment exams over the years.



Lieutenant General VM Bhuvana Krishnan, GOC-in-C, Eastern Command of the Indian Army, called upon Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma at Lok Sewa Bhawan, Dispur
PIONEER PHOTO

TN CM announces full waiver of crop loans up to ₹75,000

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay on Tuesday announced a full waiver of crop loans of up to ₹75,000 availed by farmers through cooperative banks from May 1, 2025, to February 28, 2026.

The waiver would benefit 14.43 lakh farmers across the State and would entail the State Government ₹5,932 crore and would ensure a big

relief to the ryots, the Government said.

Following a review meeting with ministers and senior officials at the Secretariat here, the chief minister said that farmers who had availed loans exceeding ₹75,000 will receive a waiver of ₹35,000, a release from the Government said.

The announcement follows a representation from the farmers in the wake



of the State Government announcing a waiver of loans of up to ₹50,000 last month

for small and marginal farmers who availed cooperative bank loans. The new announcement is a revision.

According to the release, as per the Reserve Bank of India's Model Operating Procedures for Government Loan Waiver Schemes, the Government should fully disburse the entire amount of crop loan waiver within 45 to 60 days. "Considering the current financial position and financial resources of the

State Government, in this difficult situation, the chief minister has ordered a waiver of approximately ₹6,000 crore to 14.43 lakh farmers who have availed crop loans from May 1, 2025, to February 28, 2026," the release added.

"This crop loan waiver will be of great benefit to farmers who wish to obtain loans for the upcoming cultivation season," the release said, quoting Vijay.

Bihar Police shoot 2 suspects in ₹50-lakh robbery

SURESH PD NIKHAR ■ Patna

In a major breakthrough in the investigation of a high-profile robbery case, police shot and arrested two alleged criminals during an encounter in Gaya district here on Monday night. The accused were wanted in connection with the robbery of jewellery and cash worth around ₹50 lakh. Both sustained bullet injuries to their legs and are currently undergoing treatment.

According to Gaya Senior Superintendent of Police (SSP) Sushil Kumar, police received information around midnight on Monday that criminals linked to the Gurua robbery case were planning another crime. Acting on the tip-off, a police team laid a trap and conducted a raid near the Amas police station area.

During the operation, the suspects were surrounded and asked to surrender, but they allegedly opened fire on the police team.

In self-defence, the police retaliated, injuring two of the accused in their legs.

While three other criminals managed to escape under the cover of darkness, and efforts are underway to apprehend them. One of the injured accused has been identified as Sujit Chaudhary, the



alleged mastermind of the robbery, who suffered three bullet wounds in both legs. The second injured criminal also sustained a bullet injury. Both have been admitted to Anugrah Narayan Magadh Medical College and Hospital, Gaya, where they are receiving treatment.

Police said the accused have confessed to their involvement in the Gurua market robbery. Sujit Chaudhary and Shrawan Mallah, both residents of the Amas police station area, have been named in the case.

Jewellery suspected to be linked to the robbery was also recovered during the operation, although officials have not yet confirmed the exact value of the recovered items. The robbery had taken place on May 27, at around 6:30 pm in Gurua, Gaya district. Four armed criminals allegedly shot local jeweller Prabhakar Barnwal and fled with jewellery worth approximately ₹45 lakh and cash amounting to ₹5 lakh.

Phase 1 of Census 2027 completed in 23 States and Union territories

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Phase one of the 2027 Census — house listing and housing census (HLO) — has been completed in 23 states and Union territories so far, a government statement said Tuesday.

A 15-day self-enumeration process is underway in Kerala and Nagaland, followed by a field operation starting on July 1 and continuing until July 30, it said.

The field operations for the phase commenced in Himachal Pradesh on Tuesday, and are already underway in Gujarat, Jammu & Kashmir, Ladakh, Puducherry and Uttar Pradesh.

“Residents who have completed self-enumeration are requested to keep their generated self-enumeration ID ready and share the same with the enumerator during the field visit to complete the HLO process. Households that have not opted for self-enumeration will be covered during the physical house-to-house visit by enumerators,”



the statement said.

The ₹11,718 crore census exercise, which is the eighth since Independence, is being conducted in two phases — the first stage is known as house listing and housing census, while the second stage is the population census.

The housing listing and housing census, which started on April 1 and will continue till September 30, will systematically list all structures, houses, and households throughout the country to provide a sound framework for the population enumeration.

In a first, the exercise will be digital, with enumerators using a special mobile appli-

cation to collect the information.

During the housing listing field operations, enumerators will physically visit each house and building and ask citizens 33 questions about basic facilities in their homes, information about the head of the household, such as name and sex, and ownership status, among others.

For the first time, citizens have also been provided a self-enumeration platform on a specially developed website where they can answer the notified questions, generate an ID and provide it to the field enumerator when they come for verification, saving valuable time.

Every State will have to provide a 15-day window for self-enumeration immediately preceding the month-long field operations during which enumerators will go door-to-door with their questionnaire to collect data.

The State and UTs can choose a period — 15 days of self-enumeration followed by 30 days of field exercise — between April 1 and September 30 to complete the HLO phase.

The second phase of the census — population enumeration — will be conducted in February next year, in which demographic, social, and economic particulars of every person in the country will be recorded. Caste-related questions will also be part of the second phase.

The reference date for Census 2027 will be March 1, 2027, for all States and Union Territories, except for the Union Territory of Ladakh and snow-bound non-synchronous areas of Jammu & Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh, and Uttarakhand, where the reference date will be October 1, 2026.

Twisha Sharma death case: Court extends judicial custody of husband, mother-in-law

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhopal

A court in Bhopal on Tuesday extended by 14 days the judicial custody of late model Twisha Sharma's husband, Samarth Singh and mother-in-law and former judge Giribala Singh, both accused of dowry harassment.

Ankur Pandey, the lawyer representing Twisha's family, said that both accused joined the hearing, which was held in the court of Judge Shobhana Bhale, virtually.

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) had sought an extension of judicial custody until June 30, which the court accepted. Both accused are currently lodged in the Bhopal Central Jail.

Twisha was found hanging in her marital home in Bhopal on May 12. Amid allegations of lapses in the probe, the investigation was referred to the CBI.

On June 2, the court remanded both accused to judicial custody for 14 days till June 16.

Twisha's first post-



mortem report said her death was caused by “ante-mortem hanging by ligature” and her body bore “multiple ante-mortem injuries (simple in nature, possible by blunt force over other parts of the body have been noted)”.

After receiving the post-mortem report and recording the statement of family members of Twisha, a former actor-model, the police registered the FIR on May 15.

In their statements, Twisha's family members had alleged that she was tormented by her in-laws, who were not satisfied with the dowry paid at the time of marriage on December 9,



2025.

They had accused her in-laws of mental torture and domestic violence, and pushing the 33-year-old to take the extreme step.

In the statement given to the police at the time of filing the FIR, Twisha's family said she had spoken to her mother at 9.41 pm.

During the call, her husband was heard shouting, and the call was abruptly disconnected, the FIR citing the statement alleged.

After repeated calls, Giribala Singh picked up the phone and told Twisha's sister-in-law that “she is no more” and cut the call, it is alleged.

ENUMERATION PHASE OF SIR BEGINS IN ARUNACHAL PRADESH



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Itanagar

The enumeration phase of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls has got underway across Arunachal Pradesh, as part of a nationwide drive by the Election Commission to update voter lists.

According to a statement issued by the state's Chief Electoral Officer (CEO), electors whose enumeration forms are submitted by July 14 will be considered for inclusion in the draft electoral rolls.

Voters who are unable to submit the forms within the prescribed period can still seek enrolment during the claims and objections stage by filing 'Form 6' along with the required declaration form, it said.

As part of the exercise, booth-level officers (BLOs) have started visiting households to distribute, collect and verify enumeration forms from Monday, it said.

Election officials said the BLOs would make repeated visits, wherever necessary, to ensure wider coverage.

The Commission has expanded the role of recognised political parties in the revision process by allowing booth-level agents (BLAs) to collect up to 50 completed forms a day from the public, and hand them over to the BLOs before publication of the draft rolls, they said.

Political parties have also been encouraged to appoint additional BLAs to support the exercise.

The revision drive in Arunachal Pradesh is expected to cover 8,87,505 electors with the assistance of 2,233 BLOs and 3,131 BLAs, the statement said.

The CEO has urged all eligible voters to cooperate with election officials and actively participate in the house-to-house verification campaign to help prepare a correct, updated and inclusive electoral roll, it added.

All arrangements in place for Amarnath Yatra: Jitendra Singh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Srinagar

Union Minister Jitendra Singh on Tuesday said all arrangements, including security, have been put in place for the smooth conduct of the annual Amarnath Yatra, which begins early next month. Singh expressed confidence that the pilgrimage, scheduled to start on July 3, will be successful.

“The yatra this time is for a longer duration, and the administration has taken care of everything, including from the security point of view. We are confident that the yatra will be very successful,” the minister told reporters here.

The remarks from Singh, who is the Minister of State for Personnel, Public Grievances and Pensions, came following the inauguration of the 59th Pre-Retirement Counselling Workshop organised by the Department of Pension and Pensioners' Welfare at the SKICC here.

The minister said the Central Government, under Prime Minister Narendra Modi, has focused on improving the ease of living of every section of society over the past 12 years.

“As you know, the number of senior citizens in India is



increasing day by day. There was a time when the number of employed people was high, and pensioners were few, but now it has reversed. When they retire at 60, their expertise, experience, skill, and knowledge are also at their peak in their own way. It should not be wasted,” he said.

Keeping this concept in mind, Singh said workshops of this kind have been started across the country.

“Even after retiring, in whichever field or sector they have expertise, they can continue to play their role, as PM Modi says that every citizen has a role to play in building a developed India by 2047,” he added. The minister said the Jammu and Kashmir Bank has been included in the list of banks disbursing pensions for central Government employees.

“After J&K became a UT, all

the employees of the Government of J&K, who used to be the State Government employees, are today Central government employees. This department looks after them,” he said. “Keeping that in mind, J&K Bank has been included in the panel of the disbursing banks through which pension is disbursed to the retired employees,” he added.

Singh said an MoU has been signed because most of the salary accounts in the Union territory are with the J&K Bank.

“I think this is a new beginning which will provide ease to this 60-plus section. We have used face recognition technology. That era is over now, when they had to visit a doctor to furnish their life certificate every year. They can now put their energy and time to better use,” he added.

Andhra CM Naidu showcases Amaravati vision at World Cities Summit in Singapore

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amaravati

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Tuesday showcased his vision for Amaravati at the World Cities Summit in Singapore, describing the greenfield capital city as a people-centric urban centre built on the principles of equity, sustainability, opportunity and livability.

Addressing the Leadership Plenary-2 session on the theme “Can Smart Cities Love Humans?”, the chief minister said Amaravati is being developed as one of the finest cities in the world with world-class infrastructure, advanced digital capabilities and a strong focus on quality of life. “People first is our policy. Amaravati will be a city based on equity, nature, opportunity and livability,” Naidu said.

Reflecting on his focus on technology-driven growth, the chief minister



said he had spoken about information technology 25 years ago and that the first-mover advantage had helped Telugu people emerge among the leaders in per capita income.

Naidu said the bifurcation of Andhra Pradesh provided an opportunity to build another city and that Amaravati is being developed as a greenfield capital and a platform of opportunities.

The CM said the city is taking shape around the Krishna River with inner and outer ring roads and iconic bridges forming key elements of its infrastruc-

ture. He noted that Amaravati would be developed as a 21-km waterfront city and would incorporate specialised zones such as Sports City, Financial City, Knowledge City, Justice City, Tourism City, Health City and Media City.

The CM said farmers had voluntarily contributed 35,000 acres of land under the land pooling model after a single call from the government and noted that a portion of the land is being developed and returned to them as developed plots.

Drawing a comparison with Cyberabad, Naidu said



Pijush Hazarika, Minister for Agriculture and Irrigation, Government of Assam, called on Union Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan at his residence in New Delhi and briefed him on the potential of Assam's agricultural sector

Over 700 peddlers arrested in Jammu's anti-drug crackdown

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

The ongoing anti-drug crackdown across Jammu division has yielded significant results, with more than 700 drug peddlers arrested and assets worth over ₹45 crore attached or demolished, an official said on Tuesday.

Authorities have also recovered large quantities of narcotics, dismantled drug trafficking networks and intensified rehabilitation efforts under the 'Nasha Mukh J-K Abhiyan' to curb the menace of substance abuse and promote a drug-free society, the official said.

He said the information was given at a meeting jointly chaired by Divisional Commissioner, Jammu,



Ramesh Kumar and Inspector General of Police, Jammu Zone, Bhim Sen Tuti to review the two-month progress of the 100-day anti-drug campaign in the region. The meeting was informed that a total of 598 FIRs were lodged against drug peddlers, in which 701 peddlers have been arrested to date, while 155 hotspots of drug activity were identified across Jammu, the spokesman said.

He said 24 PIT-NDPS detention orders were also issued against drug smugglers, with

recovery of large quantities of narcotics, including over 14 kg of heroin, 49 kg of ganja, 3,712 kg of charas and 204.5 kg of poppy straw.

Illicit crops, including poppy plants over 52 marlas (one marla = 272.251 sq feet), poppy straw weighing 25.43 kg, wild cannabis over 44 kanals (one kanal = 0.125 acres) and 476 litres of illegal liquor were also destroyed, the spokesman said.

As a measure of deterrence, he said 62 immovable properties of drug peddlers worth ₹19.30 crore have been demolished, while 21 immovable properties worth ₹24.868 crore have been seized or attached and movable properties worth ₹1.69 crore were also seized or attached.

Recitation of Hindu prayers made must in Chhattisgarh schools

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Raipur

The Chhattisgarh Government has mandated daily recitation of Gayatri Mantra and other Hindu prayers along with the national anthem and national song across all schools under its education department from the academic session 2026-27, officials said on Tuesday.

The direction to conduct a series of daily cultural, educational and value-based activities is aimed at fostering patriotism, promoting students' intellectual development and familiarising them with Indian culture and traditions, they said.

Opposition Congress questioned the need to make recitation of Hindu prayers compulsory in schools as students of other faiths also study there, and accused the BJP Government of trying to impose the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) agenda in schools. It also demanded withdrawal of the order.

The new academic session in the state commenced from Tuesday.

According to an order issued by the School Education Department to all District Education Officers (DEOs) on June 12, the schools will now conduct mandatory activities at

three different times during the day, a Government official said.

Under the new guidelines, the morning assembly will include the national anthem, national song, Deep Mantra, Saraswati Vandana, Guru Mantra and readings of biographies of great personalities, he said.

During the mid-day meal, students will collectively recite a food prayer (Bhojan Mantra), while the closing session at the end of the school day will include the state song, Gayatri Mantra and Shanti Mantra, he added.

The initiative is intended to foster patriotism, discipline, moral values and cultural awareness among students while strengthening their connection with Indian traditions and national ideals, he added.

The Government has directed the DEOs to ensure strict implementation of the order. Officials will conduct inspections of schools, and administrative action may be taken against school managements or principals found violating the prescribed guidelines, the official added.

Reacting to the decision, Chhattisgarh Congress communication department chairman Sushil Anand Shukla questioned the need to make religious chants compulsory in educational institutions.

Only 26% of rainfall in Maharashtra, Govt asks farmers not to rush sowing

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Maharashtra received only 26 per cent of its normal rainfall in the first half of June, prompting the Government to advise farmers “not to hurry” crop sowing, as per a crop situation review presented before the State Cabinet on Tuesday.

The State received 27.4 mm of rainfall from June 1 to June 15 against the normal rainfall of 103.8 mm.

The report stated that preparatory agricultural activities, including nursery raising for paddy and finger millet and pre-sowing field operations, are underway across the State.

“As rainfall is likely to remain weak till mid-June, instructions have been issued to farmers not to hurry with sowing operations,” the presentation noted.

The report said rainfall is expected to remain scattered over Konkan and parts of central Maharashtra, while Vidarbha and Marathwada are likely to witness improved rainfall activity from June 18 onwards.

Jharkhand Guv attends children's cultural programme in Dwarka



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Jharkhand Governor Santosh Gangwar attended a children's cultural programme organised by HamaraSamarpan Charitable Trust in Dwarka as the chief guest.

The event began with children welcoming the governor through patriotic songs and cultural performances. Addressing the gathering, Gangwar praised the trust's efforts in supporting persons with disabilities and the underprivileged sections of society. He emphasised the importance of quality education and healthcare for

children, saying these are essential for building a stronger future for the country.

The governor also lauded trustee Dr Sonia Rawat for her work towards women's empowerment and child welfare. Stressing the need to improve girls' education, he said educating young women would help them become self-reliant. He urged the organisation to expand its health and education awareness initiatives to rural areas of Jharkhand.

Certificates were distributed to children who excelled at the trust's training centre during the programme.



Editor's
TAKE

PM Modi's Slovakia visit:
Opening new frontiers

Modi's historic visit to Slovakia is a strategic signal that India's engagement with the world is growing wider, deeper and considerably more purposeful

When Prime Minister Modi stepped off the plane in Bratislava, the occasion was about far more than exchanging pleasantries across a negotiating table. It was about staking out a vision – of an India that is quietly but purposefully embedding itself into the sinews of European geopolitics, not through headline-grabbing rhetoric, but through the unglamorous yet essential work of building frameworks, forging alliances and finding common ground.

Upgrading India-Slovakia ties to a "Comprehensive Partnership" might look routine. It is not. For three decades, the two countries maintained a relationship that was perfectly pleasant and almost entirely unremarkable. What the Bratislava summit achieved was a fundamental transformation of that dynamic, replacing polite distance with purposeful proximity.

Defence cooperation, counter-terrorism, artificial intelligence, semiconductors, digital infrastructure, energy and labour migration – the breadth of agreements signed tells its own story. The decision to establish an ICCR Chair in Artificial Intelligence at the Technical University of Košice, the first such initiative anywhere in the world, is perhaps the clearest signal of all: this partnership is being built with its eyes firmly on tomorrow. The timing matters enormously. The visit came on the heels of the landmark India-EU trade deal, and both sides were candid about their intent to capitalise on it. Modi's acknowledgement that he would work towards the agreement's "earliest implementation" signals that India is serious about this relationship. Automotive manufacturing, electronics and advanced manufacturing have been identified as sectors ripe for collaboration. For too long, India's economic and strategic calculus has been concentrated around a narrow cluster of relationships – the United States, China, the Gulf and, to some extent, Russia. Each of these ties carries its own vulnerabilities, compounded by the volatility of an era defined by trade wars, geopolitical rivalry and the weaponisation of supply chains. Diversification is no longer a strategic luxury; it is a structural necessity. Europe, in this context, offers a compelling opportunity. The continent is itself reconfiguring – militarily, economically and politically. Central and Eastern European nations such as Slovakia are increasingly assertive members of the European Union, with growing industrial capacity, technological expertise and political influence.

Slovakia's reiteration of support for India's permanent membership of the UN Security Council and the Nuclear Suppliers Group reflects the kind of multilateral solidarity that India needs to build, brick by brick.

Modi's European tour underscores a calculated pattern. India is positioning itself as a pivotal power that refuses to be captured by any single camp. The joint condemnation of terrorism builds international consensus around India's security concerns. In India's emerging foreign policy arithmetic, every relationship adds to the sum of a larger ambition: India is not a supplicant to powerful nations but an independent, confident country charting its own course.

Media and the future of geostrategic communication

As narratives increasingly shape international perceptions, the most powerful voices will not necessarily be the loudest. Rather, enduring influence will belong to those that are credible, consistent and anchored in public confidence



CHAITANYA
K PRASAD

Conversations as part of narrative-building exercises in the geostrategic space are influenced by complex factors, identities and tools. In this day and age of instant communication, where ideas and views are churned out on a 24x7 basis, narrative-building and perception management suffer within the overall framework of consistency, authenticity and transparency. This is particularly relevant to the dissemination of information and messaging. Narrative-building today is viewed as a stepping stone for agenda management and power equations between nations, stakeholders and entities. The challenge before narrative-building in the geostrategic space is to wean itself off coercion disguised as influence through content, values, non-state stakeholders and compelling yet resonant tools and ideas.

A critical element in the ecosystem is the integration and interconnection between ideas, perception, storytelling, engagement and strategic messaging, and its relationship with the role of AI in driving the narrative ecosystem. In this algorithmic age, where tools drive and assess sentiments, moods and perceptions, narrative discourse has become increasingly obsessed with technology-driven ideas, integrated with complex and diverse stakeholders and the intense push of data-driven communication.

As a consequence, the geostrategic communication space today is witnessing narrative manipulation to suit particular nations, blocs, entities and national interests. The contours of the media space emerging from this narrative conflict reflect a tug of war between ideas, opinions, perspectives and algorithms, leading to a confusing media literacy environment within the communication space. As opinions change instantly, thanks to the information blitz, it is critical that the foundations of media literacy remain sound, deep, robust and stable. The ability to evaluate content objectively and access information through the prism of accuracy, credibility and trust must become central to the communication ecosystem. The media literacy ecosystem should distinguish information through facts, credible sources, responsible tools and strong media support structures.

The media literacy architecture is influenced by multiple narratives and instruments of information dissemination that shape the language and angles of public debate, views and perceptions. Today, media literacy is subject to multiple influences and perspectives. It must constantly contend with the power of ideas and concepts that continue to flow from stakeholders at all levels.



THE MEDIA
LITERACY
LANDSCAPE ALSO
FACES THE
CHALLENGES OF
COMMUNICATION
DIVERSITY,
PARTICIPATION,
TECHNOLOGY-
DRIVEN CONTENT,
MULTIMEDIA
MESSAGING AND
COMMUNICATION
SYMBOLISM

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SINCE 1865

Today, in the geopolitical space, there is an urgent need to balance communication contests that are taking place at different levels and serving several purposes. The challenge within the media literacy framework is to create proactive "communication understanding" between stakeholders, communication instruments, national priorities, audience perceptions, national image and identity, and emerging communication interpretations. One needs to understand that the communication order operates in a borderless world, wherein narrative-building techniques are strategically positioned to influence viewpoints, communication outreach, resources, campaigns, and emerging collaborations and partnerships. Hence, in 2026, it is critical that media literacy frameworks reinforce the foundations of communication coherence, understanding and appeal.

At the same time, the idea of national image has become far more layered than before. It is no longer shaped only by official statements, diplomatic exchanges, press briefings or institutional communication. It is also shaped by clips, memes, influencers, explainers, podcasts, digital campaigns and citizen-led conversations. A single image, phrase, headline or edited video can travel faster than a formal clarification. This has made strategic communication more immediate, but also more vulnerable. In the geostrategic space, perception often moves ahead of policy explanations. Therefore, communication systems must not merely react to narratives after they have gained momentum. They must be designed to anticipate, interpret and respond with clarity, credibility and speed.

This is where media literacy becomes more than a civic skill. It becomes a strategic necessity. A society that can distinguish between information, misinformation, disinformation and propaganda is better placed to protect its democratic discourse and national interests. Similarly, institutions that understand the emotional, cultural and technological behav-

iour of audiences can communicate more responsibly. The goal is not only to counter falsehoods, but also to create trust-based communication ecosystems where facts are accessible, public reasoning is encouraged and informed participation is strengthened.

The growing role of artificial intelligence adds another layer to this challenge. AI tools can assist in translation, outreach, sentiment mapping, content creation and audience analysis. However, the same tools can also be used to manufacture synthetic realities through deepfakes, automated propaganda, manipulated visuals, fake amplification and targeted psychological messaging. The future of geostrategic communication will therefore depend on how societies build ethical safeguards around technology. Algorithms cannot be allowed to become invisible editors of public perception without accountability. Transparency on digital platforms, responsible AI use, verification protocols and institutional preparedness will be central to protecting the information space.

The critical idea within the media literacy architecture is to design a process that understands and interprets the communication ecosystem. In the age of instant communication, a robust media literacy process will ensure a level playing field and ward off misinformation, manipulation and information malpractice. It is the strong foundation of media literacy that will prevent fakery, fake news and deliberate propaganda. As media platforms become increasingly diverse and complex, it is critical to design a process that consumes content through the checks and balances of the media dissemination framework.

It is a reality today that every individual is a citizen journalist. Each person is a source of dissemination, interpretation, evaluation and response. The gateway for consuming and processing information is circuitous, complex and accessible on a 24x7 basis.

This gateway must empower every individual with the skills to access, analyse, process, evaluate and participate in communication discourse. The challenge, therefore, is to connect with the core message, understand it and interpret it effectively.

The media literacy landscape also faces the challenges of communication diversity, participation, technology-driven content, multimedia messaging and communication symbolism. A robust media literacy framework must also address communication fabrication, including fake news, manipulated images, deepfakes, statistical distortion and algorithm-driven influence. Going forward, the strength of any communication ecosystem will depend on how effectively it can combine speed with responsibility, influence with ethics, and technology with trust. In the geostrategic space, the most powerful narratives will not merely be the loudest or fastest, but the most credible, consistent and rooted in public confidence.

PIC TALK



Classical shehnai player Pandit Mahendra Prasanna and fellow musicians perform Raag Megh while standing in the Ganga at Tulsi Ghat in Varanasi. PHOTO: PTI

Can we truly understand another generation?



SHARMILA
VAIDYA

2ND OPINION

I often heard terms like Baby Boomers, Gen X, Millennials, etc. used in everyday conversations, especially by younger people. To be honest, I did not know much about these terms or pay much attention to them. One day, out of curiosity, I decided to look into them.

I discovered that these labels refer to groups of people born within a span of roughly 15 to 18 years. Each of these periods, or generations, is associated with similar social trends, value systems, technology, culture and other characteristics unique to that period of time. Baby Boomers were people born between 1946 and 1964. They grew up in the post-World War II period and witnessed significant political unrest, as well as economic and social change.

Gen X, born between 1965 and 1980, served as a bridge between the traditional world of their parents and the

digital world of their children. Similarly, all the other generations had their own unique trends and changes that defined them, whether Millennials, Gen Z or the latest one, Gen Alpha.

I also found that these categorisations originated in the United States and later spread throughout the world because of social media, technology and globalisation.

As I explored these generations, I began to wonder whether these labels were truly meaningful. To find out, I conducted an informal survey targeting both older and younger adults. It was interesting to note that most people over sixty saw these groups as stereotypes that failed to recognise individuality. Some felt it made more sense to divide time into broad periods such as the World War era, the age of computers, mobile phones and AI, or even into decades such as the 1950s, 1960s and 1970s. The younger generation, however, was more accepting of these labels. There was a general consensus that grouping people into different generations was important. It helped explain how people from one generation differed from those of another with respect to education, technology, lifestyle and social values.

According to these labels, I would be classified as Gen X. Looking back, some of the major events that influenced my life were the war with Pakistan, the Emergency period and the assassination of our then Prime Minister, Indira Gandhi. I also witnessed the arrival of computers, cable television and later smartphones.

Life seemed simpler, yet it was also a period of rapid social and technological change. I remember the excitement of watching television and the thrill of flying for the first time. The impact of those experiences shaped my value system and influenced the person I am today.

However, the main question is whether these categorisations are meaningful and useful in helping us understand people better. Do the events and changes people experience during their formative years help shape their outlook on life? As parents, can we truly comprehend the experiences and struggles our children face today?

Can we appreciate the pressures of social media, the demands of a rapidly changing world and the emotional stresses they encounter daily? As we counsel and advise them based on our own experiences, are we helping them or unintentionally adding to their struggles? Can we truly stand in their shoes and see the world through their eyes?

Maybe these labels are worthwhile after all. They not only define generations but also offer a glimpse into the world that shaped them. If they help us better understand the experiences, pressures and struggles faced by our children, they may also encourage us to listen more and judge less quickly. Only then can we truly appreciate the challenges faced by each generation.

The writer is an educator based in the US and the author of children's books

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INDIA WATCHES US-IRAN
PEACE DEAL WITH CAUTION

The agreement between the United States and Iran offers a timely respite from tensions that have unsettled global markets.

For India, the prospect of eased sanctions, the release of frozen Iranian assets and the reopening of the Strait of Hormuz are welcome developments. Stable oil prices and renewed momentum for the Chabahar port project matter far more than diplomatic symbolism.

At the same time, caution is warranted. As the editorial correctly notes, this remains a memorandum of understanding rather than a final peace treaty. Important issues, including Iran's missile programme and regional influence, remain outside the current framework.

Israeli reservations and the

long history of failed agreements underline the uncertainties ahead. With sixty days of further negotiations still to come, significant obstacles remain.

India's response should remain practical and measured. New Delhi has successfully maintained relations with both Washington and Tehran, and this balancing act remains essential. Strengthening energy security, accelerating Chabahar-linked infrastructure and enhancing cooperation with Gulf partners will help minimise risks should the current respite prove temporary.

The June 19 signing in Switzerland should therefore be viewed with cautious optimism as a pragmatic, interest-driven approach will serve India better.

K SHAKUNTHALA | COIMBATORE

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Choosing diplomacy over escalation

The announcement of a US-Iran peace deal offers a much-needed respite to a world fatigued by conflict and uncertainty. For months, the confrontation threatened regional stability, disrupted energy supplies and sent shockwaves through global markets. The decision to prioritise diplomacy over military escalation is therefore both prudent and timely.

History has repeatedly shown that wars may achieve short-term objectives, but lasting peace can emerge only through dialogue and mutual accommodation. The challenge now lies in translating this agreement into durable trust. Deep-seated differences over nuclear issues, regional influence and security concerns remain unresolved and will require patient negotiations.

For countries such as India, peace in West Asia is particularly important. Millions of Indians live and work in the Gulf region, and any disruption in the Strait of Hormuz directly affects energy prices and economic stability. A reduction in tensions will benefit not only the region but also the global economy.

The road ahead for Washington and Tehran will undoubtedly be difficult. Yet, by choosing negotiation over confrontation, both sides have created an opportunity that must not be squandered.

VANDANA CHOPRA | CHANDIGARH

Time to cut fuel prices

The reopening of the Strait of Hormuz is welcome news for India, which depends on Gulf sources for more than 85 per cent of its crude oil requirements. However, the transmission of lower global crude prices into reduced retail fuel prices is neither automatic nor immediate. Oil Marketing Companies have been absorbing losses for months, and the government is unlikely to pass on relief until those losses are partly recovered.

Indian consumers are familiar with this pattern. Fuel prices rise quickly when crude oil becomes expensive, but reductions are often delayed or only partially passed on. The ceasefire presents an opportunity to correct this imbalance, but doing so will require a deliberate policy decision rather than passive market adjustment. A phased reduction in petrol, diesel and LPG prices over the coming months, linked transparently to import costs, would be fiscally manageable and economically beneficial. Lower fuel prices reduce input costs across agriculture, logistics and manufacturing, easing pressure on households and businesses alike. The government should seize this opportunity rather than defer action until political considerations make it more convenient.

S M JEEVA | CHENNAI

Heritage deserves honest representation

NCERT's decision to restore the original image of the iconic Dancing Girl figurine from Mohenjo-daro in its Class 9 Arts textbook is a welcome correction. The earlier publication of a modified, clothed version drew widespread criticism from scholars and educators, who argued that it distorted an important part of India's cultural heritage.

The bronze figurine, dating to around 2600 BCE, is one of the most celebrated artefacts of the Indus Valley Civilisation. The altered image obscured anatomical details present in the original sculpture and stood in contrast to more accurate depictions already included in NCERT textbooks. Educational institutions have a responsibility to present historical and archaeological material faithfully. Attempts to modify artefacts in the name of appropriateness risk undermining authenticity and weakening students' understanding of the past. While NCERT's reversal deserves recognition, the episode highlights a broader challenge within education: balancing cultural sensitivities with historical accuracy. Lessons should be grounded in evidence rather than excessive censorship. Only then can students engage meaningfully with India's rich and diverse heritage.

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

Narendra Modi and the longevity of leadership in a nation of 1.4 billion

In the arena of global politics, navigating the democratic gauntlet of the world’s most populous nation for more than twelve uninterrupted years is not merely a feat of longevity; it reflects an extraordinary degree of enduring public trust and political dexterity



HEMANGI SINHA

June 10, 2026, marks a watershed moment in the history of global democracy. Completing exactly 4,399 consecutive days in office, Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi has officially become the longest-continuously serving elected Prime Minister in the nation’s history. In doing so, he surpasses a six-decade-old record held by India’s foundational Prime Minister, Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru, whose post-independence elected streak concluded at 4,398 days.

While political longevity is often calculated in simple mathematical tallies, evaluating leadership durability requires examining it through a comparative lens alongside a critical geopolitical variable: the scale of the populace. When longevity is weighed against demographic weight, a stark reality emerges. Narendra Modi stands as the longest-serving democratically elected head of government of a large country anywhere in the world today.

The illusions of scale: Small states vs demographic giants
Political history is replete with long-serving leaders, but context matters deeply.

Lee Kuan Yew, the founding father of modern Singapore governed seamlessly for 31 consecutive years from 1959-1990 as their first Prime Minister. Yet, during his foundational years, Singapore’s population hovered between 1.5 million and 3 million people, essentially a highly manageable, concentrated city-state. Sheikh Hasina governed Bangladesh and commanded the legislative architecture of her country for over 20 cumulative years including an uninterrupted run from 2009 until her resignation in August 2024. She led a country wherein most people spoke Bengali language with much less regional and ethnic variation in contrast to India. While navigating a highly complex country of 170 million, the administrative and geographic perimeter of Bangladesh remained localized compared to the subcontinental entity. Paul Biya has served as the President of Cameroon governing the three-crore population since November 6, 1982. While Cameroon holds elections, his longevity in power is often described by political scientists as autocratic rather than strictly representative. Teodoro Obiang Nguema Mbasogo from Equatorial Guinea in Central Africa has been the longest consecutively serving President since August 1979 for a small country of around 2 million people. As claimed, his elections have a mere cosmetic cover and beneath the façade, the sole power remains in his hands. The analytical and a global comparative implication thus ascertain maintaining democratic electoral process while staying the majority leader is a noteworthy epoch.

To govern a highly centralised, ethnically homogeneous or geographically compact state for decades is an exercise of elite administrative management. To do the same in a subcontinental nation of 1.46 billion people is an entirely different operational matrix.

The math of subcontinental pluralism
Governing contemporary India is equivalent to administering the entire European Union, the United States, Russia and South America combined and not just in raw numbers, but in sheer systemic friction. The scale of present Indian Democratic Governance stands at a growing population of roughly 1.47 billion that accounts for 18 per cent of the global population with the largest electorate of 960 million choosing representatives for 543 constituencies. Presently, India demarcates 28 States & 8 UTs within its territory and the political circuit has around 6 national parties, approximately 60 state parties and numerous registered unrecognized political parties that face continuous localized elections, unrestricted digital scrutiny, access and deep cultural-ideological pluralism.

Unlike single-party state models such as China under President Xi Jinping, whose tenure relies on an all-encompassing party apparatus, India’s system is a hyper-competitive, round-the-clock electoral cauldron. Since 2014, the current administration has had to navigate several concerns starting from Continuous Electoral Volatility as India is in a perpetual state of election cycles. A premier must win not just national mandates (such as the historic consecutive terms of 2014, 2019, and 2024), but also manage high-stakes state assembly elections occurring multiple times every single year.



Secondly, Hyper-Fragmented Political Landscapes affects the turnouts as well, moving past the one-party dominance of the early post-independence era, modern India features distinct active political contest, deep-seated regional assertions and aspirations, contrasting demands and complex coalition arithmetic, all of which has to be dealt with nuanced negotiations without compromising the integrity of the nation.

Thirdly, the Digital Panopticon of this century pose unprecedented challenges. Unlike the legacy leaders of the 20th century who governed without private television networks or instant digital communication, contemporary governance unfolds under the immediate, unfiltered gaze of over 800 million smartphone users and globalised social media ecosystems. The digital revolution has its multidimensional facets, so the impact it has on the political process is phenomenal.

Shift from survival to delivery
What makes this 12-year-and-15-day milestone textually significant to political scientists is that the survival of the executive has not resulted in policy paralysis. Frequently, long-serving leaders often become desperate to just hold onto power, without divulging into significant policy changes. This desperation typically causes them to ruin the economy, impose emergency, suspend civil rights, imprison opposition leaders and attack democratic institutions, as political history dictates. However, Narendra Modi avoided that trap, maintaining a stable democracy while successfully passing major structural laws.

Over the last 4,399 days, India has undergone a massive transformation through its Digital Public Infrastructure with the massive interconnected identity and economic frameworks wherein 138.34 crore Aadhaar numbers have been generated integrated with banking frameworks and targeted welfare schemes as Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY) spans over 58.3 crore accounts, as official data suggests. These accounts secure over ₹3 lakh crore in collective deposits. Women make up over 32 crores of these accounts, with the vast majority serving rural and semi-urban population, uplifting over 23 crore citizens from multidimensional poverty.

Reforms like GST has integrated the market, Direct Benefit Transfers system tied to Aadhaar and mobiles enables the Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) ecosystem to instantly channel subsidies to beneficiaries without the middlemen, reducing leakages. Furthermore, Jan Dhan accounts brought half a billion unbanked citizens into the financial system. Unified Payments Interface captures nearly 49 per cent of global real-time payments. UPI processed 24,162 crore transactions valued at over ₹314 lakh crore during the financial year 2025-26 alone. Digi Locker facilitates paperless verification for over 37 crore users, hosting upwards of 776 crore authentic digital documents. Globally, Prime Minister Modi championed the Global South by inducting 1.5 billion people of all the 55 member countries of the African Union into the G20 in Delhi and has received a record number of international awards. The policy growth thus has a consensus with the upcoming digital advancement and the 3.0 world.

The verdict of history
Every democracy features a natural shelf-life for its leadership; voter fatigue, anti-incumbency and internal contradictions that typically erode a leader’s political capital within a decade.

As the National Democratic Alliance celebrates this milestone, the statistics serve as a reminder of an underlying truth: in the arena of global politics, surviving the democratic gauntlet of the world’s most populous nation for over twelve unbroken years is not merely a record of longevity. It is a testament to an unprecedented scale of sustained public trust and targeted policy manoeuvre.

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A gathering beyond the vocabulary of politics



PHIRMI BODO

The recent Janajati Samagam convened at the historic Red Fort in Delhi was far more than a routine socio-political congregation. It constituted a profound civilisational moment—a collective act of remembrance, reflection and reaffirmation. Bringing together lakhs of Janajati representatives, scholars, cultural practitioners, spiritual custodians and community leaders from across Bharat, the gathering transcended the immediate concerns of policy and governance. It sought instead to rekindle an enduring conversation about memory, faith, identity and the cultural foundations of the nation.

Among the many issues deliberated upon, one demand acquired particular prominence: the call for the delisting of those who have embraced non-indigenous religions from the Scheduled Tribe category. Predictably, much of the public discourse that followed reduced the issue to the language of electoral arithmetic, affirmative action and political contestation. Such interpretations, however, remain profoundly inadequate. They fail to engage with the deeper philosophical anxieties and civilisational concerns that animate the demand.

At stake is not merely a question of constitutional entitlement. The debate touches upon far more enduring concerns: the preservation of indigenous worldviews, the continuity of ancestral memory and the future of cultural traditions that have shaped the civilisational landscape of Bharat for millennia. Contemporary discourse often situates tribal communities at the margins of history and society. Such a characterisation is not only historically inaccurate but also conceptually impoverished. Janajati communities have never been peripheral to the civilisational experience of Bharat. Rather, they have served as some of its most enduring custodians. Across forests, mountains, hills, river valleys and ecological frontiers, indigenous communities nurtured sophisticated systems of knowledge concerning governance, agriculture, medicine, ecological stewardship and spirituality long before the emergence of modern, Western-centric institutions and written archives. These traditions survived through oral transmission, ritual performance, collective memory and inherited cultural practice. The Janajati worldview is distinguished by an ontological orientation fundamentally different from that of Western industrial societies. Human beings are not conceived as sovereign masters of nature but as participants within a larger cosmic order. Rivers are revered as living presences, forests as sacred abodes and hills as repositories of ancestral memory. Embedded within these traditions is an ethic of reciprocity, restraint and ecological harmony that contemporary societies increasingly seek to recover under the language of sustainability and environmental ethics.

It is therefore no exaggeration to suggest that the civilisational conscience of Bharat continues to find expression within its Janajati communities. They remain living repositories of memories that predate colonial modernity, preserving cultural inheritances that have endured across centuries.

One of the most persistent misconceptions in contemporary discussions on tribal societies is the tendency to separate religion from culture. Such distinctions emerge from intellectual traditions in which religion is primarily understood as adherence to doctrine, scripture or ecclesiastical authority. Indigenous societies operate according to an entirely different philosophical grammar. For Janajati communities, faith is not a compartmentalised sphere of existence; it is an embodied mode of being in the world. It finds expression in sacred groves, seasonal festivals, ancestral commemorations and community rituals. The sacred is not external to life; it permeates life itself.

A forest may remain protected because it is understood as the dwelling place of ancestral spirits. A harvest festival is an affirmation of the interdependence between humanity, nature and the transcendent. This integrated worldview resonates with the broader Indic understanding of reality, which similarly refuses rigid separations between the sacred and the secular. Both traditions emphasise harmony over domination, duty over entitlement and relational existence over atomised individualism. Janajati traditions therefore represent one of the most ancient and enduring currents within the larger civilisational continuum of Bharat. The demand for delisting must be situated within this broader philosophical context. Beneath the legal and constitutional dimensions of the debate lies a more fundamental question: What precisely is being protected through the constitutional recognition accorded to Scheduled Tribes? If such recognition is understood solely as a mechanism for addressing material disadvantage, then cultural and religious transformation may appear largely irrelevant. However, if constitutional safeguards also carry the responsibility of preserving distinctive indigenous cultures, social institutions and worldviews, the matter assumes a very different significance.

Many tribal organisations contend that religious conversion frequently entails more than a change in theological affiliation. It often initiates a gradual process of cultural displacement, weakening ancestral traditions, customary institutions and indigenous cosmologies. The central question is not whether individuals possess the freedom to choose their faith—a principle guaranteed within a democratic society—but whether constitutional provisions intended to safeguard indigenous cultural traditions can remain detached from the preservation of those traditions themselves.

In this sense, the debate over delisting is not merely administrative. It is fundamentally a debate about civilisational continuity, cultural inheritance and the future of indigenous knowledge systems within Bharat. It compels Bharat to confront a larger civilisational question: how can a nation preserve the cultural traditions and worldviews of its indigenous communities while remaining faithful to the principles of justice and constitutional equality?

The concerns articulated at the Janajati Samagam are not unique to Bharat. Across the world, indigenous communities face mounting pressures from religious conversion, Western ideology and cultural homogenisation. The Samagam serves as a reminder that the future of Bharat cannot be disentangled from the future of its indigenous communities. To safeguard the Janajati is not merely to protect a demographic category; it is to preserve a civilisational inheritance. For when the oldest custodians of memory disappear, nations lose fragments of their civilisational soul.



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The Pioneer

Vehicle taxation can be an effective policy lever to control pollution



KUSHAN MITRA

GST structure on vehicles is far more sensible than pretending every technology deserves the same treatment. The tax system should reward the vehicles that pollute less in the real world, not the ones that merely look cleaner on a certification sheet.

That is the core problem with the current debate. We keep talking about electric vehicles as though they are the only answer, hybrids as though they are a compromise, and conventional vehicles as though they are the enemy. Reality is messier. India is not going to jump from a fossil-fuel-dependent fleet to a fully electric one overnight. Nor should policy pretend otherwise. What the country needs is a tax framework that recognises the transition, accelerates the cleanest options, and stops rewarding high-emitting vehicles with the same fiscal generosity as cleaner ones.

The European Union already understands this logic. Across Europe, vehicle taxation is routinely linked to emissions, especially carbon dioxide. According to the European Automobile Manufacturers' Association, 24 EU member states levy car taxes partially or totally based on CO2 emis-

sions and/or fuel consumption. That does not mean Europe has found a perfect formula. But it does mean it has accepted a principle India still hesitates to embrace. Several European countries have taken this approach in practical, not ideological, ways. France uses a malus system that penalises higher-emission vehicles at the point of registration. The Netherlands has long linked car taxation to environmental performance. Ireland and Spain, too, have used emissions-based structures in registration and annual taxation. The details differ, but the principle is consistent: taxation can be used to nudge the market toward cleaner choices.

India should take that lesson seriously, especially now that its own regulatory framework is tightening. The next phase of corporate fuel economy norms, CAFE-III, is expected to push fleet-average CO2 emissions sharply lower over the coming years. Draft proposals and recent reporting indicate that the regime may begin around April 2027 and extend through March 2032, with much tougher fleet-average targets than earlier norms. That matters because CAFE-III will force manufacturers to think harder about efficiency, electrification and mass reduction. But regulation alone is only half the story. Taxation has to pull in the same direction. That is where a graded GST system makes sense. Start with the lowest possible baseline for zero-emission battery electric vehicles and hydrogen vehicles. Then move upward through plug-in hybrids, strong hybrids, efficient petrol vehicles and, eventually, the highest rates for the most polluting vehicles. The sequence should be transparent



and rational.

The key, though, is that emissions cannot be measured on carbon alone. CO2 matters for climate, and there is no point pretending otherwise. But urban air quality is shaped just as much by nitrogen oxides, particulates, carbon monoxide and unburnt hydrocarbons. A car that looks respectable on a CO2 metric can still be quite damaging in the conditions in which Indian vehicles actually operate. That is why the tax conversation has to broaden beyond carbon.

This is also why real-world testing must be central. Laboratory certification is useful, but it is not enough. Vehicles behave differently in congestion, in hot weather, on poor roads, during repeated accelerations and braking, and across mixed driving cycles. If India wants a credible graded tax system, it cannot rely only on a test cycle that manufacturers can optimise around. It needs a metric that reflects actual use. Indian roads are not European roads. A policy that works on paper but fails in traffic is not policy; it is theatre.

If the government is going to link GST rates to emissions, then those emissions should be measured in a way that captures real-world performance, not merely laboratory compliance.

The beauty of a graded GST framework is that it would create a clear market signal without needing constant administrative improvisation. Buyers would know exactly what they are being rewarded for. Manufacturers would know exactly what they need to improve. And the state would stop pretending that all “clean” vehicles are equally clean. A plug-in hybrid that is regularly charged and driven mostly on electricity is one thing. A large hybrid that quietly relies on its petrol engine most of the time is another. A battery EV or hydrogen vehicle with no tailpipe emissions is in a different category altogether. Tax policy should reflect those distinctions, not flatten them.

It would also avoid one of India’s recurring policy mistakes: treating technology labels as moral categories. The problem with that approach is that it ignores usage. An EV charged on a coal-heavy grid still needs a careful policy framework, even if its tailpipe is clean. A hybrid may be far better than a conventional petrol car in the near term. A plug-in hybrid may be a sensible bridge technology. None of these realities fit neatly into the simplistic language of winners and losers. A graded tax structure is much better suited to the real transition India is undergoing. There is also fiscal logic here. India cannot afford to give away revenue without a rationale, especially when road transport imposes huge public costs through pollution, congestion and health damage. If the tax system

is going to forgo revenue on one class of vehicles, it should do so because those vehicles are delivering demonstrably cleaner outcomes. That is why the baseline for zero-emission vehicles should be the lowest, but not because they are fashionable. It should be low because they impose far less local pollution. The same logic should apply, in descending order, to hydrogen, plug-in hybrids, strong hybrids and efficient combustion vehicles.

The temptation in Delhi is always to believe that the next policy announcement will solve everything. It will not. But a graded GST system, tied to real-world emissions and not just carbon, would at least be a serious attempt to align tax policy with environmental reality. It would acknowledge that climate and air quality are related but not identical problems. It would recognise that the transition to cleaner mobility has stages. And it would reward the vehicles that actually help, rather than those that merely sound progressive. If India wants to clean its air without distorting its market, it should stop thinking about vehicle taxation as a blunt revenue tool. Tax the polluter more. Tax the cleaner vehicle less. Measure emissions honestly. Include NOx and particulates, not just CO2. And build the structure so that the cleanest vehicles begin with the lowest GST rate and the dirtier ones climb progressively higher. That is not radical. It is simply the minimum standard of common sense.

The writer is Director and the Printer & Publisher of The Pioneer

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 Order Order

SC refuses to entertain plea on urban infra around airports

The Supreme Court on Tuesday refused to entertain a plea seeking regulations to control urban infrastructure around airports, which referred to last year's Air India plane crash in Ahmedabad that killed 241 people on board and 19 doctors and students of a medical college, which was the site of impact.

Refusing to entertain the petition filed by Shakil Sheikh through advocate Laxmikant Matadan Shukla, a bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice V Mohana said the issue pertained to policy.

Shukla, appearing for the petitioner, contended that there is infrastructure hazard in and around airports across the country, as there are no regulations to control the growth of urban infrastructure.

He referred to the Air India AI171 crash that killed a total of 260 people on June 12 last year, and said that 19 doctors and students of the BJ Medical College lost their lives as it was the point of impact.

He sought directions to the Centre and other concerned departments for the formulation of regulations to control urban infrastructure in and around airports.

CJI Kant told the counsel that the court was not inclined to entertain the petition as it was purely a policy matter, and asked him whether he would like to withdraw the plea.

(PTI)

Mamata moves HC against poll defeat in Bhabanipur



Trinamool Congress chief Mamata Banerjee on Tuesday filed an election petition before the Calcutta High Court, challenging the poll result in the Bhabanipur assembly seat she lost to BJP's Suvendu Adhikari.

Adhikari defeated Banerjee by a margin of 15,105 votes in the seat held by her.

TMC sources said that Banerjee went to the high court registry to "affirm" the petition challenging the result.

Counting of votes of the West Bengal assembly election was held on May 4.

After the BJP's resounding win in the West Bengal Assembly polls, Adhikari went on to become the first BJP chief minister of the state.

(PTI)

Delhi court denies bail to man accused of exploiting woman

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court has denied anticipatory bail to a man accused of establishing physical relations with a woman after luring her under the false promise of marriage, noting that he addressed the victim as "future wifey" to take her consent.

Additional Sessions Judge Hargurvirinder Singh Jaggi was hearing the plea filed by Satish Kumar, who has been accused of luring a Kerala-based woman on the pretext of marriage and establishing physical relations with her.

In the order dated June 9, the court said, "Considering the grave nature of the allegations, the evasive and absconding conduct of the applicant, and the imminent necessity of his custodial interrogation for the recovery of digital evidence and medical examination, shielding him with pre-arrest bail would severely prejudice the ongoing investigation." According to the prosecution, the complainant, a 23-year-old cybersecurity professional from Kerala, came into contact with the accused through a matrimonial portal.

She alleged that Kumar persuaded her to travel to Delhi with assurances of marriage and that the two lived together at an Airbnb accommodation in Chhatrapur for about 19 days. An FIR was reg-



istered against the accused under BNS sections 69 (sexual intercourse by deceitful means) and 351 (criminal intimidation). The woman alleged that the accused had established physical relations with her on the promise of marriage but later abruptly stopped communicating, blocked her and disappeared.

Opposing the bail plea, the prosecution argued that custodial interrogation was necessary to recover electronic evidence and examine the digital trail of communications between the parties.

The defence argued that the relationship was consensual and that the complainant had falsely implicated the accused after the relationship broke. It also claimed that the woman had concealed details of an earlier domestic relationship.

The court noted that the parties admittedly met online, stayed together in Delhi and had a physical relationship, though they differed on whether the intimacy was based on a



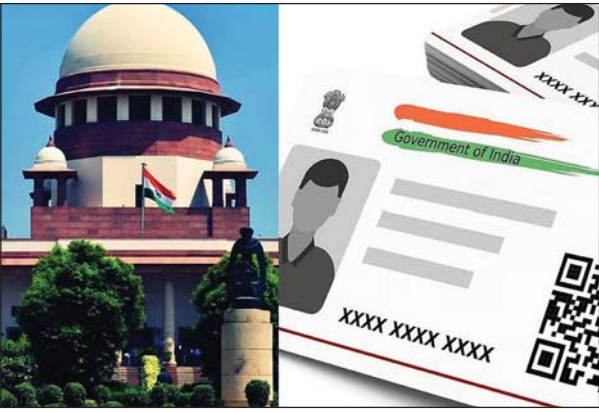
SC seeks Centre, States' response on Aadhaar as identity proof

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Tuesday sought response of the Centre and States on a plea alleging misuse of the Unique Identification Authority of India-issued Aadhaar cards as proof of citizenship, domicile and residential address, and seeking directions to restrict its use strictly for identity verification.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice V Mohana issued notices to the Centre and all the states and UTs on a plea filed by advocate Ashwini Kumar Upadhyay and tagged it with the pending similar matters.

The plea has sought directions to the Centre, states and the Election Commission to ensure that Aadhaar is used as a proof of identity and not as a proof of citizenship, domicile, address and date of birth.



The plea, filed through advocate Ashwani Dubey, also sought directions that the use of Aadhaar as a proof of date of birth and residence in the application form for new voter registration be considered against Section 9 of the Aadhaar Act, 2016, Section 23(4) of the RPA, 1950 and Article 14 of the Constitution.

"Section 9 of the Aadhaar Act, 2016 expressly states

that 'Aadhaar is not the evidence of citizenship or domicile'. The Unique Identification Authority of India notification dated August 22, 2023 clearly states that 'Aadhaar is proof of identity, not of citizenship, address or date of birth'...

"Despite this, Aadhaar is not only being used as a proof of age, citizenship and domicile for school admission, property purchase and

to obtain a birth certificate, ration card, driving licence but also being used in the application form for new voter registration (Form-6) as a proof of date of birth and proof of residence. And thus, infiltrators and illegal immigrants are obtaining various documents using Aadhaar," the plea said.

The petition contended that the existing verification mechanism under Form-6 is inadequate and might allow individuals without proper supporting documents to be included in the electoral database.

The plea sought a comprehensive overhaul of the verification framework used in electoral processes and proposed the establishment of a high-powered monitoring committee comprising a retired Supreme Court judge along with cybersecurity and forensic experts to oversee reforms.

Orissa HC asks DGP to ensure police stations carry out orders of magistrates

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Cuttack

The Orissa High Court has asked the Director General of Police (DGP) to ensure that police stations across the state properly carry out orders of magistrates and judicial officers in different matters so that litigants do not approach the higher court complaining about police inaction.

The direction was issued by Justice Savitri Ratho on June 12 while disposing of a petition filed by a 65-year-old scheduled caste woman who alleged that she had been cheated of ₹2.10 lakh by persons who had promised to sell her land through a registered sale deed, but neither did they execute the deed nor return the money.

Regarding the case, the aggrieved woman petitioner had approached the JMFC (judicial magistrate, first class), Ranpur, on August 6, 2025, who directed the police to register an FIR and investigate the matter. However, despite repeated hearings and reminders from the court, the police did not respond for about eight months, forcing her to move the HC seeking intervention.

During the hearing, the state informed the HC that the matter was under inves-



tigation after registration of a case by Ranpur police station on April 24, 2026.

However, Justice Savitri Ratho expressed concern and sought an explanation from the inspector-in-charge (IIC) of the police station, Ranpur, for the prolonged delay. The IIC, on the other hand, informed that the JMFC's order, received on August 6, 2025, was "misplaced" at the police station. He also tendered an unconditional apology and assured the court of future diligence.

The HC, however, did not accept it lightly.

"Such excuses are not

acceptable as different registers are maintained in the police station in respect of letters/orders/NBW's received from different authorities/courts," the judgment said.

The HC further noted that, unfortunately, this is not a stray case. "I have dealt with several writ applications (CRLMPs-Criminal Miscellaneous Petition) where the grievance of the petitioner is that the orders passed or directions issued by magistrates or judges of the Family Court are not being complied with by the local police, in spite of several

adjournments and reminders.

The stock excuse of the IICs in such cases is that the file/order/NBW/got misplaced, and in a few cases that the incumbent joined recently."

Justice Ratho noted that non-compliance with judicial directions leads to repeated adjournments in trial courts and compels litigants to approach the HC for relief.

"This unnecessary burden contributes to the growing number of criminal miscellaneous petitions alleging police inaction," she observed.

"Therefore, it has become necessary to direct the Director General of Police to ensure that Superintendents of Police/Commissioners instruct the IICs of the police stations under their jurisdiction, to and carry out the orders/directions of the magistrates and other judicial officers, so that the litigants do not flood the High Court with CRLMPs complaining about inaction of the local police," the order said.

It is expected that the Director General of Police will issue necessary instructions and directions to the officers to respond to and comply with judicial orders and directions, the order stated.

SC directs Tripura SEC to conduct polls to village committees



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Tuesday directed the Tripura State Election Commission to conduct elections to the village committees under the Tripura Tribal Areas Autonomous District Council in a single phase on September 27.

The direction by a bench of justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi came after Attorney General R Venkataramani, appearing for Tripura SEC, suggested conducting the entire election in a single phase.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the state government, agreed with Attorney General's submission.

"I am in complete agreement with the election commission. It would be better if it's completed on one phase. You will not have to spare more security forces," the bench said.

The top court noted in its order, "As the parties are in substantial agreement and the difference between the proposed dates is merely one month, we direct that the elections to the Village Committees be conducted in terms of the election schedule proposed in... the affidavit."

"Respondents and all authorities shall make earliest endeavours to abide by the schedule and to conclude the election process. No further extension shall be granted," the bench said in its order.

The top court was hearing a plea filed by Tipra Motha Party founder Pradyot Deb Burman alleging failure of authorities to conduct elections. Burman has sought directions to the Election Commission and Tripura SEC to immediately conduct overdue village committee elections under the Tripura Tribal Areas Automatic District Council Act, 1994.

SC reconstitutes panel on gender sensitisation

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court has reconstituted its Gender Sensitisation and Internal Complaints Committee.

The 12-member committee is being headed by top court judge B V Nagarathna, who is the chairperson.

"In exercise of powers conferred by Clause 4(2) of the Gender Sensitisation & Sexual Harassment of Women at the Supreme Court of India (Prevention, Prohibition & Redressal) Regulations, 2013 and all enabling provisions in this behalf, Hon'ble the Chief Justice of India has been pleased to re-constitute the Supreme Court Gender Sensitization and Internal Complaints Committee," an office order said.

The panel also comprises Justice Nongmeikapam Kotiswar Singh, Registrar Kaveri and senior advo-



cates Menaka Guruswamy and Liz Mathew besides advocates Nina Gupta, Soumyajit Pani, Sakshi Banga, Prabha Swami and Maheravish Rein.

The other members are — Sushma Rawat, who is representative of the Supreme Court Bar Clerks Association and Sneh Sharma, founder of Vividhta Consulting.

No bail for man accused of raping model

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thane

The sessions court in Thane has rejected the bail application of a 27-year-old man accused of raping a model and refused to entertain a "compromise" affidavit submitted by the survivor to save her imminent marriage, noting the offence is not compoundable, and the investigation is underway.

The copy of the order, passed by Additional Sessions Judge P.V. Ghule on June 9, was made available on June 15. The accused, identified as Akshaykumar Kantilal Jain who hails from Surat, was arrested on April 25 by the Kashmirira Police in Thane under sections 64 (rape) and

351(2) (criminal intimidation) of the Bharatiya Nyay Sanhita (BNS), the prosecution said.

The 26-year-old complainant, a professional model originally from Punjab, alleged that Jain lured her from Goa to a hotel in Mira Road on the pretext of an acting audition, spiked her tea, and forcibly established sexual relations.

During the proceedings, the defence sought bail on the grounds that the complainant had submitted a notarised affidavit-cum-declaration stating she wished to withdraw her allegations because her marriage had been fixed.

The prosecution opposed the plea, arguing that the offence is serious and non-compoundable. Additional Public Prosecutor Manisha



Pawse argued that the accused did not deserve bail at this stage.

While rejecting the bail plea, judge Ghule observed: "The reason given is fear of spoiling of marriage, which is

irrelevant. The offence is against society at large. Hence, there cannot be any compromise. It is not free and voluntarily withdrawal of FIR. The complainant cannot initiate criminal action and at the

same time, seek withdrawal of FIR."

Citing the survivor's affidavit, the court noted that it shows the offence of rape has occurred. "She fears that if the bridegroom comes to know about the incident, it will affect her married life. The consent was never given by her for establishing sexual relations when she was in the hotel at Mira Road. The offence is not compoundable," the judge said, noting that the investigation is still incomplete and the charge sheet is yet to be filed.

A non-compoundable offence is a serious crime where the parties involved cannot legally settle or compromise outside of court.

NEET paper leak accused to appear for re-test on June 21

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court on Tuesday allowed an accused in the NEET-UG paper leak case to appear for the re-examination scheduled for June 21 while in custody.

Vacation Judge Vishal Gogne was hearing the interim bail plea of the accused, Yash Yadav, to appear for the re-exam after the National Testing Agency (NTA) on May 3 cancelled the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test

(Undergraduate), or NEET-UG, held on May 3 for medical admissions amid allegations of paper leak.

He said while the applicant faced grave allegations of wrongful dissemination and trading in the confidential questions of the very examination in which he now seeks to appear, his rights as a student cannot be defeated by turning bail into punishment by denying him the opportunity to appear for the re-examination.

"More so, when the eligibility, candidature and selec-



tion of any student in an examination is subject to appropriate orders from the competent authorities/exam

conducting body. In this view, the court finds the applicant to be entitled to appear for the examination on June 21," the judge said.

He, however, said that considering the initial stage of the investigation, the wide sweep of the material and evidence sought to be collected, and the prospect of other suspects still being investigated, the court is not inclined to grant interim bail to facilitate such participation.

The judge noted that Yadav's counsel, in the alternative, said that his client

could be permitted to take the exam in custody.

"The court is inclined to take a favourable view of the said prayer. Such a modality would protect the rights of the applicant/accused and also safeguard the interests of the investigation," the judge said, allowing Yadav to be taken for the exam in custody.

The CBI arrested Yadav in Jaipur on May 13. He was later sent to judicial custody. A total of 13 accused have been arrested in the case, all of whom are presently in judicial custody.

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RBI chooses non austerity route to aid the Rupee



Indian rupee is trading above 95 a dollar, having depreciated over 7 per cent in 2026 alone. Since 2025, it has been the worst-performing currency in Asia, even Pakistani rupee has performed better despite the economic turmoil in that country.

The rupee had touched an all-time low of 96.84 against the dollar on May 20, and the ominous 100-mark no-owns within sight. There are several factors that affects the like G-Sec yield spread between India and US and the inflation differential, which in fact are narrowing because of India's strong macroeconomic performance. The current fragility of the rupee is largely due to India's extensive energy dependence and the disruption of the Iran War.

India imports almost 90 per cent of its crude, roughly half of which transits through the Hormuz Strait.

Every \$1 increase in crude prices adds approximately ₹15,000-16,000 crore to India's annual import bill, and at our current import of 5 million barrels a day, a rise of US \$10 in crude prices

widens the current account deficit (CAD) by 0.4-0.5 per cent of GDP.

The rupee has been falling since mid-2025, and since the War broke out in February, crude prices have climbed from US \$69 per barrel to well above US \$100 for much of the period, touching a peak of almost US \$120 earlier, and now trading at around US \$90. For a country heavily dependent on imported crude, the oil shock now compounds currency weakness, raising risks to trade deficit, inflation, and overall growth.

That the Rupee's fall has not yet unsettled fiscal deficit or headline inflation is because we have several strong macroeconomic cushions now, unlike in 1991. In FY 2026, the merchandise trade deficit was US \$333 billion (8 per cent of GDP), of which roughly a third was due to oil, over a quarter due to electronics and around a fifth due to gold. The huge deficit was substantially offset by the surplus in services trade of US \$214 billion, leaving the overall trade deficit at around US\$119 billion or, 0.6 per cent of GDP. Inward remittances also provide a cushion, and despite high trade deficit, our balance of payments (BoP)—the difference between inflows and outflows—was a surplus of \$14 billion in FY2025, which has



turned into a deficit of \$23.6 billion in FY26, exposing the rupee to further stress.

The CAD is estimated to be around 1.7 per cent of GDP in current fiscal because of soaring energy prices, while the trade deficit may triple, affecting growth, estimates of which has already been curtailed by 0.2-0.4 per cent to around 6.6 per cent.

This is unlikely to improve even if the war is to end soon, because the Hormuz closure has cut 10 per cent of global oil production and 20 per cent of global natural gas production.

The Crude oil and gas prices are up by over 50 per cent, and fertiliser by over 65 per cent. Given the massive supply disruption and damages caused to refineries and infrastructure in the gulf, it will take many months to restore the pre-war equilibrium.

Volatility of the rupee is also causing tumult in the

stock market. As global capital shifts to AI and semiconductor—heavy markets such as Taiwan, South Korea and the US, areas where India remains a laggard, FPIs have withdrawn over \$30 billion in 2026, exceeding the entire outflow during 2025. Unlike FPI capital, FDI areas relatively insulated from short-term geopolitical shocks, but even here, the highly overvalued India's stock market has provided attractive exit valuations, and FDI areas are repatriating substantial gains following the strong stock market rally. In the first nine months of 2025-26, the net FDI inflow was only US \$3 billion, against total FDI of US \$74 billion.

Though it is a sign of India becoming a mature investment destination that should witness both inflows and exits, it is again putting stress on the rupee.

RBI has used the \$33 billion of our forex reserves to stabilise the rupee since

February without much success, and to stem the deluge of outflowing dollars, both the Government and the RBI have recently announced a slew of measures.

RBI has put curbs on speculative dollar positions, and liberalised the Fully Accessible Route (FAR) for foreign investors in Government securities, making all new 15-year, 30-year and 40-year Government securities freely accessible to foreign investors, to attract FPIs into Indian Government debt.

It has increased investment limits for NRIs and OCIs and simplified their direct participation in Indian equity markets.

It offered concessional forex swaps for overseas borrowings, and announced a Special FCNR(B) deposit scheme to absorb the full hedging cost for banks in raising such deposits, replicating the successful 2013 "Raghuram Rajan scheme" that attracted large dollar inflows during the taper tantrum. The current scheme is estimated to mobilize \$35-40 billion from non-residents.

On its part, the Government has increased the effective import duty on gold from 6 per cent to 15 per cent, capped imports at 100 kg per licence, and moved the import gold, silver and plat-

inum jewellery from "free" to "restricted", requiring Government approval/licences for their import, following the PM's appeal to citizens to avoid buying gold for a year. It removed capital gains tax on eligible FAR Government securities held by foreign investors, while exempting interest income on such securities from tax.

Will these measures deliver? Credit rating agency ICR estimates that they will yield a surplus BoP of \$5-10 billion. The rupee briefly cheered, gaining 84 paise and recovering to sub-95 level, before paring the gains.

The textbook response to currency pressure is to tighten: raise rates, attract capital, defend the exchange rate—a route taken by other oil-importing peers—Indonesia, the Philippines and Sri Lanka which tightened credit and weakened consumption.

The RBI has chosen a different route to manage the currency through the external sector, without disrupting the domestic situation, banking upon India's strengths of stable and resilient macroeconomy, well-capitalised banks, and healthier corporate balance-sheets. It might work.

(The writer is Former Director General, CAG of India)



States' aggregate expenditure rose sharply by 131 per cent between 2015-16 and 2024-25, keeping pace with economic growth, as they focused on welfare and development activities, said a CAG report on Tuesday. Revenue expenditure continued to dominate budgets, averaging over 83 per cent of total spending, while capital expenditure increased in absolute terms but remained a relatively smaller share. "Social and economic services together accounted for about two-thirds of total expenditure, reflecting states' focus on welfare and development," said the CAG's Publication on State Finances 2024-25. The report was released by the Comptroller and Auditor General of India (CAG), K Sanjay Murthy. Committed expenditure and subsidies consistently absorbed more than half of revenue expenditure, reaching 53.31 per cent in 2024-25, with subsidies growing particularly rapidly.

At the disaggregate level, states' expenditure remained concentrated in 8 object categories – including 3 types of grants-in-aid, salaries, pensions, interest payments, subsidies and major works – accounting for nearly 78.46 per cent of total spending and about 12.38 per cent of combined Gross State Domestic Product (GSDP).

This reflects the continued dominance of committed and obligatory expenditures in State budgets, the report said. Total expenditure of the states increased from ₹22.18 lakh crore in FY 2015-16 to ₹51.20 lakh crore in 2024-25, an increase of 131 per cent. "Over the period 2015-16 to 2024-25, despite a substantial increase in total expenditure, the expenditure structure remained largely unchanged, with salaries, pensions, interest payments, subsidies and grants together absorbing a substantial share, indicating fiscal rigidity," it added. (PTI)

SEBI allows AIFs to retain liquidation proceeds longer



Markets regulator SEBI on Tuesday issued guidelines to permit Alternative Investment Funds (AIFs) to retain liquidation proceeds beyond their permissible fund life under specified circumstances. The regulator also introduced an 'Inoperative Fund' framework for wound-up funds with residual obligations. The move follows amendments to the Sebi (Alternative Investment Funds) Regulations on April 18 aimed at providing operational flexibility to AIFs during the winding-up process and surrender of registration. Under the new framework, AIFs or their schemes may retain liquidation proceeds beyond the liquidation or dissolution period if they have received litigation notices or regulatory demands, obtained consent from at least 75 per cent of investors by value for retaining funds against anticipated liabilities, or need to meet residual winding-up related operational expenses, Sebi said in its circular. The regulator said litigation-related communications could include notices from tax authorities, regulators, law enforcement agencies, courts, investors or counterparties that indicate potential tax, legal or regulatory liabilities, even if such liabilities have not crystallised. For retention of money against anticipated liabilities, fund managers will be required to disclose the amount proposed to be retained and the estimated duration of retention while seeking investor approval. If funds are retained for residual operational expenses, the retention period cannot exceed three years from the end of the permissible fund life. The regulator has asked the Standard Setting Forum for AIFs (SFA) to formulate implementation standards for eligible operational expense heads in consultation with Sebi. Also, Sebi has introduced an 'Inoperative Fund' status for AIFs that have completed liquidation of all investments but continue to hold retained proceeds or remain registered pending the outcome of litigation. (PTI)

Invest in India before it is too late: Goyal tells corporates, investors, venture funds

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal on Tuesday urged investors, corporates and venture capital funds to "get into action" and start investing in India before it is "too late".

He said India's investment ecosystem is ready, the domestic market is vast, and the Government would help investors connect with market opportunities, while a supportive policy framework is already in place.

"To our investors and venture funds, the time is now, get into action and start investing before it is too late. Indian family offices, Indian venture capital funds, Indian investors, Indian corporates, they all have to come into action. "The ecosystem is ready. Our startups are doing some phenomenal work.

There are tried and tested models in India. The market is large. Government will help connect you to the market. The policy framework is available. Get open to ideas on that front and invest in the future



that India offers to the world," he said. The minister was speaking at the closing ceremony of 'Bharat Innovates 2026' in Nice, France. He also called upon the domestic industry to promote startups by joining hands with them in the manufacturing segment. "So that India will become your (Indian industries) launch pad and the global market will become your destination," Goyal said, while urging

researchers, academia and higher institutes to jointly carry out R&D programmes. He said it will help India reduce the time towards scientific discovery and reduce the time to market the good work that is being done in India.

The Government has announced a series of measures to promote the startup ecosystem in India. It has rolled out a startup action plan to support budding

entrepreneurs. The minister said that almost the entire amount of the second tranche of the Rs 10,000 crore Fund of Funds scheme is going to be committed for deep tech innovators and entities. He also asked the domestic industry to leverage free trade agreements (FTAs) finalised by India in recent years. Besides, Goyal sought suggestions on further improving the ease of doing business in the country and on measures to encourage Indian startups working overseas to return and establish their base in India.

"All those who are working around the world, many of whom want to come back... Give us some suggestions.

How can we make the path of coming back to India to serve our mother land? How can we encourage so many young men and women researchers and innovators?

"We've been working for others for developing technologies... How can we help bring them back to India? How do we attract them?" he asked.

Former Amazon executive is new Bigbasket CEO

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Tata-owned quick commerce platform Bigbasket has announced the appointment of former Amazon executive Amit Nanda as its new Chief Executive Officer (CEO).

Nanda succeeds co-founder Hari Menon, who will step down from the top executive role to become a mentor. Both Menon and co-founder Vipul Parekh will continue to serve on the company's Board and mentor the leadership, bigbasket said in a statement.

Nanda brings over two decades of experience



Amit Nanda

across e-commerce, consumer goods, and consumer banking. He joins bigbasket from Amazon India, where he served as Director of Selling Partner Services and oversaw the third-party mar-

ketplace ecosystem. During his 11-year tenure at Amazon, he also played a key role in scaling the company's owned brands portfolio. Previously, he held leadership positions at Hindustan Unilever and Citibank.

In his new role, Nanda will focus on strengthening bigbasket's position in the highly competitive quick commerce segment and accelerating innovation across its businesses, the company said.

"Having built bigbasket from its inception to its current position as one of India's most trusted consumer platforms, I am delighted to welcome Amit as CEO.

Akasa Air starts flight services to Noida airport from Navi Mumbai

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Domestic carrier Akasa Air has commenced its flight services to the newly-launched Noida International Airport with its inaugural flight QP2017 departing from Navi Mumbai International Airport on Tuesday morning, linking the Mumbai metropolitan region with Delhi-NCR.

Akasa Air flight departed from Navi Mumbai at 7.30 am while the return flight arrived at NMIA at 12.30 pm, a Navi Mumbai International



Airport Ltd (NMIAL) spokesperson said.

The airline will operate seven flights a week to the greenfield airport.

Commercial flight services at the Noida International Airport commenced on Monday, after a 21-month delay. Prime Minister Narendra Modi had laid the

foundation stone of the greenfield airport in the Gautambuddha Nagar district of Uttar Pradesh in November 2021. The facility was inaugurated by PM Modi on March 28 this year.

By linking Navi Mumbai's emerging aviation and commercial ecosystem with Noida's fast-growing industrial and business corridor, the service is expected to support greater movement of entrepreneurs, investors and travellers between western India and northern India, the NMIAL spokesperson said.

US-Iran peace deal to lower costs for Indian exporters: CRF

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

A sustained US-Iran peace deal would promote greater regional stability, helping Indian exporters through lower freight, insurance and logistics costs, while providing a more predictable environment for trade, think tank CRF said on Tuesday.

Chintan Research Foundation (CRF) President Shishir Priyadarshi said that a durable US-Iran peace agreement has the potential to significantly improve the trade and investment climate across West Asia by reducing one of the region's biggest geopolitical risks. "For India, the benefits extend beyond lower energy price volatility. Greater regional



stability would improve shipping confidence, reduce insurance and logistics costs, strengthen connectivity initiatives such as India-West Asia-Europe Economic Corridor, and create a more predictable environment for trade with the Gulf and the wider West Asia," he said.

US President Donald Trump has announced that the US and Iran have finalised a deal to end their 107-day war, which triggered a global energy crisis. The peace agreement is scheduled to be signed on June 19 in Switzerland, according to Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz

Sharif. Priyadarshi said the agreement is important as geopolitical stability acts as a strong catalyst for trade facilitation.

The leaders of India, European Union, France, Germany, Italy, Saudi Arabia, UAE and US announced an MOU on September 9, 2023 — on the sidelines of the G20 Leaders' Summit — committing to work together to develop a new IMEC.

The IMEC will comprise two separate corridors, the east corridor connecting India to the Gulf and northern corridor connecting Gulf to Europe. The US-Iran conflict has severely disrupted movement of cargo ships across the Strait of Hormuz, a key narrow passage between Iran and Oman that handles roughly

a fifth of global oil consumption and serves as the primary export route for major Gulf producers, including Saudi Arabia, Iraq, Kuwait, the United Arab Emirates and Qatar - all key energy suppliers to India. This disruption has led to an increase in crude oil prices, which was pushing inflation northwards.

It has affected India's exports and imports to and from the West Asian region. The main countries of this region include six GCC nations (Bahrain, Oman, Qatar, UAE, Kuwait, Saudi Arabia), Israel, Iran, Iraq, Jordan, Lebanon, Syria and Yemen. India's exports to the GCC nations in 2025-26 dipped 2 per cent year-on-year to \$55.71 billion as against \$56.87 billion in 2024-25.

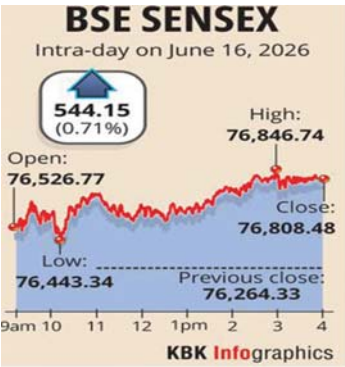
Sensex jumps 544 points to finish above 76,800 mark

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Benchmark stock indices Sensex and Nifty rose for the third consecutive day on Tuesday, propelled by a positive trend in global markets and softening crude oil prices following a peace deal between the US and Iran.

The 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 544.15 points, or 0.71 per cent, to settle at 76,808.48. Intraday, it surged 582.41 points, or 0.76 per cent, to 76,846.74.

The 50-share NSE Nifty climbed 135.25 points, or 0.57 per cent, to end at 23,989.15. During the day, it jumped 148.7 points, or 0.62 per



cent, to 24,002.60. Foreign investors turning net buyers in Indian equities also boosted the sentiment, according to experts.

US military plane crash in California leaves 8 dead

CHRISTOPHER WEBER/
KONSTANTIN TOROPIN
■ Los Angeles

A B-52 bomber crashed shortly after takeoff at a US Air Force base in Southern California's Mojave Desert and burst into flames, killing all eight people aboard, military officials said.

Aerial footage showed virtually nothing left of the aircraft that went down around 11.20 am Monday during a routine test mission at Edwards Air Force Base, which is north of Los Angeles.

Black smoke rose from a large swath of charred desert near the runway on the base, with emergency vehicles nearby. Those on board included Government con-



Smoke plumes rising from a B-52 bomber that crashed shortly after takeoff at a US Air Force base in Southern California

tractors and uniformed military. After reviewing footage of the crash, it was determined that no one could have survived, Col James Hayes, the deputy comman-

der for the 412 test wing at Edwards, said at a news conference. "We lost eight great Americans," Hayes said, adding that officials were working to notify their fam-

ilies. It was not immediately clear what caused the crash, and it could take up to six months to complete an investigation, Hayes said, but shared that the B-52 was supporting the "radar modernisation programme".

The Boeing B-52 Stratofortress is a long-range bomber that entered service in 1955. Designed to carry both conventional and nuclear weapons, it has been used in conflicts involving the US military from Vietnam to Iran. In 2025, Boeing sent a B-52 to Edwards with a new, modernised radar system. A test team planned to conduct ground and flight test activities on the aircraft throughout 2026 to feed a production decision, the air force said in

a 2025 news release.

The modern Active Electronically Scanned Array (AESA) radar system replaced the aircraft's antiquated radar for efficacy. It was unclear if that was the same aircraft involved in Monday's crash.

Edwards Air Force Base is home to a large portion of the US Air Force's aircraft test and development efforts and is about 161 km north of Los Angeles.

The 412th Test Wing, which runs the base, also conducts developmental testing of all Air Force aircraft, weapons systems, software and components before purchase by the service as well as throughout their lifespan.

The vast desert base is

also where Air Force test pilot Chuck Yeager reached a speed of Mach 1.05 and broke the sound barrier in 1947.

The airfield was closed most of Monday and all inbound aircraft were being diverted, but it reopened to people coming onto the base by late afternoon. Non-commercial visitor passes for the base were suspended as emergency crews doused the flames.

It's too soon to say what might have happened.

The way the B-52 crashed so quickly after takeoff without getting very high or going far makes aviation safety expert Jeff Guzzetti suspect some kind of flight control malfunction. (AP)

Former Sri Lankan president moves court to prevent arrest



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Colombo

Former Sri Lanka President Gotabaya Rajapaksa on Tuesday filed a petition in a court to prevent his arrest in connection with the Easter Sunday attacks. nOn April 21, 2019, nine suicide bombers, including a woman, carried out a series of devastating blasts that tore through three churches and as many luxury hotels, killing 270 people, including 44 foreigners, 11 of them Indians, and injuring over 500 others. Rajapaksa, 77, filed a writ petition in the Court of Appeal, citing the police chief, the director of the Criminal Investigation Department and the officer in charge as respondents. His attorneys told the court that there was a likelihood of his

arrest under the Prevention of Terrorism Act (PTA).

Rajapaksa, who served as president from 2019 to mid-2022, was slapped with a foreign travel ban by the courts in March, following the arrest of former state intelligence chief Suresh Sallay. Sallay has been in detention under PTA provisions since late February and staged a hunger strike last month, claiming ill-treatment in custody. Sallay is accused of orchestrating the Easter Sunday attacks to help Rajapaksa win the presidency in 2019 by harbouring and maintaining links with the National Thowheeth Jama'ath (NTJ), which carried out the bombings. The Islamic State terror group claimed the attacks, but the Government blamed the local Islamist extremist group NTJ.

Security forces kill 5 TTP terrorists in Pak's Punjab



M ZULQERNAIN
■ Lahore

Five "highly dangerous" Tehreek-e-Taliban terrorists were killed by the law enforcement agencies on Tuesday in Pakistan's Punjab province, police said.

The Counter Terrorism Department (CTD) of the Punjab police conducted an intelligence-based operation near Attock district, some 400 kilometres from Lahore, early Tuesday.

"Following credible intelligence, the law enforcement agencies launched the operation," the CTD said in a statement. During the raid at their hideout, the terrorists opened fire on the security personnel, triggering an exchange of gunfire between the two sides, it said.

"As a result of the operation, five highly dangerous terrorists were killed," it added. A cache of weapons and explosives, including one suicide vest, three submachine guns, and two hand grenades, was recovered from the slain terrorists. (PTI)

6.7 magnitude quake sparks panic in Indonesia

MOHAMMAD TAUFAN
■ Palu

A 6.7 magnitude earthquake shook part of central Indonesia's Sulawesi island on Tuesday, causing scattered damage and rattling residents of a city devastated by a quake and tsunami eight years ago.

The strong shaking sent people fleeing into open areas in and around Palu, a city of about 400,000 people and the capital of Central Sulawesi province. Several hospitals evacuated patients, some with IV drips, outdoors as a safety measure.

Images from the area showed heavily damaged structures with partially collapsed roofs, shattered walls



Patients who were evacuated are seen outside of a local hospital following an earthquake in Palu, Central Sulawesi

and debris scattered across the streets. The National Disaster Management Agency said information on the damage, possible casualties and displaced people was still being gathered.

"We have evacuated all guests from the hotel, including several guests who remained in their rooms," said Effendi Natali, a general manager of a four-star hotel in Palu.

"They all panicked, which is a natural reaction during an earthquake, but everyone is safe," Natali said, adding that the hotel sustained only minor damage.

The initial quake was centred 43 kilometres east-southeast of Palu, and the US Geological Survey said it was about 10 kilometres deep. Several aftershocks followed, the strongest being of 5.2 magnitude.

People also moved away from coastal areas as a precaution if the quake set off a tsunami. Indonesia's Meteorology, Climatology, and Geophysical Agency said there was no danger of a tsunami but warned aftershocks could continue. (AP)

1 KILLED, 4 INJURED AS QUAKE HITS CHINA

Beijing: One person was killed and four others injured on Tuesday after a 6.3-magnitude earthquake jolted Haixi Mongolian and Tibetan Autonomous Prefecture in northwest China. The quake struck at a depth of 10 km, with the epicentre at 37.80 degrees north latitude and 95.56 degrees east longitude, said a report issued by the China Earthquake Networks Centre. The Qinghai provincial seismological bureau dispatched an on-site work team to the quake-hit area to assist local authorities with emergency response.

UN calls on Taliban to reverse crackdown on women in Afghanistan

EDITH M LEDERER ■ United Nations

The UN Security Council unanimously adopted a resolution Monday calling on Afghanistan's Taliban rulers to swiftly reverse their crackdown on women and to combat militant groups inside Afghanistan that Pakistan accuses of carrying out cross-border attacks.

China's UN Ambassador Fu Cong, whose country sponsored the resolution, said the hope is that the Afghan Government will "take more proactive measures to protect human rights, especially the rights of women, and project an image of openness, inclusivity and responsibility".

The resolution extends the UN political mission in Afghanistan until June 17, 2027, and authorises it to support humanitarian aid deliveries "without discrimination" and to promote national and local governance "without any discrimination



based on sex, religion or ethnicity, with the full, equal, meaningful and safe participation of women,... minorities, youth and persons with disabilities".

The resolution's adoption follows the arrest of at least 30 women in the western city of Herat this month for allegedly violating the Taliban's strict dress code. (AP)

India, Sri Lanka push local currency trade

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Colombo

India and Sri Lanka have discussed ways to enhance trade settlement in local currencies to reduce transaction costs and insulate the bilateral trade from dollar volatility.

Local currency settlement reduces transaction costs, eliminates conversion losses in both directions, and insulates bilateral trade from dollar volatility, said Santosh Jha, Indian High Commissioner.

"And for Sri Lanka specifically, it reduces pressure on scarce hard currency reserves—preserving dollars



Santosh Jha

for uses where they are truly necessary, while rupee-to-rupee trade flows freely between our two economies," Jha said at a round-table discussion on 'Rupee to Rupee: Strengthening the India-Sri Lanka Commercial Corridor'.

Nepal, China FM hold comprehensive bilateral talks

KJM VARMA ■ Beijing

Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi and his Nepalese counterpart Shisir Khanal held "comprehensive talks" covering the entire gamut of bilateral ties.

Khanal arrived in Beijing on a four-day visit on June 14 after his weeklong trip to India. After he met with Wang, Khanal said in a post on X, "We held a comprehensive discussion on the entire gamut of bilateral relations, including in the areas of connectivity, border management, trade, technology transfer and multilateral cooperation." "We also exchanged views on expanding people-to-people ties and reaffirmed shared commitment to further strengthen-



ing Nepal-China relations for the mutual benefit of our two countries," he said.

Wang told Khanal that China has always placed its relations with Nepal in an important position in its

neighbourhood diplomacy and pursues a friendly policy toward all Nepali people.

China will, as always, support Nepal in safeguarding its national sovereignty, independence and territori-

al integrity, and in exploring a development path suited to its own national conditions, Wang said, the Chinese Foreign Ministry said.

Khanal's visit to Beijing is regarded as significant as both countries were expected to reset the relations after this year's massive victory of the new Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP), ending the prolonged rule of leaders of Nepal's Communist parties, K P Sharma Oli and Prachanda, who sought to move Kathmandu closer to Beijing, away from India. The RSP's victory in the general elections marked an end to the dominance of the communist parties, which gained political prominence after the abolition of the monarchy in Nepal in 2008. (PTI)

Man jailed for arson on homes linked to UK PM

EMMA BURROWS ■ London

The Russian-speaking handler, a shadowy figure known as "El Money," was not happy. A string of arson attacks targeting a car and two London homes linked to British Prime Minister Keir Starmer had attracted little attention, possibly because the then 21-year-old attacker, a Ukrainian recruited online, was not very good at documenting them.

One video that was supposed to show Starmer's former car on fire lasted only seconds. The second, filmed in the dark, largely captured the repeated sound of striking matches.

El Money wanted publicity and was prepared to pay. The attacker, Roman Lavrinyovych, was found guilty Monday alongside his accomplice. But the person—or network—behind the online persona of El Money has escaped public blame or



punishment. The plot fits the description of Russian state-backed sabotage, said Cmdr.

Dominic Murphy, who has spent two decades investigating such activities—including previous high-profile attacks—and who oversaw the initial investigation into the fires before retiring in March. (AP)

UNSC reform would border on failure if only non-permanent category expanded: India

YOSHITA SINGH
■ United Nations

India has cautioned that reform of the UN Security Council will border on "failure" if only its non-permanent category of membership is expanded.

India's Permanent Representative to the UN Ambassador Harish Parvathaneni made these remarks while addressing the Inter-Governmental Negotiations (IGN) meeting on Security Council reforms.

"UNSC reform would be grossly inadequate, bordering on failure, if expansion is limited only to the non-permanent category as it would fundamentally not change



the decision making power-structure of the P5," Parvathaneni said. "Groups and member states have waited this long for real and meaningful reforms," he further added. Parvathaneni was addressing the meeting, with focus on the 'Elements

Paper', a document that contains points of convergences and divergences of UN member states on reform of the powerful UN body.

Parvathaneni stressed that by advocating expansion of the permanent category, India's consistent effort has

been to bring in a "greater sense of balance and equity" in the Security Council, and change the decision making parameters of the five veto-wielding permanent members—China, France, Russia, UK and the US.

India has been at the forefront of years-long efforts for achieving reform of the Security Council, including expansion in both its permanent and non-permanent categories, saying the 15-nation Council, founded in 1945, is not fit for purpose in the 21st Century and does not reflect contemporary geopolitical realities.

Delhi has consistently underscored that it rightly deserves a permanent seat at

the horse-shoe table. India last sat at the UN high-table as a non-permanent member in 2021-22.

India was critical of the 'Elements Paper' tabled for discussion, saying that it neither captures the overall state of play accurately nor accounts for the overwhelming sentiments of a majority of member states.

He pointed out that support of a majority for expansion in the permanent category of the Security Council has been reduced to 'a significant number of delegations' in the 'Elements Paper'.

"Despite the categorical position of a majority of member states in favour of

expanding the permanent category, as reflected either in the national statements delivered at the IGN or through association with groups such as L69, G4, CARICOM etc, this has not been depicted accurately," he said. Parvathaneni also noted that the 'Elements Paper' mentions that the permanent category would be expanded through the Fixed Regional Seats proposal, which he said "incredibly has only been documented" in this 'Elements Paper'. It further adds that member states elected to such seats would serve in their national capacity and not formally represent their respective regions.

"These present three inherent issues—one, the proposal does in no way expand the permanent category; two, the concept of regionality would not be served if the concerned member States act in their national capacities; and three, it weakens the case of SIDS (Small Island Developing States), a cross-regional group which India has been consistently supportive of."

India said this whole proposal is akin to granting a veto to the 10 elected members of the Council, who sit at the horse-shoe table for two year terms, "bereft of convoluted arguments of permanency. (PTI)

Europe is worried over South China Sea: Germany

JIM GOMEZ ■ Manila

German President Frank-Walter Steinmeier said in the Philippines on Tuesday that Europe is worried over tensions in the disputed South China Sea where a major flare-out could endanger freedom of navigation as has happened in the Strait of Hormuz.

In a joint appearance with Philippine President Ferdinand Marcos Jr. in Manila, where Steinmeier is on a state visit, the German president referenced the blockade of the Hormuz as a result of the Iran war and said European leaders were concerned about continuing territorial confrontations in the South China Sea, particularly between the Philippines and China. The United States lays no claims to the South China Sea but has repeatedly warned it's obligated to help defend the Philippines, its oldest treaty ally in Asia, if Filipino forces, ships and aircraft come under an armed attack. China has repeatedly warned the US not to meddle with the disputes, which also involve Vietnam, Malaysia, Brunei and Taiwan. (AP)



Kishau Dam hurdle cleared; Himachal gets ₹2,000 cr relief

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The long-pending Kishau Dam Project received a significant boost on Monday after the Centre agreed in principle that beneficiary states will bear the ₹2,000 crore power component cost associated with Himachal Pradesh's share in the project, ending an eight-year financial deadlock.

The breakthrough came during a high-level meeting chaired by Union Home Minister Amit Shah in New Delhi, where Himachal Pradesh Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu strongly advocated the state's position regarding the 422 MW Kishau Dam Project proposed on the Tons River along the Himachal Pradesh-Uttarakhand border.

The project, estimated to cost around ₹15,000 crore, has faced delays over disagreements on financial responsibility.



Following discussions, the Centre agreed that Delhi, Haryana and Rajasthan-the principal beneficiaries of the project's water component-would bear the cost of the power component on behalf of Himachal Pradesh.

Speaking after the meeting, Sukhu described the decision as a major victory for the state. He said the previous state Government had agreed to contribute around ₹800 crore towards the project, but his administration opposed the arrangement, citing

Himachal Pradesh's limited financial resources.

The Chief Minister argued that while the Centre provides 90 per cent grant assistance for the water component of the project, similar support should be extended for the power component.

He also pointed out that Himachal Pradesh would bear the social and environmental costs of the project, including displacement in affected areas, and therefore should not be burdened with additional financial liabilities.

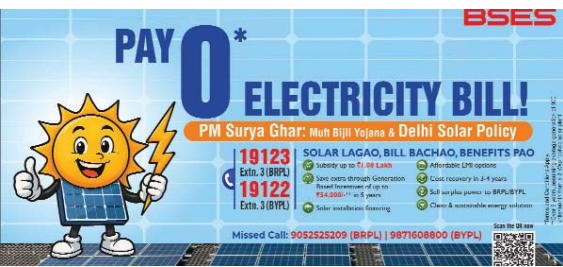
BSES rolls out multi-platform drive to push rooftop solar across Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Power distribution company BSES has launched a city-wide multi-platform awareness campaign to promote rooftop solar adoption and encourage consumers to take advantage of Government-backed renewable energy schemes.

The campaign aims to accelerate the uptake of clean energy solutions by highlighting the benefits of installing rooftop solar systems under the Government of India's PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana and the Delhi Solar Policy.

As part of the outreach initiative, BSES has rolled out radio jingles across leading FM stations in Delhi, targeting a broad audience across the National Capital Region. The company has also placed advertisements at key Delhi Metro stations to maximize



visibility among daily commuters. In addition, social media platforms are being used to educate consumers about rooftop solar technology, available subsidies, and the process of installation.

According to BSES, rooftop solar systems offer substantial financial benefits to consumers. Households can avail themselves of central Government subsidies under the PM Surya Ghar scheme, incentives provided through the Delhi Solar Policy, and flexible financing options. These benefits can significantly reduce elec-

tricity expenses, with some consumers potentially achieving zero electricity bills depending on their energy consumption and system capacity.

The company noted that surplus electricity generated through rooftop solar installations can be exported to the power grid under the net metering mechanism, allowing consumers to earn additional savings. Over the lifespan of a solar system, users can save several lakh rupees while reducing their dependence on conventional energy sources.

PROSPECT



Jayanta Mallabaruah, Minister for Environment and Forest, Govt of Assam attending the Closure Workshop of the Assam Project on Forest & Biodiversity Conservation, Phase-II in Guwahati KAMAL LOSAN TALUKDAR



Rakesh Agarwal, IPS, DG NIA with Hardi Singh, IPS DGP, Assam at the Assam Police Institute, Guwahati PIONEER PHOTO

IHLD MedTech receives investment of \$3 million

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

As India grapples with a growing burden of diabetes and chronic wounds, a network of specialised wound-care Centres of Excellence is set to be rolled out across the country over the next two to three years, offering integrated diagnosis, treatment and long-term monitoring for patients with chronic and non-healing wounds.

The centres are being developed under the Wound Heal Plus initiative of IHLD MedTech, which has received an initial investment tranche of US\$3 million from Singapore-listed Ultra-Green.ai, with the potential for additional investments that could increase the total investment to up to US\$12 million, subject to mutually agreed milestones and other agreed conditions. The funding will support the expansion of IHLD MedTech's Wound Heal Plus and iLiveConnect platforms.

IHLD MedTech, an Indian medtech company building technology-led healthcare delivery platforms, said the centres would bring together wound screening,



Dr Rahul Chandola

disciplinary approach involving vascular surgeons, plastic surgeons, podiatrists, orthotists, nutritionists, physiotherapists and rehabilitation specialists.

"We believe the future of healthcare lies at the intersection of advanced technology, clinical intelligence and continuous patient engagement," said Ravinder Sajwan, CEO of UltraGreen.ai.

A key feature of the programme is the use of advanced fluorescence imaging technology that allows clinicians to assess blood flow and tissue perfusion within wounds.

The resulting images are analysed through WoundLinks, a software platform developed in collaboration with UltraGreen.ai, helping doctors identify poorly perfused tissue and make more precise treatment decisions, Dr Chandola said.

Beyond hospital-based treatment, patients will continue to receive care through iLiveConnect's continuity-care platform and mobile wound-care clinics after discharge, enabling specialists to track healing, identify risks early and intervene when necessary.

advanced imaging, treatment, rehabilitation and digital follow-up services under one roof, addressing what experts describe as a major but often neglected area of healthcare.

The investment will also support the expansion of iLiveConnect, a doctor-led, AI-enabled continuity-care platform designed to extend healthcare far beyond hospital walls. "One of the biggest challenges in India, and indeed across the world, is that wound care remains a largely neglected area of healthcare," Dr Rahul Chandola, cardiovascular surgeon and Founder and Managing Director of IHLD MedTech, said.

The Wound Heal Plus centres will offer a multidis-

Rubrik takes big leap towards protecting data, securing future

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

At its much-awaited global event focused on cybersecurity and AI — Forward 2026 — Rubrik, the US-headquartered security and AI operations company, took a major leap forward when it announced the launch of Rubrik AI, transforming its platform with agentic-first experiences to operate at AI speed. Rubrik AI adapts to each organisation's context and security threats and autonomously acts at machine speed across Rubrik's product portfolio.

Apart from Rubrik AI, the NYSE-listed company founded by four NRIs, announced other major launches and tie-ups at its flagship event held at Las Vegas. With AI adoption being taken up at a massive scale, threats and cyber attacks are also growing multi-fold. The rush to adopt enterprise AI is expanding the attack surface in ways that static controls and legacy recovery plans weren't built for. To meet these challenges at scale, every year Rubrik brings together the global security and IT community to address these challenges at scale at Rubrik Forward.

"Today, Rubrik becomes an agent. Our Agentic Cyber



Rubrik CEO, Chairman and Co-Founder Bipul Sinha addressing global security and IT community at company's flagship event Forward in Las Vegas PIONEER PHOTO

Resilience is designed to mitigate risks from both external AI attacks and internal agent deployments. Rubrik AI will deliver agentic automation to enable resilience against machine-speed cyber breaches and compromised AI agents," said Bipul Sinha, CEO, Chairman and Co-Founder, Rubrik.

From day one, Rubrik built an API-first platform to provide the industry's leading cyber resilience for customers. Now, the company has innovated the Rubrik platform even further for the agentic era. Rubrik AI powers a new way of interaction with Rubrik's solution suites that is fully agent first: Customers define the business outcomes, and Rubrik AI reasons and autonomously acts to deliver those outcomes.

Other major announcements at the mega event

include launch of Rubrik Agent Cloud (RAC) for Anthropic's Claude Code and Claude Cowork; unveiling of the next stage Annapurna, establishing the AI-ready unstructured data layer for enterprise Data Intelligence platforms of choice; and the launch of Autonomous Business Recovery (ABR) for Cloud Applications, the agentic cyber resilience solution that recovers cloud applications from data to network,

identity and configurations.

Rubrik also introduced two new Identity Resilience capabilities to expand its product suite -- Identity Continuity which is powered by the acquisition of Strata.io, which enables organizations to secure, modernize, and manage human and agent identities without disrupting existing infrastructure; and Identity Roll Forward, industry-first capabilities, and fully developed in-house.

Rubrik also announced, Project Hourglass, an alliance

with elite Global Systems Integrators (GSIs) to deliver Rubrik Agent Cloud for Anthropic's Claude Code to their enterprise clients.

GSI leaders, including Cognizant, Deloitte, LTM, HCLTech, NTT Data, and Wipro, are integrating Rubrik Agent Cloud (RAC) into their cybersecurity and digital transformation architectures. Project Hourglass addresses the critical security and operational risks associated with autonomous AI agents across the modern enterprise.

Guru Nanak Dev University, Amritsar		
Expression of Interest (Eoi) Notice		
The Department of G.N.D.U., Amritsar invites sealed (Eoi) for the following:-		
Sr. No.	Expression of Interest (Eoi)	Closing Date & Time
1.	Allotment for e- lobby (Near Administrative Block)	30-06-2026
2.	Allotment for administrative Block Canteen	30-06-2026
3.	Allotment for University Business School Canteen	30-06-2026
4.	Allotment of Food Court Unit -4 (Fast Food Outlet)	30-06-2026
For more details log on to https://digital.gndu.ac.in .		
2426/12/2026-27/12361 Dated CHD - 15/06/2026		

कार्यालय नगर निगम, देहरादून				
(ई-निविदा सूचना)				
नगर निगम, देहरादून में विंतीय वर्ष 2026-27 हेतु स्वास्थ्य रटोर के प्रयोग आने वाली सफाई उपकरण आपूर्ति करने हेतु निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है तथा निविदा से सम्बन्धित समस्त विवरण ई-निविदा पोर्टल www.uktenders.gov.in से प्राप्त किये जा सकते हैं।				
कार्य का विवरण	निविदा शुल्क (18% जीएसटी सहित)	घरोहर राशि निश्चय	निविदा डाले जाने की प्रारम्भिक एवं अंतिम तिथि	निविदा खोलने की तिथि एवं समय
सफाई उपकरण क्रय किये जाने हेतु।	5000/+GST अतिरिक्त	1,00,000 /-	17.06.2026 से 01.07.2026 अपराह्न 5.00 बजे	02.07.2026 को पूर्वाह्न 11:00 बजे
नगर आयुक्त नगर निगम, देहरादून				

verka		
THE PUNJAB STATE COOPERATIVE MILK PRODUCERS FEDERATION LTD.		
SCO 153-155, SECTOR 34-A, CHANDIGARH-160022. EPABX NO. 012-5041812,66		
Notice Inviting Tender		
Tenders are hereby invited for the purchase and supply of following items:-		
Sr. No.	Name of Work/Item	Period/Tentative Qty
1.	For Verka Head Office, Chandigarh Construction of new sewer lines and parking at Verka Hoshiarpur Dairy.	Five Months
2.	For Verka Chandigarh Dairy e-Tender for hiring services for outsourcing activities/ contractor for packaging UHT Milk & Milk products/ Beverages.	Annual
3.	For Verka Mohali Dairy a) Supply, installation & commissioning of Milk Protein Concentration System. b) Hiring of :- i. Insulated vehicles of minimum 01 MT capacity for 2 nd leg delivery of Verka Milk and Milk products in Delhi-NCR area. ii. Passenger vehicle/ taxi (Swift Dzire, Toyota Etios or equivalent) for officers in Delhi area.	01 No. Annual/ 02 No's (No. of vehicles may increased or decreased) 04 No's (No. of vehicles may increased or decreased)
4.	For Verka Bathinda Dairy a) Hiring of insulated vehicles for supply of packed Milk and Fresh milk products in Bathinda Milkshed area. (Cap. 2.2 MT, 1.7 MT, 03 MT) b) Supply of Manpower for packing of ice cream in all variants & pack sizes, shifting of packing material and other related jobs for the ice cream section as per requirement. c) Manpower required for job contract i.e. for processing, manufacturing, packing of milk & milk products & panjiri and loading & unloading of milk, milk products, edible, non edible & packing material.	Annual with extension upto one year/ 01 vehicle for each Annual/ 01 No.
5.	For Verka Gurdaspur Dairy Hiring of insulated single portion road milk tankers (capacity-10000 ltr.) for the transportation of milk from BMC/MCC.	Two year/ 10 No's
6.	For Verka Sangrur Dairy Job contract for feeding of rice husk into boiler (by manpower), transportation of husk from husk yard to boiler, cleaning ash bit & removal of ash out-side the factory (Verka Sangrur Dairy) by own mode of transport.	Annual
7.	For Verka Ludhiana Dairy a) Hiring of vehicles (tampoo/ trucks) for supply of Verka Milk products/ ghee/ SMP etc. between Verka Ludhiana Dairy and stations. b) Job contract for packing of liquid milk, dahi and lassi in pouches and cleaning of milk plastic trays (including DIET, GADVASU).	One year with extension upto 01 year Annual
8.	For Verka Jalandhar Dairy a) Supply of Nitric Acid (in cans & tankers). b) Maintenance contract for operation and maintenance of milk and milk products pouches filling machines & tray washer (along with coding of pouches and photo cell of machine). c) Labour contract for packing of milk & milk products in different pack sizes (Milk, Dahi & Lassi pouches, Dahi cups, garvi, matka, paneer packing, kheer packing, Ghee, Butter & powder packing, Butter melting, special pinni packing, panjiri manufacturing & packing, reconstitution of SMP/WMP/DW & Sugar etc.) d) Operation, Maintenance & House Keeping of effluent treatment plant, water softener plant (2 no's), sewerage treatment plant and tube-wells installed.	Annual Annual
9.	For Verka Amritsar Dairy Hiring of vehicle for supply of fresh milk and milk products at Beas Route.	Annual
10.	For Verka Mega Dairy, Bassi Pathana a) Loading /Unloading of Verka milk & milk products, corrugated boxes, SMP bags. b) Vehicles i.e. 1.5 MT, 2.5 MT, 4.5 MT, 9 MT, 15 MT, 20 MT, 24 MT, 27 MT and 32 MT for the transportation of UHT milk, milk products, beverages, juice and other Verka ambient products etc. from Verka Mega Dairy Bassi Pathana to other Verka Dairy units, milkfed branches & depots (in the state of Punjab & upcountry Ltele) and defence units. c) Auction of unserviceable material.	Annual Annual
11.	For Verka Cattle Feed Plant, Bhatian(Khanna) a) Labour job contract for different activities for production section, store section and marketing section. b) Transportation of finished cattle feed, mineral feed mixture and UML to various station of Punjab, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh, Rajasthan. Capacity an average per day.(Qty increase/ decrease as per demand).	Annual/ 04-06 No's trucks of 7 Mts to 10 Mts 06-08 No's trucks of 10,05 Mts to 16 Mts, 02-05 No's trucks of 16.05 Mts & above MT 01 No.
NOTE: 1. For complete details regarding above tender (NIT), please visit our website i.e. www.verka.coop & e Tendering portal i.e. eproc.punjab.gov.in . 2. Corrigendum, if any, will be uploaded on website only.		
General Manager (Purchase)		
1018/12/2026-27/12370 Dated CHD - 15/06/2026		

DAILY SUDOKU

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction-no maths involved.

SOLUTION (16.6.26)

7	3	4	8	6	1	5	9	2
5	6	8	3	9	2	4	1	7
1	9	2	4	7	5	8	6	3
9	1	5	6	3	7	2	4	8
4	2	3	9	1	8	6	7	5
6	8	7	2	5	4	9	3	1
2	4	1	7	8	6	3	5	9
8	5	9	1	4	3	7	2	6
3	7	6	5	2	9	1	8	4

DOUBLE CROSSWORD

WEDNESDAY | JUNE 17, 2026

ACROSS

9 Having pages missing, doesn't include it 10 It's in the jeweller's window your mates are about to break (8) 12 Look on page two (4) 13 Stops to get ice (6) 14 Have little skill in drink making (7) 15 Completely free from, instantly (5,4) 17 Intimating that one's influencing unfairly (7,2) 18 Mean to have a drink at last (7) 20 Waste what you've earned (6) 21 Come to the jail (4) 24 Leave, terribly angry about having been exposed (8) 26 The old aircraft turning to land - or take off (8) 28 Out to get the son in, will get rid of (4) 29 Is put off by the figure, which is silly (6) 31 Actresses are put upon by her (7) 34 The reptile file (9) 36 The lout, when he'd been caught entering, became violent (6,3) 38 Invigling against - that's right; complaining of (7) 39 Think the notice outside was funny (6) 40 Backtrack and you'll find he's misled you (4) 41 Though determined, be beaten back in a true rout (8) 42 Don't leave much time to do the shredding? (3,2,4)

DOWN

1 A bit upset by thunder? Nonsense! (8) 2 Being forced to, when in possession of (6) 3 Understood one's successor had done so (8) 4 As usual, young and thickset (6) 5 Holding a green ticket for the trips (8) 6 This nipper is a loner (6,4) 7 Did he rest on the bed after tea? (7) 8 In the role of Lear, perhaps, which is demanding (6) 11 Bird with a sharp point to its tail (7) 16 Fastened outside again, in rows (6) 19 Is loaded with fishing equipment (5) 20 Served up, too (3) 22 Charge, we're told, for the nails (5)

SOLUTION (16.6.26)

ACROSS	21. Frock coat	DOWN	1. Scrap	18. Horace
4. Idlers	23. Peer	2. Brain	20. E-age-r	21. Few
7. Cardigan	24. Fa-NG	3. Lids	22. Cam	23. (im-) Polite
8. Twelve	26. Now	4. I-n tow	23. (im-) Polite	25. Roc
10. A-ria-s	27. Atom	5. Wilson	26. Now	28. Tarts
13. Loin (cloth)	29. Eton	6. Re-ver-t	27. Atom	30. Table
14. P-and	32. Scar	7. Eton	28. Tarts	31. N. Eddy
15. How-L	33. G-race	8. Re-ver-t	29. Eton	32. Star
16. Cry	34. Fitter	9. Having	30. Table	33. Game
17. G-h-I-O	35. Tramp-led	10. A-ria-s	31. N. Eddy	
19. Sea-t	36. Hearts	11. Bird	32. Star	

BRIEFLY

Shuttler Rounak Chouhan enters main draw of Macau Open



India's Rounak Chouhan secured a place in the men's singles main draw of the Macau Open Super 300 badminton tournament after his opponent, Myanmar's Hein Htut, retired in a qualification match here on Tuesday. Both players had taken a game each before Htut retired, with the scoreline reading 14-21, 21-15, 19-17 in favour of the Indian. Chouhan will take on Zhe Ying Wu of Chinese Taipei, ranked 133rd in the world, in the round of 32 of the main draw on Wednesday. In other qualification matches, Tushar Suveer lost his men's singles match against Christian Adinata of Indonesia 20-22, 13-21, 15-21. India's Alap Mishra lost to Htut 18-21, 18-21 before the Myanmar shuttler retired hurt in the final qualification match against Chouhan. The women's doubles pair of Ashwini Bhat and Shikha Gautam lost their qualification match to Amalia Prativ and Siti Fadia Ramadhanti of Indonesia 10-21, 8-21. (PTI)

Araujo's equaliser saves Uruguay in their opener against Saudi Arabia



Maxi Araujo finally gave the crowd of mostly Uruguay fans in South Florida something to cheer about with his tying goal late in Monday's World Cup opener against Saudi Arabia. La Celeste salvaged a point, but they were not thrilled with the result. "We gave it away. We have to be honest," midfielder Federico Valverde said in Spanish after his side played to a 1-1 draw, making up for a flat first half by controlling the second. "We gave away the first half," Valverde added. "We didn't play the way we had trained. It wasn't what we were aiming for. We rushed things too much. We wanted to win the game in the very first minute. Sometimes you need a bit more patience and just play our game. We improved a lot in the second half." Abdullelah Al-Amri scored on a rebound in the 41st minute for Saudi Arabia, and Araujo got the equalizer in the 80th, firing a rebound past goalkeeper Mohammed Al-Owais from close range. (AP)

Iran plays to 2-2 draw with New Zealand, Just scores twice

GREG BEACHAM
Inglewood (US)

Iran opened its politically charged World Cup by playing to a 2-2 draw with New Zealand on Monday night, overcoming two deficits and getting the tying goal from Mohammad Mohebbi in the 64th minute. Ramin Rezaeian scored an early goal and assisted on Mohebbi's goal for the Iranians, whose World Cup cycle has been in upheaval since the US and Israel began a war against Iran on February 28. Iran ultimately decided to compete even after FIFA rejected its request to move its three group-stage matches out of the US.



Iran moved its training base during the tournament from Arizona to Tijuana, Mexico, and the team is flying into the US on the day before each game before returning quickly

Belgium settles for 1-1 draw with Egypt



ANDREW DESTIN
Seattle

Romelu Lukaku's entrance as a second-half substitute drew a standing ovation from the smattering of Belgium supporters. It took only 23 seconds to turn those hopeful cheers into raptures of euphoria. Lukaku's presence sparked an immediate attack that led to Belgium's lone goal against Egypt on Monday, helping to earn a 1-1 draw in the team's opening World Cup match. "He's a target man," Belgium captain Youri Tielemans said.

"He needs to build up his fitness, which is understandable after being out for the season. But, he helps us in this way." Lukaku, a Napoli striker who leads his nation in goals scored, withdrew from Belgium's friendlies in the United States in the spring to get fitter as he continues to recover from a hamstring injury. That injury didn't look too bothersome in the 66th minute when he ran down the middle of the field moments after entering the game and lurched to tap a cross from the right into the net. Egypt defend-

India look to sharpen their batting against Netherlands

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Leeds

India will aim to put an improved performance with the bat when they face Netherlands in their second group game of the Women's T20 World Cup here on Wednesday. Smriti Mandhana at the top and Richa Ghosh in the lower order made the difference with the bat in the opener against Pakistan. The rest of the batting line-up, including opener Shafali Verma and Harmanpreet Kaur, could not come to the party. Bharti Fulmali plays a crucial role in the middle-order but she had a forgettable first outing in the ICC event. More consistency is needed from the Indian batters for the tougher battles ahead in the league stage. The Netherlands game should be cake-walk but India would need to beat either Australia or South Africa in the league stage to qualify for the semifinals. The fielding against Pakistan was not up to the mark, to start with, but some good catches were taken later in the innings. Both the pacers, Arundhati Reddy and Kranti Gaud, were



not able to make an impact. They both would be looking for early breakthroughs at Headingley. The spin duo of Deepti Sharma and Shree Charani shared eight wickets amongst themselves with the former picking up a five-wicket haul. It was important for Deepti to strike form having gone for runs in the series leading up to the T20 showpiece. Charani has been

impressive in her blossoming international career, troubling the best batters with her guile and flight. Netherlands, on the other hand, come into the game following a loss to Bangladesh. They would need improvement in all departments to challenge India. "I think in all three aspects of the game, it wasn't quite the fire we hoped for. With the bat, I think we were a few runs short. We never really got going. We lost a bit too many wickets on the way.

Will Kuldeep, Jaiswal get game time in second ODI?

APARAJITA UPADHYAY
Lucknow

With the Indian team management keen on testing different combinations ahead of next year's ODI World Cup, it remains to be seen whether Kuldeep Yadav and Yashasvi Jaiswal get into the playing XI in the second ODI against Afghanistan here on Wednesday. The hosts lead the three-match series 1-0 after their comfortable win in the rain-curtailed opener. A win on Wednesday will give them an unassailable lead. But India's focus, however, extends beyond immediate results. With two dozen ODI matches scheduled before the World Cup, the team management has made it clear that the ongoing series is an opportunity to test different combinations and assess players in various roles. "For this series, it's all about trying



different combinations and seeing what really works for us. We don't play that many ODIs anymore - leading up to the World Cup, so it's all about trying different combinations and seeing what our strengths are," skipper Shubman Gill had said ahead of the opener. In that context, Kuldeep's place in the pecking order has come under

scrutiny in recent months. The left-arm wrist spinner featured regularly during the home series against South Africa and New Zealand but has since endured a dip in form. A modest IPL season was followed by an underwhelming outing in the one-off Test, where he struggled for rhythm. He also missed selection in India's recent T20I squads for the Ireland and England tours as well as the Asian Games. But ODIs remain the 31-year-old's strongest format and the team management could consider bringing him in. Kuldeep taking wickets in the middle overs makes India's job a lot easier. Head coach Gautam Gambhir prefers multi-dimensional cricketers, not as much for their bowling, but their ability to chip in with bat, making spin all-rounder Washington Sundar a certainty. (PTI)

Hemlata wants Yastika in playing XI and improvement in fielding



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi

Yastika Bhatia should be utilised in the upcoming games of the Women's T20 World Cup, reckons former India international and chief selector Hemlata Kala who would also want to see an improvement in the fielding department. India began their World Cup campaign with a win over Pakistan. They effectively need to beat either South Africa or Australia from their group to enter the semifinals. In the Pakistan match, India chose to play the big hitting Bharti Fulmali over Bhatia who has a more conventional game. Kala, who served as chief selector from 2016 to 2020, a phase when India reached the finals of 2017 ODI WC and 2020 T20 WC, wanted Bhatia in the playing eleven for game against Netherlands in Leeds on Wednesday. "I would like to see Yastika in the playing eleven. She doesn't have to play one down necessarily. She can play in middle-order also and we should use her, she also did well in series against England," Kala said.

India secure semifinal berth in FIH Nations Cup



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Auckland

The Indian women's hockey team booked its place in the semifinals of the FIH Nations Cup with a hard-fought 2-1 victory over Japan, courtesy goals from captain Salima Tete and Lalremsiami here on Tuesday. The win was India's second in Pool A of the tournament, which serves as a qualifier for next year's FIH Pro League. With six points from two matches, India secured a spot in the last four. India broke the deadlock in the third quarter, with skipper Salima Tete scoring in the 33rd minute after sustained pressure from the forwards. Japan responded quickly, equalising just two minutes later through Ai Hiramitsu. However, Lalremsiami struck the decisive goal in the 49th minute as India held firm against a late Japanese challenge to seal victory. The match was also a

memorable occasion for midfielder Jyoti, who celebrated her 100th senior international appearance. The first half was closely contested, with both teams creating opportunities but failing to find a breakthrough before interval. The game came to life in the third quarter when India took the lead through a penalty-corner variation in the 33rd minute. Nikki Pradhan's deft touch redirected Navneet Kaur's strike perfectly into the path of Salima, who calmly slotted the ball home. Japan hit back immediately, with Hiramitsu converting a penalty corner in the 35th minute to restore parity. With everything to play for in the final quarter, Lalremsiami netted the winner. Sushila Chanu Pukhrambam delivered a precise pass from the edge of the circle into the danger area, where Lalremsiami expertly deflected the ball into the net to hand India a crucial victory.

Cape Verde holds Spain to a surprising 0-0 draw

JAMES ROBSON
Atlanta (US)

So much for a supersized World Cup diluting the quality of soccer's biggest tournament. Tiny Cape Verde, making its debut at the World Cup, pulled off a stunner, holding heavily favored Spain scoreless in a 0-0 draw on Monday. "This means everything for our country," Cape Verde coach Pedro Leitao Brito said. "We have always said that we wanted everybody to see our country, our team and we have shown organization and bravery and this is proof of what our country is about - resilience and to try to overcome hardships." European champion Spain is one of the favorites to win the tournament and was -1200 to beat Cape Verde. But it could not find a way past a 40-year-old goalkeeper and a stubborn defense that had an answer to everything Spain's superstars threw at them. Not even sensational teenager Lamine Yamal, who came in off the bench in the second half, could turn a game that ended with wild and emotional celebrations inside the stadium. "A dream" was how Cape Verde



defender Steven Moreira described it. Veteran goalkeeper Vozinha broke down in tears after the final whistle following his impressive performance to keep Spain at bay. He was the player of the match, pulling off a string of saves at the end of the first half to deny Ferran Torres, Pedri and Aymeric Laporte.

The closest Spain came to finding a breakthrough was when Torres struck the bar shortly before halftime. "We should have won today's match with everything that happened, with all the favorable situations we created, but we lacked fresh-

ness and a clinical edge," said Spain coach Luis de la Fuente, who had warned before the match that Cape Verde could be one of the surprise teams of the World Cup. Spain could have been the victim of an even bigger upset when Dinéy Borges had a late chance to score, but saw his header saved by Spain keeper Unai Simon. Add Cape Verde to Cameroon, Senegal and Saudi Arabia on the list of teams that have pulled off shocking results against soccer's giants in the World Cup. Cameroon beat defending champion Argentina in 1990 and Senegal beat defending champion France in 2002. Four years ago, Saudi Arabia triumphed against Lionel Messi's Argentina, which went on to win the tournament in Qatar. Cape Verde didn't win, but its performance rebuked some of the criticisms that the expansion of the World Cup from 32 teams to 48 would weaken the tournament. The group of islands off Africa's West coast have about 4,000 square meters (about 2.5 miles) of landmass and approximately half a million inhabitants, making Cape Verde third-smallest nation by population to qualify for World Cup. (AP)



Smriti only Indian among TIME's 100 most influential sportspersons

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New York

Cricketer Smriti Mandhana has been named by TIME magazine among this year's 100 most influential people in sports, the only Indian to be featured on the list.

TIME's list of the 100 Most Influential People in Sports 2026 features athletes, coaches, advocates and investors who are "people shaping sports today."

The list, headlined by American bas-

CRICKETER SMRITI MANDHANA IS THE FIRST WOMAN TO SCORE MORE THAN 1,000 ONE-DAY INTERNATIONAL RUNS IN A YEAR

ketball legend LeBron James, includes superstars from the world of sports such as football icon Lionel Messi, Chinese-American skier Eileen Gu, tennis star Carlos Alcaraz, basketball player Victor Wembanyama, legendary golfer Rory McIlroy among others.

The other big names in the list include another football icon Cristiano Ronaldo, South African cricket captain Temba Bavuma, who last year led his team to a historic Test series win in India as well as victory in the World Test Championship (WTC), basketball player for the New York Knicks Jalen Brunson and FIFA president Gianni Infantino.

Mandhana, 29, the vice captain of Indian women's national team, is part of the elite club.

TIME's profile for Mandhana said that the Mumbai-born left-handed opening batter was the "first Indian woman to score a double century in a domestic one-day game, the first to score a century in all three international formats, and is a joint holder of the most international

women's cricket centuries with 17" as it noted that the "records keep tumbling in" for Mandhana. She is also the first woman to score more than 1,000 one-day international runs in a calendar year.

"But Mandhana is proudest of the team honors she is also accumulating. She captained the Royal Challengers Bangalore to the 2024 and 2026 Women's Premier League titles and was vice captain for India's triumph at last year's ICC Women's World Cup, scoring the second-most runs in the tournament," TIME said.

In 2024, she set the record for most international runs across formats by a woman and then beat her own record last year "a feat that contributed to her being crowned BBC Indian Sports-woman of 2025."



Sarpreet becomes first Indian origin player to start FIFA World Cup match



PHILEM DIPAK SINGH
■ New Delhi

New Zealand attacking midfielder Sarpreet Singh became the first footballer of Indian origin to start a FIFA World Cup match in his team's 2-2 draw against Iran in their group match in Los Angeles on Tuesday.

Born in Auckland to Punjabi parents, the 27-year-old Sarpreet made his World Cup debut in the politically-charged match and had a few attempts at the Iranian goal. He was named in the starting XI by head coach Darren Bazeley and played almost the whole match, substituted only in the 90th minute.

New Zealand coach Bazeley kept faith on Sarpreet till the end as Iran came back twice from a goal down to play out a 2-2 draw. Wearing No. 10 jersey, Sarpreet had three shots at the Iranian goal, including one in the 61st minute which, however, could not beat the Iran goalkeeper. He operated in middle of the park in New Zealand's 4-2-3-1 formation.

New Zealand face Egypt in their second Group G match

on June 21 in Vancouver.

Two days back, Nishan Velupillay of Australia, another player of Indian descent, made his World Cup debut in his team's 2-0 win over Türkiye in Vancouver, Canada. The 25-year-old winger was not in the starting line-up and came in from the bench in the 60th minute.

Velupillay was born in Melbourne to an Anglo-Indian mother and a Malaysian father of Sri Lankan Tamil descent.

Before this edition of the FIFA World Cup jointly hosted by the USA, Canada and Mexico, Vikash Dhorasoo of France was the only player of Indian descent to have played a World Cup game. The midfielder, now 52 years old, played two group matches in the 2006 World Cup in Germany where France finished runners-up.

But Dhorasoo, whose forefathers had their roots in Vizianagaram in AP, actually played just a few minutes combined in the two matches. He came in from bench in 84th minute in France's draw against Switzerland in 2006. (PTI)

Shock World Cup call for Renard to coach Tunisia, Sabri Lamouchi fired

GRAHAM DUNBAR ■ New York

It seems no World Cup is complete without Herve Renard and suddenly, somehow, surprisingly he will also be at this one.

The suntanned Frenchman in the trademark open-necked white shirt was hired to coach Tunisia on Tuesday for its final two group games following turmoil.

Tunisia fired coach Sabri Lamouchi early Tuesday after the team was routed 5-1 by Sweden in its opening game on Sunday.

So here comes Herve for his third straight men's World Cup with a third different team. In between times, he also took France to the 2023 Women's World Cup. Renard's latest reprieve comes just two months after he was fired by Saudi Arabia despite leading the kingdom through a shaky qualifying program, where it was given home advantage through final rounds.

His finest World Cup hour was guiding the Saudis to a shocking 2-1 win over eventual champion Argentina and Lionel Messi in their 2022 opener in Qatar.



Between men's World Cups, Renard left Saudi Arabia to coach the France women at their World Cup three years ago and then as the home team at the 2024 Paris Olympics. Both ended in quarterfinals exits.

His first World Cup was in 2018 with Morocco, which impressed in Russia with the core of a team that would reach the semifinals in Qatar. However, Morocco under Renard did not advance to the knockout stage from a tough group with Spain, Portugal and Iran.



Renard has yet to lead a team out of the World Cup group stage which is now his short-term mission that could be all over within 10 days.

His appeal in an emergency to an African soccer federation like Tunisia - now the sixth to hire him - is that he made history winning Africa Cup of Nations titles with two different teams: Zambia in 2012 and Ivory Coast in 2015.

Renard has just four days to get his ideas across before Tunisia faces Japan on Saturday in Monterrey, Mexico. (AP)

Popovic is now guiding the Socceroos



ANNE M. PETERSON
■ Vancouver

Maybe when Australia's World Cup journey is over, Tony Popovic can reflect on his legacy with the Socceroos. Popovic is back at the World Cup as Australia's head coach, 20 years after he played for the Socceroos at the sport's premier tournament.

Australia made a statement in its Group D opener, defeating Turkey 2-0 on Saturday night in Vancouver, British

Columbia. Turkey, making its return to the WC for the first time in 24 years, was widely considered the stronger side going into the match.

"I think, as a coach, you're proud of the group, you're proud of the staff, you're proud that you made so many people happy in the stands. You don't really reflect too much on what it does for you, but I think that's normal for a coach, because you're already thinking, is there anyone that's injured?" Popovic said. (AP)

Scaloni: The whole planet awaits Messi's 200th cap

DAVE SKRETTA ■ Kansas City (US)

Lionel Scaloni tends to be pensive about a lot of things, but especially when the subject turns to another Lionel — a much more famous one, arguably the most famous athlete in the world, and one the Argentina coach gets to see on a daily basis. You see, Scaloni has watched Lionel Messi for much of his life. Both hail from the Argentine province of Santa Fe, Scaloni from the small town of Pujato and Messi from the much larger Rosario. Both of their paths passed through Newell's Old Boys, the historic club that has produced the likes of Maxi Rodriguez, Gabriel Batistuta and the current U.S. coach, Mauricio Pochettino.

So when Scaloni speaks about Messi's legacy, it bears listening.

"Not only the Argentinian population but everybody — the whole planet — wants to see him play," Scaloni explained. "Everybody



wants to see him on the pitch, because he has an effect not only on Argentina fans but supporters all over the world."

Those supporters will likely get their last chance to see Messi wearing his light blue striped shirt at the World Cup beginning

Tuesday night, when the defending champions open their tournament against Algeria at Kansas City's Arrowhead Stadium.

Messi had been dealing with a minor hamstring issue in the lead-up to the World Cup, but he's looked comfortable in the rare chances reporters have witnessed training. And in last week's final tuneup against Iceland at Auburn's Jordan-Hare Stadium, he came into the game as a second-half substitute, scored moments later on a penalty kick and played 20 minutes without any problems.

So barring an unforeseen event, Messi — who has yet to speak publicly since the national team congregated for the World Cup about two weeks ago - will earn his 200th cap during its match against Les Fennecs. "There's nothing negative to say," Scaloni said. "He's always been there, and he's essential for us. He's going to remain that way." (AP)

Czech Cup winner Karvina relegated, fined for match-fixing



JEAN FERNAND KOENA ■ Prague

Czech Cup winner Karvina was expelled from the top division as punishment by the Czech Football Association for its involvement in a major match-fixing scandal.

The association's ethics committee also fined Karvina 10 million Czech koruna (\$480,000) for offering bribes to two referees and two players to influence a league match and two relegation playoff games involving the club in 2024.

Karvina town mayor Jan Wolf offered the bribes and was banned from soccer for 12 years and fined 3 million Czech koruna (\$144,000).

The committee announced its decision late Monday. The club, which is owned by the eastern Czech town, has five days to appeal.

The verdict will likely impact the club's participation in European competitions, with UEFA to have a final say.

By winning the Cup, Karvina advanced directly to the fourth round of qualifying in the Europa League next season. If it were to lose the fixture it would still have a berth in the third-tier Conference League.

In March, the association said a total of 47 individuals and teams, including referees, officials, players, former players and clubs from the top four leagues, were facing a disciplinary investigation for their alleged involvement in the scandal.

WC official says twitch caused gesture resembling white power sign

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Geneva

A World Cup video review official said his hand gesture resembling a white supremacist sign was caused by an involuntary twitch, and a FIFA committee concluded the Australian didn't breach the sport's disciplinary code.

FIFA's discrimination monitor had called for Shaun Evans to be removed from the tournament.

Evans worked Germany's opening 7-1 win over Curacao on Sunday as an assistant to the video assistant referee, based at the World Cup broadcast center in Dallas. When the official broadcast cut before the game to show the video review officials, Evans made an "OK" symbol with his right hand in front of his right leg. "I did not intentionally make a hand gesture or symbol to communicate a message, affiliation, game or belief of any kind," Evans said in a statement released



Monday by FIFA. "The only explanation I can offer is that the movement was an involuntary, subconscious twitch and I was unaware I had done it at the time. Images taken later during the match showed that I repeated this movement many times while holding a pen between my fingers."